

A woman with blonde hair styled in a voluminous, messy updo is lying on her back on a deep purple, draped fabric. She is wearing a strapless, sequined dress with a black and white checkered pattern. She has large, ornate silver earrings and is looking directly at the camera with a slight smile. Her hands are resting near her head and neck.

**arnica
butler**

**jo's
secrets**

JO'S SECRETS
A Romantic Wife Sharing Novel
By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

“The Laughing Goat?” Nate said, turning the wheel and peering out from under the sun visor to make sure he was reading the signs correctly.

Jo was blankly looking out her window, lost in her own thoughts.

“Hon?” he asked, putting a hand on her knee.

Jo snapped her attention to the windshield, looking ahead, squinting. Making, in Nate’s opinion, a big show of being interested in his question, to cover up the fact that she had been miles away. Whenever she pretended to have been paying attention, she blinked more than usual, and made a thin-lined grimace out of her mouth. It was an expression she never wore in response to anything else.

But he no sooner had these negative thoughts than he dismissed them: these were tough times, and he should be cutting his wife a break. He had to stop thinking only of himself, and his feelings. Jo, self-possessed and cucumber-cool as she was, had every right to be having trouble with... this.

“Uh, yeah,” she said, in a lilting voice that, like her grimace, was only for this particular situation. “Laughing Goat. I don’t know. This is all... none of this was here when I was here. It’s like, a completely different place.”

There was a silence while she looked out of the passenger window theatrically. It was almost like she was starring in a play, and the stage directions were: *Jo looks wistfully out the window at her old town.*

“So... you want to go there?” he asked, slowing the car and braking his impatience as well.

“I don’t know,” Jo snapped, obviously lost in thought again and irritated to be shaken out of it. “I mean... sorry. I don’t know. I guess. It’s... sounds kind of hipster, doesn’t it?”

She was trying to make up for being snappy with that last bit. She was smiling, pushing her long bangs from her forehead, tipping her head against her hand with her elbow on the car door. “What’s their logo look like?”

She looked behind them, appraised the sign swinging from the porch of The Laughing Goat, and said: “Huh,” with a shrug.

Not bad, the shrug meant.

“Maybe Sayville is just a nice place to live now,” Nate suggested, and he couldn’t keep his own desperate hope – that Sayville was, in fact, a nice place to live now – from cracking through his voice.

Sayville, Georgia, a stone’s throw from Tennessee, was a town surrounded by beautiful landscapes and full of dark shadows everywhere. There were signs that Sayville was being infused with a little bit of money, but an air of decay and hopelessness still hung about the place. There was a Southernness to it that made it all the more depressing, but Nate supposed that was because he was not from the South: *everything* in the South seemed like it was either dangerous or tragic to him.

But it wasn’t just the town. There was the matter of his wife, and the change coming over her, like something was seeping back into her, the way the water seeped into the wood-framed houses.

He had turned the car around, because he was hungry, and there was not much left of Sayville’s three blocks of half-shuttered downtown. This was the kind of place that closed everything but antique shops on Sundays, and since he had never lived anywhere but a city – his high school had more students than the whole of Lee County – he found himself extremely agitated by the lack of restaurants.

“Oh, are we going there?” Jo said, but not like she really even wanted to ask, or like she cared about the answer. She was looking out the window again.

They rolled right up to the curb next to the restaurant, and Nate leaned on the steering wheel, searching for “No Parking” signs.

Jo was already stepping out of the car. “There’s no rules about parking,” she muttered.

There’s no rules.

It wasn’t a big deal. He wasn’t a Grammar Nazi. This was the kind of speech-level mistake that he knew Jo would never *write*. But in the twelve years he had known her, it had also been the kind of thing he would have bet large sums of money on never hearing her *say*.

The inside of The Laughing Goat was unexpectedly pleasant. Dark green billiards tables matched dark green lamps, brown leather booths and dark wood completed the classic pub appearance. Things looked new, taken care of, and – and this was crucial – not trashy at all.

“Not bad,” Jo said, removing her sunglasses.

Not bad – but, as was usual in Sayville, customer service was on more of a geological timescale. No one appeared behind the bar, or from the kitchen, and two other patrons were stirring melted ice water in empty glasses amid the remnants of a very large meal that no one had yet bothered to clear.

But there was air conditioning, which was a big bonus. It was not very good – probably half as much as was actually required to drain the Georgia air of water and heat – but it was something.

Jo plopped into a booth, not seeming to notice the lack of customer service at all. Jo, in fact, had acquired a monumental level of patience – not typical of her at all – since they crossed the Mason-Dixon line.

And patience, it seemed, was what was required.

A waitress sauntered out of the kitchen, surveyed the dining room, crossed over to the messy table, picked up half of the dishes, and very s-l-o-w-l-y said:

“Can I get y’all anythin’ else?”

It was another ten minutes, during which time the waitress disappeared again, and the patrons continued sitting, and the air conditioning continued huffing as hard as it could, before she reappeared and – slowly again – took their drink order.

“I’ll have tea,” Jo said.

“What kind of tea is it?” Nate asked.

He already knew the answer, because there was only one kind of tea served in Sayville and it was technically cold syrup with a tea flavor, but he enjoyed asking the question because he enjoyed the fact that it made everyone screw their eyes up in confusion. It really hadn’t been his thing to fuck with people in this way since his adolescence, but he couldn’t help himself.

Jo shot daggers at him, while the waitress scrunched her eyes together in an attempt to fathom the question.

“It’s... tea,” she said finally.

“It’s sweet tea, darlin’” Jo said, in an extra-thick drawl. Her eyes glinted at Nate, and he backed down. The waitress looked from one to the other, unsure of what to say.

“I’ll have a beer,” Nate said, smiling.

She looked at him, and while it would have been fun to see how long she would have done that, he could feel Jo glaring at the side of his face.

“What kind do you have?” Nate prompted her.

“Kinda what?” the waitress said.

“Kind of beer,” Nate said patiently. “What kinds of beer do you have?”

“Uh... we got... Coors and then some kinda special one, it’s...”

“Have that one,” Jo said to Nate, and her voice was icy.

“I’ll have that one,” Nate said, smiling broadly at the waitress.

The waitress was now confused, so a long beat passed before she took a deep breath and asked, very genuinely: “You want me to find out what it is?”

He smiled with closed lips. “That’s quite all right,” he said grandly. “I’m sure it’ll be good.”

“Bless her heart,” Jo said, after she’d disappeared.

There was another one. “*Bless your heart.*” Jo had never blessed so much as a sneezing child in her life, and now she was walking around Georgia like she wanted to be Pope.

“*Bless your heart,*” though, seemed to be less of a benediction than a polite way to be bitchy, and Nate didn’t care to explore it in any more depth. Here, he took it to mean that Jo thought the waitress was a little slow. Even for Sayville, which was some feat.

“So there’s no way to get, say, actual tea here. Anywhere,” Nate said, trying to make conversation.

Jo had her phone out and was scrolling through her messages. “Sweet tea *is* actual tea, we’ve been over this.”

“No hot tea. Anywhere. No unsweetened tea. Anywhere,” Nate pressed, only half-joking. What kind of demented people didn’t understand that you could make tea without sugar?

Jo looked up from her phone and squinted at him, as though trying to see if he were the wrong person. “You don’t *drink* tea,” she said.

“I like iced tea,” Nate said, defensively. “Just not... half mixed with corn syrup.”

Jo sighed, her eyes back on her phone. They’d had the tea conversation ten times and she was getting bored with it. “Signal’s shit here.”

The waitress had emerged from behind the bar with their drinks. She set Jo’s hideous iced tea in front of her, and then his beer. “Just one moment,” she said. “Be right back with your menus.”

It was this kind of thing that was driving him to madness. Making a separate trip for a menu. They'd be lucky if they finished eating here before the end of the week.

Jo sighed at her phone and picked up her tea. "That guy's supposedly coming from Houston but he hasn't said when he's gettin' here."

Nate took a sip of his beer. "Thought people didn't care about that stuff so much here."

Jo set her phone down, screen down, and folded her hands, like she was about to tell him some very bad news. "This is horses," she told him airily.

She didn't roll her eyes, but that was only because eye rolling was not something that New Jo did.

The front door opened, a wave of heat rolled through, and a thin woman in a tight-fitting dark-gray t-shirt and jeans hurried toward the kitchen. "Sorry I'm late but them hogs of the Wardles up on 20 were all over the place," she said, disappearing through the door. Except it sounded like, "Sahruh ahm leht buht them hawgs uvthuh wuhrduhls uhp awln twehnnuh wuhr uhl ovuh thuh dayum ruhd."

Nate had caught sight of a shapely ass in the jeans out of the corner of his eye. Not that he was really looking, because his own wife had a very nice bottom that had turned more than a few heads. He kept his eyes on Jo. "So horses, people take seriously around here," he said, and gave a short nod as though making a note of it.

Jo waved a hand in the direction of nothing in particular, opened her mouth like she was going to say something, and then stopped herself. She lifted her tea to her lips. "Horses," she declared, "are big money." She took a sip of her tea.

Nate hurried to put the beer to his lips and stop himself from saying anything to that one.

Horses might be big money, but Seymore Farms certainly hadn't figured out how to make any of it. The farm was dilapidated, hanging on by a thread in every sense of the word, and deep in the red. Deep – like, more money than Nate could fathom – deep. And certainly more than they could get from selling it.

He looked at his wife over the rim of his beer glass. Her hair was pulled back in a ponytail, her bangs loose, her creamy skin just flushed enough with sun that she would start getting freckles soon and begin

complaining about them. Her jeans, he had seen, had a streak of dirt on the left calf, and her appearance was generally jarring if you were used to seeing Jo as she was – or had been – in a smart, expensive gray or black suit, an attention-grabbing silk blouse, and pumps that probably cost more than this bar.

Her current footwear had been purchased at a farm supply store and had steel-toed boots.

The no-nonsense marketing executive Jo Bentley was still there: Jo took absolutely no shit from anyone on the phone, and woe the creditor who crossed the line with her. She had thrown herself into saving the farm and recuperating at least her parents' debts, and she was doing it with the same winning attitude she did everything.

Just... in rolled-up sleeves and muddy boots.

And while wrangling unbroken horses.

It was a side of Jo he had never imagined being there. Of course he had known she'd grown up on a farm, and that she was from Georgia – but when he had met her, at university, she had been in a graphic design program, with funky dark hair and torn jeans, smoking cigarettes and cracking dry jokes. After she'd graduated and gone into marketing, her transition from funky grad nonconformist to high-powered executive had been gradual enough that it hadn't disturbed him.

But this?

While he contemplated his wife, the waitresses had emerged from the kitchen and were exchanging banter over the bartop, evidently changing out shifts. Nate listened to see if anyone had thought to bring them a menu, but could make no sense of what they were saying.

So he didn't really think much of it concerning him when one of the waitresses began yelling: "TJ, TJ? It is! That there is Tabitha Seymore if I'm a day old. Cassie git back in here."

And then she was standing next to their table – still no menus, Nate noted – with her hands on her hips, shrieking:

"Tabitha Seymore, you been gone so long I thought you were dead." She jerked her head in the direction of the men seated in the booth near the kitchen, who Nate had forgotten were still there and alive. "Gus, you been sittin' here all along and you hadn't seen that TJ Seymore's sittin' right here in my bar?"

She turned back to Jo. And now Nate also turned his attention on his wife.

The man who was Gus grunted. “Hot damn it is,” he squeezed from his belly.

Jo’s face was doing something very strange at this point, and it was the kind of thing Nate had never seen her do, so it took him a moment to realize that she was *flustered*.

“Mandy Knight,” she said, her voice low and flat.

“It’s Mandy *Poole* now,” Mandy said, her emphasis on “Poole” a peculiar mixture of pride and sarcasm. “I married that Chase Poole ‘bout the time you left town. Divorced him since then but I’m too lazy to change my name back, you know how they are down there.”

“Down there,” Nate knew, was the seat of the county – a town not much larger than Sayville in his view – referred to in Sayville with all fluctuating disdain and reverence typically directed at places like New York City.

Jo had been Jo as long as Nate had known her. Of course he had known her last name was Seymore, and of course he had known that her *real* first name was Tabitha. Her parents had called her “Cat” when they had come – the only time they had come to Chicago – to their wedding. At the time, he hadn’t thought much of it; it had seemed like a nickname (what was less logical about “cat” than “muffin” or “honey” or “sweet pea?”) and he hadn’t even asked about it.

Since their recent move to Sayville, a veritable heap of nicknames had emerged. But it was clear: in Sayville, Georgia, no one called Jo “Jo.” She was TJ Seymore, or Tabby-Cat, or Tibby, or *Tabitha Josephine Seymore!* for emphasis.

But never Jo.

And Jo was the woman he had married. Jo was a girl from graphic design who cut her own hair and smoked cigarettes by the door of Thompson Hall, with no makeup and a dark sense of humor, which she wore as well as a well-tied scarf. Jo was the girl who paid attention to him, way above his class, and who had been not only the coolest girl, the darkest girl, the girl with the most secrets and the best laugh, but the most talented and smartest girl. Jo was the sultry, cigarette-smoking bad girl who landed a high-paying corporate job and started paying \$500 for haircuts because she could. Jo was the kind of woman who sat at the head of a table and gave

you “the look.” Jo was the kind of woman who did not have problems with sexual harassment or career advancement, in spite of being extremely attractive. Because Jo, it was pretty clear, would probably chop your dick off if you got wise.

Jo was also fun, in a stratospherically smart kind of way. He didn’t just love Jo, he actually really *liked* her. He might even have still been friends with her if she wasn’t his wife, and there were an alternate universe in which he wasn’t madly in love with her. He felt a lot of men couldn’t say that about their wives.

But Tabitha...

Tabitha Josephine Seymore was someone *else*.

Tibby was also someone else.

And now, he thought with a sinking feeling, he was about to find out who TJ was.

“Chase Poole,” Jo was saying, bringing him back to reality because she was leaning toward him, her Guinness-dark eyes on his, and her voice was low and creamy. “Bless his heart.”

Bleyuhs hus hahrt.

There was a certain erotic magic to Jo’s new accent, he had to admit. She had never rid herself completely of it, but enough time up “nuhwuhth” had sharpened her vowels to a more standardized version of English – one in which “uh” was not the only vowel sound. She had dropped all of the expressions, and spoke as fast as anyone he knew.

Here in Sayville, she sounded like someone had filled her throat with honey. Everything came out slow, sultry, and smoothed down.

It was sexy, but also a little disturbing.

Occasionally, he didn’t understand her.

While he was thinking, the waitress, Mandy, had gone, and Jo had acquired a menu. She held it up in front of her face, scanned it quickly, and let it fall forward. She wrinkled her nose and then rubbed it, sniffing at the same time. “You know, honey, I think actually we better just have these drinks and head back. I’m gettin’ worried about this horse guy.”

Her eyes were moving around the bar, though. She was thinking about something else.

Nate’s curiosity was piqued.

“I’m really hungry,” he complained.

Mandy was coming back through the door, nothing in her hands, calling back into the kitchen as she walked out of the doors.

“Can’t *git* good help ‘round here for nothin’. You folks know what you want?”

“You know, I think we just have to run on home?” Jo said quickly. “I forgot all about a -”

“You have any hamburgers?” Nate interjected. “I could eat a whole horse.”

That last line made Jo shoot him a look, because she knew it was thrown in to make fun of the folksy banter in Sayville.

Mandy did not get the joke. She brightened and took out a notepad. “I can do you a great burger, that’s the one thing Curtis here can cook right.” She glanced down at Jo. “You remember Curtis Brown.”

There was a moment of silence.

Mandy brightened. “Don’t you worry, I’ll get it out in ten minutes and you can take it home. Meantime, we can have a nice chat. You want anything?”

Jo shook her head, smiling tensely.

Mandy looked her up and down over the edge of the notepad. “You’re still as built as a brick house, TJ Seymore. Be right back.”

Jo glared at Nate.

He glared back, annoyed very suddenly by Jo’s increasingly strange behavior. They were only in this godforsaken backwater of Georgia because of *her*; she could have just as easily started over anywhere, and she knew that. She’d even gotten a job offer in Chicago, from a headhunter she hadn’t even sought out. She’d received the offer the day they arrived in Georgia with the moving van.

Not that she had mentioned it to him: he had overheard her on the phone about it.

They had been up on that farm for weeks without going into town. At first he had liked it, but it grew boring pretty fast for a city-boy like him. His writer’s dreams of locking himself in an attic room looking out over pastures and forest were attained. They were boring as hell, and he had writer’s block, and he wanted to see some buildings and some people.

But Jo ran the errands. Jo never wanted to eat at a restaurant. “There aren’t any open anyway, this time of year,” she had objected.

And now this: making an excuse to leave and go back to the farm when they were having the first conversation they'd had with someone besides her father, and, for Nate, the occasional grunt from the farm help she had hired.

"I'm hungry," he said testily.

"There's plenty to eat -"

Nate sighed. "I want to be *out*," he said. "Look... why don't you go on back to the farm, handle the horse stuff, and come back for me later? I'm sick of that place."

Jo raised an eyebrow. "And just what will you do all that time in Sayville, Georgia?"

Nate's cock thickened a little. That accent was sexy, however weird it might be.

He looked around the restaurant and shrugged. "Dunno. Thought I'd eat my burger, chat with Mandy, maybe walk around and look at antiques or something."

The last bit was a joke.

When he looked back at Jo, her face had a panic-stricken layer beneath her smile.

"Talk to Mandy, huh? You know she's never left this town probably. If you wanna talk about John Deere products, though..."

Nate brought his beer to his mouth. "I might ask her about you," he said, almost winking. "You know, back in the day."

He took a sip of his beer and watched his wife.

Jo was a cool customer – she couldn't *not* be. She had worked in one of the most cutthroat businesses in the world, in one of the most cutthroat cities for it, and one big part of her job was staying cool under pressure. Even when an ad campaign backfired, even when someone might be losing a million dollars for saying the wrong word.

But Jo had a few tells for when she became stressed; a few hairline fractures in her flawless veneer. Her skin, creamy white, with a yellow undertone, went pale like porcelain. Her jawline would bulge, because she clenched her teeth. And her eyes would narrow.

Not a lot, just a little.

It wasn't the first time Jo had had this reaction in Georgia. And now he was more curious than ever. It was pretty clear she didn't want him talking to Mandy Poole about old times.

Just like she hadn't wanted him asking any of the help she'd hired, who all seemed to go way back with her, about old times.

And that was just the sort of thing that made Nate want, very much, to ask about old times.

Jo reached for a coaster, dropping her eyes, one arm crossed across her chest, very clearly thinking about her options.

She sighed. "Oh God," she said. "I'm hungry too." She lifted her gaze to meet his eyes, playfully and a little viciously. "*Ah could eat me up a whole damn horse.* I guess I'll stay."

Nate smiled with closed lips. "What about the horse guy?"

She set her tea on the coaster and lined it up in the exact center – and when Jo did this, there was little doubt that she found the exact center, as in, on an atomic level. She cleared her throat. "You're right. He's probably gonna be late and I'll miss lunch for no earthly reason?"

Her voice had the queer cadence of the South, where certain sentences ended up sounding like questions.

Mandy was returning, and she came toward them so fast that Jo had no choice but to scoot over. She slapped her notepad on the table and turned toward Jo with eyes so hungry she almost looked like a wolf. "Now then. Tell me what you been don' up there, your momma told me you were livin' in Chicago and you married yourself a Yankee..." she looked over at Nate, who raised his beer in a mock cheers, which was his new tactic whenever someone called him a Yankee, which apparently people still actually did in places like Sayville. They also referred to the Civil War as Thu Wuh (which was shorthand for Thuh Wu-wah Of Nahthuhn Uhgreshun," a phrase that evidently had to be drawn out for a full minute and followed by a moment of silence and grim faces.)

It was crazy to him, but he found it fascinating.

"I did," Jo told her. "This is my Yankee and we did live in Chicago a good long time."

"And you got no kids," Mandy said. "What was it you were doin'? Marketing?"

"That's right. I worked for Brand."

"Never heard of it but hear your daddy tell it you were rollin' in dough. And what now, you here to save the farm?"

"It's not possible," Nate said, grimly. It was out of his mouth before he had time to think, and he instantly regretted it.

Both women turned to give the stink eye. They paused long enough to make Nate uncomfortable, and he felt sure his heart was about to get blessed, but they returned to talking.

“It’s in bad shape,” Jo said, playing with the coaster again. “But I’m hopin’ we can turn it around.”

Mandy nodded. “And your daddy?”

Jo shook her head, which evidently was enough for Mandy.

Then she hit Jo with her notepad. “Now you’re here, then you gotta come to the Skinkles for Homecoming! That’s the perfect homecoming for the homeco-”

“Oh dammit!” Jo yelled, just a tiny fraction of a second before her arm jutted out and tipped over her tea.

The liquid went straight toward Mandy, who jumped out of the way and moved like a vampire to get a cloth and mop it up. “You ain’t even drinkin’ yet,” Mandy drawled, smiling, as she mopped up the spill. “Outta practice or what, girl?”

Nate stared at Jo, who began to focus so entirely on mopping up the spilled tea that it became ludicrous. Nate snapped his fingers in front of her face.

“You all right?” Mandy asked her.

Jo gave a wane smile. “I think... it’s the heat. I feel a little sick, actually. Honey, you don’t mind gettin that burger to go after all, do you?”

Of course not. Of course he didn’t.

Nate got up from the booth, pulling his wallet from his back pocket. ““You ring me up, please Mandy?”

*

“What the hell was that?” Nate asked, as soon as Jo closed the car door behind her.

Jo reached over and started the car, then turned the air conditioning on high. “Just this heat,” she said, rubbing the back of her neck.

Nate looked out the windshield. “Jo,” he said. “You’ve been acting really weird since we got here.”

He looked at his own reflection in the rearview mirror. Just walking from The Laughing Goat, after promising Mandy several times that they would go to the Skinkles’ party – whatever that was – had made his skin

wet with unevaporated humidity and he had turned a few shades redder than his usual olive-toned, half-Italian perma-tan, as Jo called it.

Jo, on the other hand, looked like she had stepped out of makeup for a work-wear catalog: other than a tiny droplet of sweat on her chest, she looked about as sick as an Olympic athlete.

“What are you *talking about*?” Nate said.

“What are *you* talking about?” Jo snapped, looking at him. She put her arm forward to indicate they should drive on.

Nate pulled into the street, headed back in the direction of their farm. Well, the in-laws’ farm still, technically. Not that they’d want to own it. It was over a million in debt if you took for granted that you could sell it all at the highest price.

Which you couldn’t.

They drove for a while in silence.

“I am talking about,” Nate said, after a while, “this kind of weird shit you’ve been doing ever since we got here.”

Jo leaned her head back. “What ‘weird’ stuff?” she asked, her tone exasperated.

This was another thing. Jo was an f-bombing, shit-slinging, asshole-shouting, sailor-level cusser. Now she said things like “don’t get ugly,” when the swearwords came out of Nate’s mouth.

Seriously.

“You trying to tell me you just knocked over that glass? On accident?”

Jo rolled her head to face him and sneered. “What is that supposed to mean, exactly?”

“Did you?”

She rolled her head back. “I’m not even gonna dignify that with a response.”

Uhm naht evuhn gunnuh dignuhfuh thuht with uh response.

“Okay, Scarlett O’Hara.”

Jo shook her head. “Lord.”

Another silence. It was a long, long way out of town to the farm, down a dirt road and then down another long access road lined by huge trees. Nate still had trouble fighting down the worry about what the roads would be like in winter – which would never come here, but he found it hard to really believe.

“What was your friend about to say, right before you spilled your tea?” Nate asked, after a while.

“Nathan, honestly,” Jo said, in a tone of voice that made him know he shouldn’t ask any more questions.

There had been so many moments like the one at The Laughing Goat: moments he couldn’t quite put his finger on, or even point the finger of blame directly at Jo (what was he accusing her of, anyway?) - but moments, nonetheless, in which she seemed to have behaved very strangely. Like she wanted to cover something up, keep something buried.

But what was it?

Mandy’s half-finished sentence lingered in his mind, on repeat like a broken record, her Southern drawl melodic as it played back-to-back:

A perfect homecoming for the homeco-

CHAPTER 2

Nate stared through the large attic window into the emerald pastures, bordered in the distance by a peach grove, and then forced himself to look back at his computer screen.

From this room, where he had installed himself to get some writing done at long last, the daily activity at Seymore farms could not be heard or really seen. The roof of the large house, which extended to his left and in front of his view, blocked the view of the stables and the working area of the farm, the pathways to the barns and garages, the entrance. All he could see were the large pastures, and occasionally, the semi-feral horses that roamed them.

At first, this had seemed like the perfect situation. Jo's mother had passed away and her father had debilitating dementia. He had been bed-ridden in his own wing of the house with a home nurse until he could be moved to an ultra-expensive nursing home. They had come here because Jo had lost her job just weeks before her mother passed away, and the idea had been to stay only to liquidate the family farm. He would finally work on a book, he could still do some editing as a freelancer so he could return to publishing when they moved home, and Jo would have the time to take care of her dad's affairs.

The only problem is that, while Seymore Farms was a sprawling property of emerald fields dotted with million-dollar horses, replete with stables and what was practically a mansion – it had gone to seed. And it was in debt. So far in debt that they could not liquidate it without losing millions, and then her father would be destitute.

Jo had not even blinked when the accountant had given them the news. "Well," she had said practically, leaving the offices. "I suppose we'll just have to turn it around."

It would be fun, they had decided. It was a bad situation, but Jo could handle it. She had been raised on that farm, she knew horses, she knew the business, and she knew *business*. She would rebuild the family empire, and in the meantime, Nate could work on his book. They sold their condo in Chicago, they could live there for free, everything would eventually be

returned to their coffers through inheritance – Jo was an only child – and besides, it was the right thing to do.

Jo had said this last bit with such an undertone of Southern honor, that Nate had been swept up in the romanticism of it all. Jo *was* the smartest person he knew. She could re-brand anything, and if she really did know horses, well... great. He didn't, but all he had to do was see her once (for the first time) coaxing a wild stallion over to a vet to know she *really* knew what she was doing.

All of these facts: that her family had a horse farm, that she had grown up on it, that she knew the business and detested it (it was unethical as hell, she had told him) – this had all been known to Nate long ago. But it had been like a distant dream, some other world that Jo had once been a part of and was not a part of now. She was not Southern in any sense of the word. She was a city girl with a vague, unplaceable trace of an accent – the kind of thing that could pass for rural Illinois. She worked in a high-rise and hailed cabs.

But now, in the humidity and the dank Southern air, cicadas blaring all night instead of horns, the scent of hay and horses on her skin all the time, and Nate locked away in a (very nice) attic all day, it was much more real than he really... wanted it to be.

He also had writer's block.

He wasn't sure how it had started.

Writer's block had definitely been part of the impetus. Almost every writer's forum and "How-To" guide suggested that if you suffered from writer's block, writing *anything* would help you recover. Start with something in your immediate vicinity. Describe it to death. Build a fictitious story around it. Just get the juices flowing.

He had started by describing the peach grove. The pretty lines of it against the setting sun. The way the light caught the hay, the dark brown of the horse that so resembled his wife's eyes.

A horse – one of the "most spirited" on the farm, an American Quarter Horse bred for racing who was going to fetch a lot of money, had wandered into the scene. Nate had written a description of the horse, but the writer's block had remained. Every sentence had to be wrung from his head like water from a dry sponge.

Then, Caleb Knight had wandered into the scene, moving slowly toward the horse.

Caleb was about twenty, and had the strong, lean build of a high-school athlete and a farm boy. His skin was tanned, his face was pretty, his accent was charming. He wore a smug grin on his face, the kind that good-looking high school football heroes who got laid any time they wanted have. He was polite as pie, to coin an expression people actually used around here.

Polite as *pie*.

And he worked all day with Mrs. Tabitha Josephine Seymore Bentley.

Jo came into the scene a few minutes later, the two of them standing away from the horse, engaging in a dance with the animal that required patience and fearlessness, a knowledge of animals that Nate knew he would never possess.

Jo Bentley. Or TJ Seymore, as some would have it. Tall at 5' 10," built of good proportions, a strong, flat stomach and the wild core strength of an acrobat or a dancer. She was the kind of girl who walked and stood erect, with her shoulders high and her neck extended, looking not unnatural or forced, but regal. Even when she had been trying to look casual and sloppy, smoking cigarettes with the graphic design crowd with her ragged haircuts and her torn jeans, she didn't know how to slouch. Wherever she went, Jo seemed slightly out-of-place for that reason.

Jo was wearing jeans and a blue shirt. From the attic Nate could not make out the way they hugged her round, toned thighs, but he wrote about it. He had no idea if her skin was covered in a light sheen of sweat, sweet-smelling and mingling with her lavender deodorant, the only thing she wore. He also didn't know if, despite the heat, her pink nipples had hardened beneath her shirt, which was all that she wore because she had taken off her bra a while ago in the heat of the barn.

What he wrote next was a product of his writer's block, but also a product of one of his savored pastimes: erotic literature.

He had begun reading erotica a long time ago, skipping through his mother's books by Jackie Collins for the really seedy parts. When the internet had bloomed into an ecosystem of free porn, he had done what any warm-blooded male would do, and watched a ton of it.

But he kept returning to the written erotica. Maybe because it stimulated the same thrill of leafing through the pages of the books in the

study, not wanting to get caught. Maybe because that was the first way he'd consumed his erotic entertainment.

Maybe because the thrill he enjoyed was a little different. Less visual, and more psychological.

Reflecting back on the stories that had particularly thrilled him when he was an adolescent, he could see that he had always been pulled toward the erotica he eventually found and began to consume avidly: hotwife and cuckold literature. He had enjoyed the same idea even in non-erotic literature from other genres he loved. Like espionage novels by John Le Carre: he had savored the particular pain that George Smiley endured when his wife Ann ran off with her lovers. He had enjoyed envisioning the details of *that* story, drawing it out with his own imagination, more than the spy story itself.

He had discovered that, while he was a bit of a dork and in small company, he was not alone. Someone had even written fan fiction to that effect. From that fan fiction he had gone down a rabbit-hole to the twistedly painful delights of cuckold erotica. And then to hotwife erotica (though he found the idea a little unbelievable, even if there was evidence of it really existing all around him).

He had never told Jo about his habit, which he felt was just fine. They shared almost everything, but Jo herself had said on many occasions that she felt everyone was entitled to their fantasies and thoughts that they kept secret.

He enjoyed thinking about Jo telling him that. He enjoyed thinking about Jo's secret fantasies and thoughts, and he more than often imagined them as thoughts that betrayed him, or were unfaithful in some way. The effect of thinking those dark thoughts was as intoxicating as liquor, as erotic as her actual presence.

So when, in the attic of Seymore Farms, where the air conditioner struggled to keep the temperature below 75, he tried to break his writer's block by writing about the scene in front of him, and Caleb and Jo wandered into the field together, it was no wonder that he ended up writing what he wrote.

CHAPTER 3

The boy had just wrangled the stallion by himself, and gotten him into the trailer with minimal help from the other farmhands. He'd built up a sweat doing it. The white t-shirt he wore was soaked through to his skin, but not in the way old men sweat, from the pits with a tired exertion. His sweat was like the sweat of a horse, a layer from all of his body, just enough to keep him cool.

He wore a white t-shirt every day. Dry, they fit him just perfectly, rounding slightly where his solid pecs protruded, flat as an ironing board at his abdomen. When they were damp, like his shirt was now, it clung to the solid curves of his muscles, and the dark tan of his skin showed through.

He was the kind of boy who did not take off his shirt in front of a lady: no respectable Sayville boy would do that, especially if his boss was a woman. But he did lift the bottom of the shirt, when he thought she wasn't looking, and wipe his face. His lean abs, not rippled like a bodybuilder's but solid like an athlete's, burned in the corner of her eye.

She kept looking at the paperwork, seeing nothing. He was slightly out of breath – more from the heat than anything else.

Samantha pushed her bangs from her face and re-read the form for the hundredth time.

"Miss Brighton?" he asked.

She looked up at him, making every effort to keep the features of her face from revealing her thoughts, or her physical state. Deep in her abdomen, almost in her pelvis, a cool excitement was pooling, and between her legs, she could feel that her underwear was damp.

And that had everything to do with Jake.

She knew she should correct him: it was Mrs. Brighton. She was married, and had been for twelve years. Her husband Andy was in the house, and he was working. Where they were standing they could not be seen from anywhere he was likely to be looking, but he could come out at any moment.

"You all right?" he asked her, when she said nothing. His eyes were narrowed against the sun, his face glistening with light sweat, his features still retaining some boyishness even though he was obviously a man.

“Ma’m?” he persisted, and then came walking toward her, because she was still saying nothing. “Maybe you need to go inside, the heat is somethin’ awful out here.”

His hand was on her clipboard, and then his other hand was on her wrist. She didn’t have a problem from the heat, and she knew that, and yet she played along, letting him believe she did. She wiped her forehead, let him nudge her in the direction of the garage and small room downstairs that served as an office of sorts.

He told her to sit down, so she did, and she watched him as he got her a bottle of water from the fridge. She could have told him she was fine, because she was: she had grown up in this heat and been far worse off than she was at this moment. The flush on her face wasn’t from the heat.

He opened the bottle for her and handed it to her. Their fingertips touched as she took it from him. “Thank you,” she said, and brought the water to her lips.

“Take slow sips,” he told her. He didn’t mean anything by it except that, but the hint of command in his voice, the double entendre that only she could get from “slow sips,” sent another finger of desire through her, from her clit to the low center of her abdomen.

She tried hard to think about Andy as their eyes met and a few too many beats of silence passed between them. It was too long to be looking at a guy almost half her age, too long for him to be looking at his boss – like that.

She could see the moment when he just got it. He was probably the kind of guy who never gave an older woman any thought. It didn’t take long to suss out that Jake Lee was every girl in Sayville’s dream, so he had his pick of any of the girls he wanted. But she saw the interest kindle in that moment, like a light in the back of his eyes, and she could almost see him scheming as he looked at her.

She cleared her throat to break the tension. “Musta gotten too used to the cold up there all these years.”

As if Chicago was never this hot. But a guy like Jake Lee wouldn’t know that. He smiled. “Turned into a Yankee,” he said.

And his voice was lower, more like a sultry growl. Her stomach felt cool, and her blood began to race. She gave him a smile and a shake of her head.

“Nah,” he added. “That’d never happen to a true Southern girl like yourself.”

Somehow, he was standing closer, and she had let him get that close, watching her the whole time. A shift had occurred in the office, a very small but palpable shift. She was no longer in control of the conversation, no longer the leader. He was now taking it where he wanted it to go.

And she was letting him. The air conditioner rattled, sounding like it was on its final minutes of life. The wooden shutters were half-closed, and the windows so dirty that no one could see inside. They both knew where everyone was: the horse was loaded in an expensive trailer, the driver was Charlie Pauls and he was a big man who would never climb out of an air-conditioned cab to see what the hold-up was. The other hands had gone out for lunch in town.

They were alone, and somehow things had become inappropriate, and they both knew it, but she could tell it would have to be her to shut it down. It wasn’t like she didn’t know how to do that; she was a gorgeous blonde whom men hit on all the time.

But not like this. Not so young, not so hot. Not in the office of her daddy’s old house. Not by moving slowly toward her, holding her eyes steady, making her as hot as she was fascinated. He stopped just inches away from her knees, let his gaze burn into her for her another moment, and then put the back of his hand against her forehead.

His skin was hot to the touch, and it sent an electric ripple through her that she had a hard time suppressing.

“Seem cool as a cucumber now,” he said. “Feelin’ any better?”

She wasn’t sure what happened. Her fingers sought out the cap to the bottle, trying to put it on, while she looked at him. She started to stand at the same time, in an effort to rearrange the position they were in, because something about it felt... well, good, but wrong.

She ended up standing, right into him, and dropping the bottle. His shirt had cooled and dried, now it was like laundry left out too short a time on a cool day. She smelled him – he smelled of sweat and hay, but it wasn’t a foul smell. His shoulder was level with her eye, because he was a big boy – man – and towered over her even though she was tall.

And then, just like that, they were kissing.

His lips were soft and warm. He wasn’t a good kisser, she thought, but it was more inexperience than inability. Andy and her marriage flew

through her head: she had just cheated on her husband, she was cheating on her husband right now.

It was only a kiss, she remembered thinking. Even as she let her teeth close slightly on his lower lip, destroying any pathway to being an inactive participant. They were close now, and she could feel the heat of his body, the hardness of it, the coiled energy of a young man. She could also feel, against her hip bone, through her jeans and his, the unmistakable shape of his cock. Fully erect, pulsing slightly, so ready to go...

Andy wasn't bad in bed, in fact, they'd had some good times. But he was in his forties now, and so even when he snuggled up to her in the morning wanting to have sex, his cock wasn't like this. No, this kind of youthful, raw, energy for really fucking had been long gone from their marriage for years. It wasn't just him: she couldn't remember the last time she'd soaked her panties with desire before she brought her fingers or Andy's to her clit, to have the kind of dull session of manual stimulation the two of them required to get things cooking.

Not like now. Now her body was on fire. Intellectually, she knew she should stop things there, that what she was doing was very, very wrong. Instead, she put her hands on his waist, maybe somewhere in the back of her mind thinking she would push him away.

Was he the initiator? His mouth moved insistently against her lips; he wasted no time getting his fingers into her hair.

Or was it her? She was the one who slipped her hands into his jeans and pushed down until she found what she was looking for: his cock, pulsing slightly, hot, and pleasantly thick.

But he was the one who dropped his hands to his belt and unbuckled it.

And then, they were suddenly ripping at their own clothes, pushing each other's jeans down, hands diving into underwear. He pushed her up onto the table, and she let him. She opened her legs and lifted her hips to get him inside of her. He was so hard that he didn't have to guide himself, she was so wet that he slid right in.

He was bigger than Andy, but only slightly: the difference in the feel inside of her was one of enthusiasm, of energy, of youthful strength.

She leaned back on her hands and pulled him by her crossed ankles toward her. She had a strong core, a strong cheerleader's body, and so it was nothing for her to roll her pelvis up from the table and grind against

him until she came. She came fast, maybe because of the shadows and the illicitness of what they were doing, maybe because he was hot... but she did.

When he came it overtook him, and she watched his face and his tightening muscles, leaning on her hands on the table.

The thought she should have had – the thought she felt guilty for not having, later – was what a bad wife she was. How she would tell Andy, and fire Jake, and never do this again.

Instead, she thought of his hands slipping into her slit, and how he needed some guidance. And with that guidance, he would soon be very, very good at what he did.

It was a terrible thought, so she dropped her legs and stepped into her jeans, her legs shaking. His cum was dripping down her thigh as she pulled them up, and another awful thought flickered in her mind: it wouldn't matter, because she always took a shower after working in the heat.

And Andy probably wouldn't want to push her onto a table and fuck her like that, anyway. Only later did she consider, shocking herself with the realization, that she'd never even given a thought to protection: she'd taken him bareback, allowing his jets of potent young cum to swim deep into her womb.

The expression on Jake's face was one of surprise, desire, lust. She hopped to pull her jeans up and fastened them. The control had somehow swung back in her direction – it was just as palpable, just as tangible as the shift to him had been, only moments before.

And the odd thing was, she felt cool as a cucumber again. She had a kind of power over him, now that he had fucked her, and it gave her a thrill. "I better go get these papers out to Charlie and let him go. 'Else he'll start suspecting something."

Jake was still standing there, panting slightly, jeans and boxers around his ankles.

"Go on," she said, a little bossily, a little bit friendly. "Get dressed before I open this door or there's not gonna be much room for only suspicion."

She smoothed her hair while he buckled his jeans. When he was done, she turned and opened the door, without saying anything else.

And truth be told, as good as coming with her pussy wrapped around Jake's young, thick cock had been, it was almost as good to leave him

staring after her. He wanted more of her and she could feel his hunger radiating from behind her.

And as bad as she would feel in about an hour, there was no way to lie to herself: that kind of power felt good.

CHAPTER 4

Jo paused to wipe a droplet of sweat from her forehead and take a break from the work of pulling apart hay. She leaned on her pitchfork and looked over the rolling pasture, spreading out from in front of the South Stables, where the mares and their colts lived.

She was surprised to find living here as satisfying as she did. When they'd called about her mother, and the reality of her father's situation, the idea of returning to Sayville had gripped her by the throat until she thought she wouldn't be able to breathe. The possibility that she would have to go back to a place she'd worked so hard to leave behind for even a month, which is what it had seemed it would be at the time, was asphyxiating.

When she had gone through the books with an accountant, and it had been clear that Seymore Farms was as upside-down as you could get without going to jail for it, her chest had squeezed so tightly she saw spots in her vision.

There was no way she was going back *there*, she had thought. Not after living in Chicago so long. Not after remaking herself like she had. She was Jo Bentley now, not Tabitha Seymore, and the only things she had ever intended to return to Sayville for were funerals.

As if all of that hadn't stepped on her hard enough, she had lost her job at Brand to inevitable layoffs, and – she could not help believing – professional jealousy. It was if the whole universe was conspiring to smother her.

Her reaction to that sort of thing was to give in to it. She had found that if you just did anything the universe seemed to be forcing you to do with enough enthusiasm, it turned out all right. So she had been the one to suggest moving back to Georgia and bringing the farm back to life. And she had thrown herself into it, all the way, even though she was screaming inside at the time.

Sure enough, now it didn't seem so bad. She loved the smell of fresh hay, the deep green of the pastures, the age of the old home, made of stones pulled from these very fields. It had been a long time since she had put in a good day's work on a farm – or anywhere. There was nothing like the

feeling. Nothing like feeling *hungry* at the end of the day, like you could eat anything.

“Ma’am, you know that’s my job, there, don’t you?”

Jo turned around to see Caleb, her twenty-year-old hire, a good-looking kid with sandy hair and work-strong muscles under work-tanned skin, hauling two huge buckets of water up to a rafter above his head and balancing them there with ease. He moved them around as though they were paperweights.

“I like it,” Jo told him, turning back to the pasture to make sure Caleb wasn’t interpreting anything she said to him the way she was vaguely thinking it. He was *twenty*, for fuck’s sake. And she wasn’t the type to go for brutish good-looks. Even if he did have the hardest body she’d seen in a long time... Nate was a good-looking guy, a trim guy, but Caleb was the kind of guy you put in a calendar. Or envisioned if you were reading a trashy novel.

She jammed her pitchfork back into the hay. God, she was a creepy old woman, she thought. To him, she must seem ancient. “‘S’all right,” she drawled, surprised not for the first time by the depths of the roots of her accent, which had returned in full force. “Kinda like it, after all those years sittin’ behind a desk.”

Caleb pushed a bucket onto a ledge and stared at her, then gave her a smile and shook his head. “Lord. I’d give anything to get out of here and never shovel another load of pig sh- uh, ‘scuse me, feces – around. But if you like it, you’re the boss. Give me more time to do this other stuff needs doin.’”

He placed two hands on a beam at his shoulder height, and pushed himself up so he could hook a leg over it and jump nimbly up to where he had placed the water buckets. He did this without even a groan or a struggle.

Jo enjoyed the now-familiar plucking of a string inside of her, from her heart to her groin.

Then she turned away and began to spread the hay, not sure what to say. Caleb continued his ascent. Jo wasn’t sure what he was doing, but she guessed it needed to be done, and she didn’t want to sound like a “cidiot” (the rural colloquial combination of “city” and “idiot”) and reveal how out-of-touch she was with farm life.

Say what you wanted to about the kid, he was a hard worker. The Knights had a family reputation for being hard workers, and woe befall the boy who didn't keep it up. He had done all the chores she'd assigned him by around two o'clock, and then he'd set himself to more.

A few moments passed in silence. Jo would have liked to say something, but decided against it: Caleb seemed content to do his work, and she was the only one making things awkward, and that was probably entirely in her own head. Caleb, in all likelihood, didn't even know she was on this planet after he left the farm at night. She was just a middle-aged lady who was his boss.

"I thought for sure you'd hire yourself some farmhands, TJ Seymore," said a sultry voice from behind her.

Jo's stomach dropped. Mandy Knight – Mandy Poole, rather.

It was inevitable, she knew – she had known, from the beginning – that she would have to reckon with her past eventually. Almost everyone was still here, and it wasn't like no one would recognize her.

Still, she'd done her level best to stay out of town, hoping, somehow, she could live here for a few years and never run into a single person who remembered her.

Fat chance of that, in a small town like Sayville.

So here was Mandy Knight, leaning against the barn door, one foot crossed over an ankle.

Mandy looked good – and to tell the truth, Jo was surprised by that. She'd assumed everyone in Sayville would have gotten old and fat, like most girls out there did once they had a few kids. But Mandy looked like she was twenty-seven. She wore her hair long, carefully straightened, cut stylishly with bangs. Her figure hadn't suffered so much as a dent: she was thin and toned, well-proportioned and tall, a bit like Jo but with less definition in her arms and legs.

Only her hands gave her away as older. They had aged far more than Jo's, no doubt from the restaurant and "real" work.

She gave Jo a playful grin and the hint of a wink. Mandy had always been like that: everything she said she seemed to be indicating had some kind of joke or mischief behind it, and it took a long time knowing her to realize it wasn't necessary to attribute her malicious-looking grin to malice. It was just playfulness.

Still, she was unsettling.

“I *got* me a farmhand,” Jo said, letting her pitchfork lean away from her in an outstretched arm. She used her other hand to point up into the rafters, where Caleb was moving with confidence and two buckets of water to the dangerous heights of the barn loft. She wondered, momentarily, why he hadn’t used the ladder, then remembered it had rotted out, like so much else in this place. His confidence in the rafters was a good sign.

Mandy looked up at Caleb, and folded her arms to take in the view at her leisure. “Oh yeah, I heard about *that*,” she drawled, almost sexually.

When she looked back at Jo, she leaned forward slightly to confide: “There’s a whole lotta guys disappointed they didn’t come down here for that job, I’ll tell you.”

Jo blinked, because it took her a while to understand what Mandy was getting at, and by then, she had moved on.

“Just up here,” she almost yelled, indicating with her eyes that she wanted Caleb to hear her for some reason, “to extend my invitation to the Skinkles again.”

Jo jammed the pitchfork in the hay to give herself something to do. “I dunno,” she said.

“Oh come on, Tibs. You know everyone ‘round here is just chompin’ at the bit to see what happened to TJ Seymore. If you don’t go down there, all these rumors goin’ around’re gonna be bigger than they already are.”

In spite of herself, Jo laughed, tossing some hay into the corner of Mable’s stable. “Oh, yeah,” she sang. “Like what? What’re they already saying?”

“Somebody said you married an old stockbroker for his money while you were hookin’ up with your man – what’s his name? -”

“Nate.”

“Nate, here. Somebody – whole lotta people, actually – sayin’ you got knocked up and you have a baby in New York...”

Jo shook her head and started pitching hay into the stable for Mable, as Mandy rattled off the list of improbable things she had supposedly done over the past twenty years. Most of it was ridiculous. But actually, she thought suddenly – that could work to her favor. The more ridiculous the stories these people had about her past – especially the part that Nate had been witness to and therefore knew to be untrue – the more likely it was that anything *true* about her past would sound just as made-up.

“So?” Mandy said, after a while.

Jo gave another toss of hay, then rested against the pitchfork. “So, what?” she asked.

Mandy, who still moved like a sex kitten, swaying her hips and dragging her fingers provocatively on something – a table, her bare skin, a railing, whatever – sauntered over to a stool and sat down on it. She sat with her legs spread, elbows on knees, and gave her hair a toss. She seemed, as she always had, flirtatious in her every action. “So, what *have* you been doin’ all this time?”

Jo rolled her eyes and started in on the hay again. “Now, I’m sure my momma told her book club, and they told all of Sayville a long time ago.”

Mandy blew on her bangs. “Yeah, sure, you got yourself some hotshot job in Chicago, designing things, but that in’n’t the story anybody wants to hear.”

Mandy had a devilish grin on her face. “You’d better come on down to Skinkles,” she added. “Or who knows what folks’ll make up.”

Caleb’s muscled body dropped nimbly from a rafter. He expelled a soft breath, and gave Mandy a nod.

“Hey there, Caleb,” Mandy said, crossing her legs and pointing a shoe at him. Jo noted that Mandy, somehow, had made it all the way out to the stables without getting a smudge of dirt on her ballet-slipper shoes.

“Mandy,” Caleb said politely, with a polite-as-pie smile, and then turned to Jo. “All done for the day, gonna get back up there in the morning after that has a soak and clean it out. Seven o’clock?”

Jo nodded. “Sounds good.”

“Bye, Caleb,” Mandy sang.

The two of them watched him leave. Jo’s eyes were on his shapely ass, which looked like an ad for jeans.

“If that boy weren’t my second cousin...” Mandy drawled, puckering her lips.

Jo looked at her. “He’s like, ten years old,” she said, the protest in her voice diluted more than she’d hoped.

Mandy rolled her eyes. “He’s twenty-one in November and don’t tell me you haven’t given it no thought whatsoever...” she looked out the door again, even though Caleb was long gone. “Actually, I think it’s just the last name puts me off. Can’t have people thinkin’ we’re backwoods rednecks ‘round here.”

“Can’t have that,” Jo said, digging into the hay, shaking her head.

“So? You gonna come to this cookout, or d’I have to drag you down there?”

“I’ll think about it.”

Mandy leaned on her knees again. For a moment, her expression looked devilishly mischievous, and Jo had to breathe slowly to keep her heart rate steady. After all, if Mandy really got the hankering to do it, she could make Jo’s life pretty miserable. Mandy knew just about every secret there was to know in Sayville, especially the Sayville TJ Seymore had grown up in, and Jo really preferred that those details remain in the past.

After she’d seen Mandy, she’d thought about having a conversation with her, coming clean with her that she’d kept a lot of secrets from her husband, and she’d prefer if Mandy didn’t spill them all. Just don’t allude to them, she’d have told Mandy.

But who knew if you could trust Mandy with a mission like that? She wasn’t a mean girl, and she didn’t have the brains to be particularly manipulative. She wasn’t a nice girl either. She reminded Jo of a cat, who would just tip things over for the hell of it, the sound of the crash.

But Jo had so many balls in the air already – Nate wasn’t an idiot, and unfortunately, he was a writer, which meant that he was essentially a spy on human nature. He didn’t miss details, and he could already tell, from the few interactions with people Jo had been unable to avoid, that she was trying to keep the lid on *something*.

Jo looked up at the rafters. “Whadya reckon he was up to up there?” she asked, to buy herself some more time.

If what Mandy said was true, and rumors were swirling about her time away, and why she came back, then maybe she could leverage the rumor mill in her favor. Maybe, instead of hiding from the truth, she should just open the floodgates and let it come in right with all the bullshit.

In fact, if she played her cards right, she could probably get Mandy generating some truly unbelievable bullshit for her.

It was a risky strategy.

But Jo had made a living for the last eight years being a risk-taker in one of the riskiest businesses ever. Generating rumors, or blending them away, was what she did for a living.

“Probably pigeon shit,” Mandy said. “Eats away at the wood.” She shrugged. “Or maybe he just wanted to show off for you. That boy’s got some guns, you seen him with his shirt off?”

Jo rested on the pitchfork. “You’d really do him if he wasn’t your cousin?” she asked.

“Might still, anyway,” Mandy sniffed. When she saw Jo’s raised eyebrows she rolled her eyes. “It’s a small town, Tibs. Beggars can’t turn down a slab of gorgeous meat served to them on a platter of-.”

And Jo, who was far from being a prude, felt compelled to stop her mid-sentence. “Well, I guess I *will* come on down to Skinkles,” she said quickly. “Why not?”

Mandy clapped her hands together and babbled about the fun they’d have.

Jo smiled, and nodded, but she was already working, deep inside her brain, forming a strategy.

CHAPTER 5

The dirt driveway down to “Skinkles” - the determiner “the,” Nate had noticed, was peculiarly optional in Sayville dialect – looked like a child had been playing with toy trucks and had abandoned the game midway to go take a nap. Enormous pickup trucks were parked every which way, but Jo, who had insisted on driving because she could only remember how to get there by muscle memory, drove full-speed through them and wedged their vehicle into the pile.

The house was a large stone mansion like Jo’s parents’ place, with an added-on wraparound porch, Christmas lights strung inexplicably from the awnings. It was near dusk, and the many people standing on the porch eyed their SUV suspiciously until Jo emerged from it, when a collective hoot rose up from the throng and a few launched themselves over the railing yelling things like “I’ll be damned,” and “If it isn’t TJ Seymore.”

Nate sat a few beats in the car, getting almost immediately too hot. The back of his neck was burning with the general discomfort Sayville brought him, and also the irritation of hearing his wife’s former name hollered out so many times. Jo Bentley seemed to be a thing of the past. He was the only one who called her that, here, and he’d have thought “Jo” could have ended up a term of endearment, a pet name, something sweet between them. But the name seemed to suit her less and less as the days passed. Maybe he was imagining it, but she seemed to respond to it less and less. He had called her Jo in the kitchen the other day to get her attention, and she had taken more than a few seconds to respond.

He was entertaining all kinds of horrifying fantasies. She was actually a secret agent, and her cover was slipping. She had only married him because she was desperate (though, for what, he couldn’t really fathom, since Jo seemed more than capable of earning her own money and had thought she had a safe inheritance).

He took a deep breath, prepared himself for being called “The Yankee,” and opened the door.

Jo was being embraced by a number of men their age, most of whom had the physique of barrel-chested men who drank too much beer, and dirty

shirts. A few women were squealing the way women squeal when they see each other after any amount of time, from one hour to twenty years.

No one paid him any mind.

They were having a perfectly unintelligible conversation – the accents were too strong, the expressions too unfamiliar, the references that littered the talk were to people he had never heard of.

Finally, Mandy – the waitress from The Laughing Goat – made her way down to the throng. Nate kept his eyes, and a plastic smile, on the group with his wife, but he couldn't help notice Mandy and her sultry walk.

She walked right up to him. "How you gettin' on?" she said, extending a semi-cold glass bottle of beer to him, which he took gratefully.

"Oh terrific," he said cheerfully. "It's great to be the Yankee of Sayville."

Mandy snorted softly through her nose, and smiled winningly. It was the kind of practiced, innuendoed smile that surely provoked more than a few men. "That's funny," she said. "You're funny. Women do like a good sense of humor in a man."

She was standing just a little too close to him for someone who was essentially a stranger. Not touching, just... too close. She edged in a little closer, and then her arm was through his.

"Boys," she called out, pulling him toward the group. "Don' be rude, now, this is TJ's Yankee husband, Nathan Bentley from Chicago. Be hospitable and say hello to the man."

Nathan felt his face burning, but hoped it was not visibly red, as the burly men encircled him and extended hands, yelling "Ho there, Nathan Bentley from Chicago, I'm Ricky Skinkle!" (or similar) Their handshakes, with few exceptions, were firm and exaggerated.

The happiness of the exchange between them and TJ evaporated, and it turned into a meet and greet as awkward as a first day on the job, with each person shaking hands vigorously while the others watched. Everyone gave him a suspicious stare except when they were personally shaking his hand.

He had a terrifying thought as the ladies approached: he had no idea what was appropriate here. Did he kiss their hands? He didn't want to, that was a weird custom and he didn't even know if they did it here. But what if they expected him to? A handshake, here in Georgia, seemed out of place. They didn't have their hands out anyway.

He settled for tipping his baseball cap slightly and saying “ma’am,” which felt absurd to him but seemed to land well with the girls. The men were unchanged, which he supposed was good because it at least meant he hadn’t screwed up.

Everyone set to interviewing Jo, who asked if she could get herself a beer, which they had already brought down for her. She seemed in a hurry to head toward the house, and meet a few more people, which Nate wasn’t sure how to take.

Since she’d gotten to Sayville she’d seemed to be hiding something. But she was the one who had suggested the party, and her sudden enthusiasm for it had his hackles up.

Now she was practically charging into the crowd, leaving him to fend for himself, which seemed even odder, because until then, she’d almost seemed to want to be a barrier between him and anyone from Sayville at all.

Mandy put her arm back through his and started to walk him up to the house. She extended an arm toward the group of men. “George Ray, there, Bruce,” she drawled, making little sense to Nate, who took a while to figure out “Bruce” was his last name, “he was TJ’s sweetheart back in the day.”

She took a swig of her beer, and Nate watched her face, trying to decide if she was being malevolent or not. “But then,” she added, “So was Chance there. And Jay.”

Her eyes were on the house, not Nate, so she didn’t seem to be saying any of that to fish for his reaction. Close to the steps she was distracted by something and briefly let go of him, but came back to link her arm in his again. “Come on darlin,” she said, smiling. “I’ll introduce you to the gang.”

*

Nate got himself to work getting drunk as quickly as possible, but he soon figured out that he was no match for the gang at “Skinkles.”

Partway through the evening, he caught on that this was a homecoming cookout, because evidently homecoming was just as important to adults as it was to high school kids, who were evidently having their own party at a quarry. He didn’t want details.

The first hour of the party was uncomfortable. Jo was dragged from person to person, repeated an abbreviated, canned story about why she was

back (“My daddy’s sick, and you know how momma passed, so I’m gonna try to take care of the farm for a bit,”) deftly ignored any questions about where she’d been and why she never visited, and then lurched out of a group to grab Nate and introduce him. He felt like an afterthought, and everyone he was introduced to eyed him with skepticism, as if they didn’t quite believe that he could be Jo’s husband.

Or, at least, that’s how it seemed.

Mandy appeared, towing a girl who looked eerily like her, with brown bangs, a pretty face, and the same impish expression turning up her mouth and lighting up her eyes. “Nathan Bentley, TJ Seymore’s husband from up north, this is my good friend Annabelle Lewis.

“I would have said you were sisters,” Nate said, putting a hand out, which Annabelle took while looking at it as if it were a strange piece of meat.

Nate cleared his throat. “Uh, sorry, I’ve been meaning to ask someone... how is it you greet a lady down here?”

Mandy smiled. “Bless your heart, darlin,’” she said. Then she exchanged a glance with Annabelle. “There aren’t any ladies in Sayville so I reckon’ you won’t need to worry about it.”

Nate smiled back, unsure what to make of Mandy, who delivered this reply while shifting her hips to one side and fluttering her eyes with her provocative half-smile.

“You could get me a drink,” Annabelle suggested. “Ladies don’t walk around with their drinks down here.” She gave Mandy a sidelong glance, and Mandy tipped the bottle of beer she was definitively carrying around, and took a sip, her eyes still on Nate.

“Uh,” Nate said. “Well then, okay, a drink it is... what will you have?”

Mandy smiled, as if there was some kind of joke going on, and Nate’s stomach flipped again. This place was giving him the creeps, though he’d be hard-pressed to say exactly why.

Annabelle put her hand on his arm. “Beer’s just fine,” she told him.

They giggled when he walked away.

Jesus, what was it with this place? He got a dark vibe from everything, and while he knew he was probably just being paranoid, he felt, constantly, like something terrible was about to happen.

When he got back to Annabelle and Mandy, carrying three beers – one for each of them – the girls fluttered and smiled and exchanged glances again. Nate noticed that other people at the party, passing by, gave them curious looks. It seemed to him that guys were smirking, girls were rolling their eyes, and he, Nate Bentley, was in hot water.

He looked around for Jo as Annabelle slowly disgorged the answer to his question “What do you do for a living?” But Jo had disappeared, something he found equally alarming.

“So,” Mandy said, as soon as Annabelle’s slow-moving explanation rolled to a halt. “What do you think of Sayville so far?”

Nate eyed her warily. “It’s... lovely,” he said.

Mandy blinked her eyes.

“It’s an adjustment,” Nate said. “A lot of, uh... cultural differences.”

Mandy’s only response to this was to look over the rim of her beer at him pointedly before extending her tongue to the rim – very subtly, very quickly – running the tip of it along the edge of the glass, and then taking a sensual sip in a way that could not have alluded more to being a blowjob unless she had an actual cock in her mouth.

Nate’s dick reacted, thickening a little. He said nothing, because that was the kind of thing he had only seen – only imagined seeing – in movies.

“Like what?” Annabelle asked.

“Yeah, like what?” Mandy asked. The way she pronounced her “I” was overtly sexual, she lifted her chin and lifted her tongue to her front teeth with an overly open mouth, her darkly shadowed eyes dropping heavily in a bedroomy blink.

Nate blinked. “Uh...” For a moment he was not sure what he was talking about. “Oh, just... you know, levels of politeness... I, uh, never lived in a small... town before...”

Mandy was swinging slightly as she listened to him, and it was so distracting his mind went blank. She was attractive, for sure – but he had seen an attractive woman or two before in his life. Just not one who actually acted like this.

“Small towns can be real interesting,” Mandy told him, after he babbled for a few seconds and his voice trailed off. “You can make your own fun.”

“Sure,” Nate said, uncertainly. “I’m sure they can...”

It was Annabelle's turn to laugh lightly and bring her drink to her mouth.

An awkward silence ensued, while Mandy stared at him sexually and Annabelle laughed inwardly about whatever she had taken to be funny.

"So..." Nate said loudly, because some music had been turned up from another room. The party was tangibly wilder, suddenly. "You were about to say something to Jo back at the restaurant. When she spilled her tea?"

Mandy leaned her head forward. "What's that, darlin'? Can't hear you?"

"Back at the restaurant, you were about to say something -"

Annabelle rolled her body to the music and loudly sang the lyrics to the song, which every occupant of the house seemed compelled to do, including Mandy. The chorus was belted out while everyone held their hands in the air, smiling at each other.

Nate did not know the song.

Mandy leaned back in toward him. "What was it you were askin' me, hon?"

She put her hand on his shoulder, and he was sure that he felt her fingers stroke him. She had pulled him close to her, and her lips were just millimeters from his ears. Her breath made the hairs stand up on end.

"You were saying something," Nate repeated, already sensing he would be interrupted again, and never get his answer. "Back at the bar, when you invited us."

Mandy was smiling at him strangely, her eyes absorbing him. She was just about to shake her head, he could tell.

"You said, 'it's a perfect homecoming for the -' and then Jo spilled her tea?" Nate yelled.

Mandy's hips had started to move, and she was grinding dangerously close to him. He needed to extract himself, and he was sure that she was going to say she didn't remember.

Mandy didn't seem, quite frankly, like the kind of girl who remembered much.

But Nate only thought that because he was not from a small town, where remembering things of that very sort was a very particular kind of currency. And Mandy Knight may not have had much by way of legal tender, but she knew how to make herself rich in other ways.

Her eyes narrowed so slightly Nate didn't even notice, but he could see a weasel's interest in her expression. She drank another sip of her beer, and hung an arm on Nate's shoulder. "Oh, yeah. I remember what I said," she drawled, and pushed her hips toward his.

Nate was frozen, unsure of what to do. Mandy was smiling: she had him rapt with attention and she was enjoying that.

She pushed her pelvis against him, moving his semi-thickened dick in a small circle. Checking out to see if he was hard. Her smile remained the same: whatever she thought of that, she wasn't going to let him know.

"I said, 'the perfect homecoming for the homecoming *queen*.'"

And then she sat back to watch his reaction, because Mandy Knight had already calculated something, and she had calculated correctly.

There wasn't much to do in Sayville, but she was right about one thing: you could make your own fun. And watching that Yankee Nate try to keep a straight face, like he wasn't surprised his own wife hadn't told him she was homecoming queen, was pretty fun.

Thinking about why it would be that TJ Seymore hadn't mentioned that was even more fun.

And the realization that if TJ hadn't mentioned *that* fact, there was probably a whole lot more she hadn't told him... well, that would at least be really interesting.

Nate took a sip of his beer.

"She never told you that?" Mandy asked.

She wondered what he would say. What kind of Yankee was he?

"I must have forgot," Nate said.

Mandy smiled and clinked her bottle against his. A smart Yankee. Well.

Bless his heart.

Annabelle leaned over to Mandy, her eyes on the corridor and a group of young guys who were making their way into the crowded party.

Mandy looked Nate up and down. "I gotta go see somebody," she said, her hand on his arm. She gave him a squeeze. "If you know what I mean."

Nate smiled. He did not. He guessed drugs, but with Mandy you couldn't really tell. "I'll just..." he said, pointing in the opposite direction.

"Hope I see you later," Mandy said. Then her face went impish again. "Or maybe you wanna come along?"

“Uh...” Nate said.

“Go on, find your homecoming queen,” Mandy said.

Nate turned, and walked uncertainly into the kitchen.

*

Another period of awkwardness followed. Jo had disappeared, and he was occasionally overtaken by mild panic, until he saw her over the increasingly animated sea of people, talking to someone, usually a guy, but definitely looking ordinary.

His stomach was queasy. He didn't like the paranoid feeling he was getting.

He talked to a few people, participating in a standard conversation while his mind worked away in the background.

High school. What had Jo ever told him about high school? Or Georgia, or any part of this past, for that matter?

She had grown up on a farm. They raised race horses. They were wealthy.

But high school... what had she ever said about it?

Whoever he was talking to – a really, really drunk younger guy who had wanted to know if he was from some place called Sawyer and could not remember Nate's answer, asked him if he smoked.

Nate had caved, wanting a cigarette. When they got to the porch, it turned out to be a joint, which he pretended to smoke to avoid arguing with his drunk friend.

The drunk wandered off, Nate managed to bum a cigarette off a pair of girls, who chatted him up for a nanosecond before having one of those staged conversations where two people talk about themselves for the benefit of the third person but pretend it's just normal talk.

High school... high school.

Had Jo told him *anything* about high school at all?

It seemed impossible, on the face of it, that they had been married so long and the topic had never come up. But Jo wasn't a stroll-down-memory-lane kind of girl, and the fact that she wasn't – until now – had seemed perfectly in place with her personality. But he had never felt as if there were a gap in his knowledge about her, not like he did now.

As he tried to recall any real piece of information about Jo's life in Sayville, or high school, he realized that he had made assumptions about Jo's previous life based on what she was like in university. He had just *assumed* she was one of the misfits, smoking behind a dumpster, rolling her eyes at the popular cheerleading types.

She had never actually claimed to be that, though. Not that he could remember. In fact, now that he really racked his brains for a memory of a conversation about any of this, he realized it probably didn't exist. Jo had laughed about a couple of jokes he had made, nodded in agreement during movie scenes where the brainy or unconventional dorks get revenge on the jocks... he had taken those meager cues for confirmation that his own constructed memory of Jo as a teenager was correct. Sufficient.

But... what did it matter? Why was it bothering him?

He had edged himself along the wraparound porch, away from most of the people. It was pitch black out in the fields and surrounding the house: the eerie glow of the Christmas lights made it impossible to see much. There was no moon.

But he could hear something out there, and it took a few moments for him to realize what it was. The huffing, puffing sounds of a couple having sex. He squinted into the inkiness, and he could see the faint outline of a vehicle moving, as though pushed by the hand of a strong wind.

It was not an especially scandalous sight, not at a party like this where everyone seemed to be acting twenty years younger than they were anyway (he had seen someone doing a beer bong in the living room on his way out). But the skydiving sensation in his stomach came from something else, a fluttering thought that never really coalesced: maybe it was Jo.

As soon as he had the thought, though, he was startled from the fantasy by a loud bang on the metal of the car.

"Get a fuckin' room, Knight!" a male voice yelled.

Laughter.

A female voice from inside the car.

Two male figures emerging from the darkness.

"...like old times."

"She did my brother at his wedding."

A laugh. The guys joined a cluster of more men who had emerged from the party. Nate shrugged off the awkward feeling making the nape of his neck burn.

“Knight’s out there fucking your cousin in your car, bro,” one of them said.

There was a low conversation, a lot of jockish laughter, and then Nate distinctly heard someone ask about “TJ Seymore” being back in town.

“Right in there talkin’ to Charlie Miller, shit you not.”

More murmurs, laughter, while Nate tried hard to eavesdrop and appear to be minding his own business. He heard the phrase “just like old times,” and he thought, just after someone mentioned that Mandy was taking a long time in the car, and had maybe lost her touch, he heard someone say: “Go on get TJ, she’ll get the job done.”

And then a snap.

Nate froze, unable to believe he had heard what he had heard. The sentence had to make a few circles in his mind, while he connected the known facts that his wife, Jo, used to go by “TJ” and that it was therefore his wife this gang of orangutans believed could “get the job done.”

His limbs felt cold. He stared in the opposite direction, leaning on the balcony, the conversation next to him getting lower and less like English than the locker room grunting of men sharing sexual exploits by hinting at them with smirking smiles.

He wished he had another cigarette, because he didn’t look like he had any business out here. He felt like if he left, it would be pretty obvious, so he stayed put, taking his phone out as though he had some business to attend to.

“You the guy?” one of the group said, turning the conversation very suddenly on Nate.

Nate felt his insides turn again. This party was a roller coaster: one moment he felt ashamed of his paranoia, like maybe he’d watched one too many episodes of *Ozark* or something, the next minute there was a definite malice hanging in the air again, and he was sure he was going to get slugged.

“What guy’s that?” he asked, looking up from his phone, which had no service. He was doing his best not to sound like a jerk, but also not like a pushover. *Where he was from*. A question like that was always loaded.

“Guy who married TJ Seymore,” the man, a brown-haired guy with signs of balding, erased by a shaved head, and a bulky physique piled over a once-athletic frame.

The one Mandy had identified as Jake popped his beer bottle from his mouth before the sentence was finished. “Yeah, that’s him,” he said, and Nate could not tell if it was a snarl or a plain statement.

“Nate,” Nate said, impressing himself with his own cool.

Their eyes narrowed, and Nate felt his heart skip a beat, mostly because he had no idea what kind of interaction this was. He managed not to flinch when one of them reached into a box and clinked a bottle against another to hold it out to him. “You got a beer, bro?”

Nate walked forward with the confidence he had learned in Chicago, where sometimes you ended up in Cicero without meaning to and it was best to bluff at least a little chutzpah. It was a tactic he’d learned from a Jewish friend who pulled out a yarmulke and lit up a cigarette whenever he found himself in that situation, because, he was convinced, a Jewish kid smoking and wearing a yarmulke and walking like a tough guy gave everyone the impression that he’d taken one too many beat-downs and either lost his mind or gone full-on Rambo. Either way, those were two things most people stayed away from.

He reached for the beer, even though his wasn’t finished, and prayed it was a twist-off. “Take one of those,” he said.

They eyed him a beat too long, and Nate had a sinking feeling the whole thing was going to turn ugly.

“I’m Jay. Smith.” Jay Smith said, instead, extending his hand. His grip was firm but not aggressive. His tone seemed friendly.

“Chance,” the bald guy said. “Nicholls.” Same handshake.

Jay and Chance, former boyfriends. Last names, Nate noted, were of great importance here.

“Donny Ray,” the last guy – the most hostile – said. His handshake was soul-crushing, but Nate gave back as hard as he could. Donny Ray did not offer his surname, which Nate supposed meant something, but he didn’t know what.

Jay reached for Nate’s beer with a bottle opener in his hand, waving him to relinquish it.

Thank God for small miracles. These guys looked like they’d take it off with their teeth and expected everyone to be able to.

“So tell us, Nate. What the hell *did* you do to land yourself the Homecoming Queen of Lee County High?” This from Chance, who Nate couldn’t decide if he was friendly or hostile.

Nate had the beer back in his hand so he was able to keep it short by taking a sip. “Just good-lookin’ I guess.”

“He’s not a fuckin’ redneck,” Jay mumbled.

Nate took a longer gulp than necessary.

Donny Ray – not George Ray, from earlier in the evening, Nate thought miserably, wondering how he’d keep all the names straight – made a derisive snickering sound. “She still pretty wild?”

Nate could not pretend to drink more beer.

He wasn’t sure what “wild” meant, but he knew two things: based on the conversations he’d overheard, and his own imagination, he could take a guess; and, he didn’t want to be an ass and ask.

Nate shrugged.

The guy looked down the length of the bottle at Nate as he took a long sip and made the same derisive sound.

Jay shot him a look. “So... it true TJ ended up bein’ some hot-shot... what is it?”

“Marketing executive,” Nate contributed, helpfully.

Jay squinted.

“Thought it was lawyer,” Chance said.

“I heard she went into porn,” Donny Ray said, with a certain strange smile on his lips, looking right at Nate. “Got enough-”

“Guys,” Jay interrupted softly, and then moved on quickly to address himself to Nate. “Marketing executive, huh? Sure come a long way from Sayville.”

There was an awkward silence.

“Good for her,” Jay said, and it seemed to Nate he was doing him the favor of breaking it up.

“You all running a farm?” Nate said, to keep things moving. His head was spinning, though. Got enough what? There were very few ways to finish that sentence, and he didn’t like any of them.

Porn.

Got enough practice.

The words spun in his head, just like the fact that Jo – or TJ, as it were – had been homecoming queen, and never mentioned it. He realized far too late that Chance had been talking to him for quite some time, and that he had been nodding and agreeing and had no idea what he was talking about.

“Sure,” he said, hopefully.

Chance gave him a strange look. “Whereabouts? Up there in Chicago?”

“Uh, yeah,” Nate said, hoping he would key in soon on the topic.

“Eh, you prob’ly won’t think a whole lotta this, then.”

Jay put his arm around Chance and patted his belly affectionately. “Mostly what Officer Nicholls here does is check up on Lee County’s dining establishments. You don’t want to ride along with him ‘less you been starvin’ a few weeks.”

Nate swallowed, grateful for the clue. “Well, I’d still be interested,” he said, as soon as he realized he’d been invited to a ride along, and that Chance was a cop. He thought Jay winked at him as he tipped his head back and took a swig of beer.

Maybe Jay was on his side.

“He don’ want to go ridin’ around with no rent-a-cop,” Donny Ray said. “What is it you do, Nate? Somethin’ white collar, am I right about that?”

“Editor,” he said quietly, nodding slightly but not taking his eyes off Donny Ray’s.

Donny Ray glared at him with glinting eyes, as though Nate had just confessed to murder.

“Like, books and stuff?”

Nate nodded. “Articles, essays, that kind of thing too,” he said. He immediately wished he hadn’t. He sounded like Frasier Crane confronting a lynch mob.

“Hell, that’s a good livin’ if you can have it,” Jay said, looking at Chance. His body language said to cool it. He put a hand on Nate’s shoulder. “Sure by now someone’s told you Chance here and myself used to go out with TJ, back in the day,” he said.

Donny Ray gave a feral snort.

“But you seem like a good guy, and we’re happy y’all are back.”

“Now that’s a true statement,” Donny Ray agreed.

“Ignore Donny Ray,” Chance said, apparently having been shuffled into place by Jay. “His momma dropped him on his head a whole buncha times.”

“Faggot,” Donny Ray spat.

“Careful, ‘round Chicago here,” Chance warned. “Gotta be more PC.”

Chance was clearly joking, but Donny Ray started to puff up. Nate wondered if a fight was brewing: Donny Ray seemed pretty wasted, and like he was unstable to begin with.

Nate had no idea where the whole thing was headed. His blood was pounding with the kind of cornered-dog fear he used to have walking home from school.

But just then, Mandy Knight emerged from the darkness, and earned herself a round of lewd applause. She winked at almost everyone and primped her hair as she walked by, evidently unashamed of any aspect of what had transpired.

Nate held his jaw firmly in place, so that his mouth didn't fall open. Was this for real?

He took advantage of the break in the "conversation" to point his beer bottle aimlessly at the house, and follow in Mandy's wake to the door. "Just gonna... go see where Jo is..." he mumbled.

But the guys had already started snickering among themselves, undoubtedly about Mandy, and no one seemed to even notice that he left.

*

"Should you be driving?" he asked, when Jo took the keys from him.

"Only cop in this whole county is *at* that party and anyway.... I just had a few beers," Jo retorted. "Anyway. *You're* drunk. Climb on in."

Nate *was* drunk, which fit in nicely with her plans. Mandy had certainly been a big help – without knowing it, but that was probably the only way Mandy had ever been a big help in her life. Nate seemed to have plenty on his mind, and so now all she had to do was field his questions and find just the right way to spin her answers, without actually lying to him if it was possible. She'd made a living doing just that, to millions of people – selling a story without outright lying – so it seemed like she could handle one person's perceptions just fine.

It wasn't that she *wanted* to lie to her husband. In fact, it was the last thing she wanted to do. But the person she'd been in Sayville was *not* her anymore, and she didn't want Nate to really dig into it. Maybe she thought he'd lose respect for her, maybe she thought he'd hate her.

Maybe she just didn't want to deal with it.

Conveniently, she was sober as a preacher on Sunday morning, and Nate was too drunk to think straight.

She waited for him to bring it up. She drove slow, took a road in the wrong direction so they'd have to double-back – Nate still didn't have himself oriented and he'd never pick up on the trick.

"So," he said, finally. "I heard something interesting tonight."

Jo braced herself. Whatever it was, she could spin it, but it would require some fast thinking. "Oh, yeah?" she said, in her folksiest voice.

"I heard..." Nate said, and paused to bring his fist to his mouth to burp. He pounded on his chest. "Jesus, these roads are bumpy. I heard... you were homecoming queen? In high school? Did I hear that right?"

A softball.

She nodded, turning slowly to merge on a county road. The blinker threw the black fields into temporary light and then pitch-darkness, making a barn appear intermittently. Nothing had changed much in Sayville, that was for sure. She knew right where she was, and looked the same as it had almost twenty years ago. "I suppose you did," she told him, in her most amused tone.

Nate leaned on his hand and looked at her across the car. "How the -? Why the hell didn't you ever mention that?"

He was smiling. This was fun to him. Well, good. Maybe that was all he'd heard all night, in which case, maybe that was all he'd ever hear.

Everyone had grown up, after all. Almost everybody had kids. They weren't going to spend time talking about high school.

Jo shrugged. "I don't know. Kind of embarrassing, I guess." She looked over at him and smiled. "You know how I was trying to be all, dark, grunge-artzy student when I met you."

Nate grinned.

She reeled him in. Settling on the seat, both hands on the wheel, a smile on her lips, she said, smiling: "Back in high school," she paused for effect, "I was blonde, I put Sun-In in my hair to get blonder, I was a cheerleader, and I was homecoming queen. Okay? There you have it."

She found herself smiling at the memory herself. Actually, it felt good to have this out in the open, especially if this was as far as she had to go with the explanation of her high school years.

"Wow," Nate said. He turned to face the windshield. "Wow."

He was still smiling. He shook his head. "Homecoming queen. What is that, even?"

"Oh, come on, you didn't have a homecoming queen in your high school?"

He rubbed his head. "I guess so, some popular girl..."

"I bet you know her name," Jo said.

Nate was smiling. He looked down at his lap, shaking his head again.

"I bet you do," she prodded. She gave her hair a toss. "Everybody does."

There was a silence while they both smiled into the dark roads.

"You know it," Jo insisted, about a quarter of a mile down the road.

"I don't. Maybe. It was like... Krissy, Krista..."

"Don't lie, you know it, and it's all one word to you, and you had a secret crush on her."

"No."

"Just an itty, bitty one?"

"Okay, it was Krista-McCartney and she had brown curly hair and the longest legs anyone has ever seen."

Jo laughed and nodded. "See?"

Nate was quiet. He rubbed his jaw, where a little bit of stubble was growing and actually looked quite sexy on him. Something stirred inside of her.

"You're right," he said thoughtfully. "No one forgets the homecoming queen."

"Down here it's a big deal," Jo said, and looked over to see what expression Nate was wearing.

"Is it, now?" he asked, turning to face her again.

"Sure is," she said.

"So *nobody* would forget their homecoming queen, then. Not around here," Nate said. He had his hand over the back of the seat – the headrest was too low – and his fingertips brushed over her shoulder. "All those guys, back at the party, they would remember you the same way I remember Krista-McCarthy."

Jo tucked a strand of hair away. The conversation was edging dangerously close to something she'd rather brush under the table. "I guess," she said.

“But Krista McCarthy,” Nate declared loudly, “is now very fat, and very unattractive.”

Jo shot him a look.

“I saw her at the reunion ten years ago. It couldn’t have gone anywhere but downhill from there,” he said, shrugging.

There was a silence, while Jo shook her head apologetically for Krista McCarthy.

“Bet everyone was pretty stunned to see you show up, looking as hot as you did in high school,” Nate said, his voice fading, like his mind was wandering somewhere else.

Jo didn’t know what to say. It was probably best to just let him talk.

He turned to her suddenly, after a long think. “Those guys are probably going to go home and re-up all their fantasies about you.”

Jo kept her eyes on the road. She wasn’t quite sure what to make of Nate’s tone.

“Don’t be silly,” she said.

“Yeah,” Nate said, like he was having a conversation with himself.

“They will. They’ve all just gone to a party and their dream girl from high school was there, out of nowhere, and she looks just as good as she did back then, and they are all going to go home and think about that all night.”

His tone was partway between accusatory – as though he were egging her on to something – and, if she wasn’t mistaken, a little bit boastful.

She shook her head, as though she thought he were crazy.

“Man. That’s some splash you made, Jo Bentley.”

She shook her head again. They were almost home.

Nate looked over at her. His mood was buoyant, he seemed a little horny – but playfully so. His fingers swept over her shoulder.

“But you’re mine,” he said softly.

And then, suddenly, a dark thought clouded his mind, and it changed his expression just as surely as a cloud changes the color of a field.

“What?” Jo asked, without thinking, because the change on his face was so drastic.

Nate’s focus drew from within himself and to her face. He took a breath, his mouth parsed as though he wanted to say something. He said nothing in the end, thinking better of it.

“What?” Jo said, laughing, trying to make his mood lighter.

Dammit.

So there *was* more to what he had heard at the party than just “homecoming queen.”

Nate’s mouth closed, and she was sure he was going to say something, but in the end he just shook himself, as though he wanted to rid himself of the idea, like a dog does water from its coat. “I forgot what I was going to say,” he said lamely. His hand was on the door handle, and he popped it open.

He was climbing out of the car before Jo could do much damage control.

CHAPTER 6

After the Skinkle party, Nate had gone on a roller coaster on the way home. He had been drunk, it was too hard to pin down why he was going from ecstatic to depressed, bouncing from one conversation he'd overheard to the next. He remembered a dark cloud coming over his mood when they arrived at the farm, and thinking he was going to confront Jo about something.

But by the time they made their way upstairs, he had forgotten what that was. Jo had put two hands on his back as they walked down a dark hallway, and the heat of her touch had rippled through him, chasing out the dark thoughts.

Her hands had slipped down his back, into his jeans, tickling his ass, making them both laugh while they were trying to walk. For a moment he had forgotten the whole evening and was just enjoying that his wife was not tired after a whole day on the farm, was touching him, seemed welcoming.

He spun her around and pressed her against the wall, and they kissed, his hands pulling at her rough clothing, finding the soft silk layers beneath, then her bare skin.

It was then that delicious tidbits from the evening began to percolate in his thoughts. His wife, the cheerleader, the homecoming queen, and so you had to know that every guy at that party – literally, every one of them – had wanted her, and yet he was the one who got her. A real dream girl, and she was his.

Those were nice thoughts, and he was turned on anyway, so his cock was already hard as they tumbled into the bedroom, peeling off each other's clothes.

Maybe it was when he touched her pussy, found it to be perfectly smooth except for her well-trimmed landing strip, still waxed as though she lived in the city and had a spa to go to, that set off the dark thoughts. He couldn't say why.

But the dark thoughts – about all the *other* snippets of conversation he'd heard about his wife, hints that she'd had "plenty of practice" at giving blowjobs in cars, the fact that she'd hidden her past from him for so many years, the salacious looks on the faces of the guys at the party, the plethora

of “exes,” the little snorts of laughter – crept into his mind. Dark thoughts mingled with pleasant ones, and as he knelt between Jo’s spread legs, he thought about her sucking on another guy’s cock in the car at the Skinkles.’

And just like all of his perverse fantasy literature, the thought only made his cock harder.

So while he was inside of his wife, Jo Bentley, he pictured TJ with her legs spread wide for Jay, or Chance, or even that volatile Donny Ray character, and then, reverting to his own written fantasy, and sending him over the edge long before he meant to go – he thought of Jo with her lips around the cock of their young, GQ Magazine-type farmhand.

And then he passed out almost right away.

In the morning, Jo was already out at work. There was never any time to sleep in on a farm.

He sat up, his head rolling, and tried to think his way back through the evening. He had plenty of bad feelings about what had happened, mostly because his memory was so foggy, but there was no way of knowing how Jo felt about everything, because she wasn’t there.

He had gone down to the kitchen to make some coffee, hoping that she would be there. He wandered out onto the farm ground, toward the offices and the stables, but when he saw that trucks were there for the horses, he decided to stay inside. Nothing like feeling like a douche-wad, and then looking officially like a douche-wad while guys who knew what they were doing walked around looking like the Marlboro Man to your coffee-mug holding “cidiot.”

So there never ended up being a good time to find out how the conversation had been perceived by Jo. He looked back, just before going into the house, and saw her, tight jeans and plaid shirt, golden hair backlit by the sun, holding onto a rein and smiling next to none other than Caleb.

So, when he climbed the stairs to the attic and sat down at his laptop to try and work, it was no wonder that he ended up working on something other than the Next Great American Novel.

*

She didn’t know what had overcome her. She was taking bigger and bigger risks, and this time it was too far. But she couldn’t stop thinking about him, no matter what she tried. The night before, in the dark with Andy

– she had been the one to initiate sex – she had imagined the very scenario she had made happen the next day. And the sex had been so much better, she had come hard and seen Andy's surprised face in the moonlight as she rode on top of him (something she almost never did).

She had known he would have questions for her afterward, so she had pretended to be asleep. And while she lay there, pretending, she thought about Jake again.

After he had fucked her in the office, after she had felt how thick he was, how hard and constantly ready to go, she had found herself craving him – or maybe not so much him, as sex – in a way she hadn't felt for a very long time. She wanted to feel herself get stretched out by him, up against a wall, her ankles around his solid waist, the veins on his muscled arms bumpy under her palms.

She wasn't so much into oral sex with Andy. What was it about it now...? She had liked it when they were new to each other, but the allure had faded as they got older. Him to her, or vice versa.

So she had no idea, really, what came over her when the house filled up, impromptu-like, with a party. Mindy had come over with an old friend, told Jake to stay, they had sent someone out for beers. Andy had even come down and had a few, they had all gotten drunk together with the farmhands, people called looking for people who were late and she had told everyone to invite whoever they wanted. This was partly to see who Jake invited – a girl? A girlfriend?

But only his brother came.

The party moved to the fire pit. She went back to the house for some more beer. She said it loudly, Jake was looking right at her. She took orders. She said she had to pee like a racehorse, to buy herself some more time.

She hoped that everyone was so drunk they hadn't noticed Jake peeling away into the darkness. She heard him walking at a clip along the fence, out in the dark, where she knew no one could see him if they were by the fire.

She skipped the beer fridge and went straight to the bathroom. When she saw him in the dark hallway she pulled him in, not checking anything outside, anything in the house. Anyone could have been there in the darkness, watching.

She turned on the lights and shook one leg out of her jeans. She was on the countertop in seconds, and that was when she found herself pushing

him down between her legs. She rested her knees on his shoulder and knotted his short hair in her grip, pushing his face into her.

His tongue moved around gracelessly for a few moments, which, if she had to be honest, was something most guys did. He could be forgiven for it, because he was young. She pulled on his hair and moved one hand to her slit, prying her lips apart so that her swollen clit was right where he could not miss it. And then, pushing and pulling him by the hair, she maneuvered him into position. When his tongue at last landed right where she wanted it, she gasped. "That's it, right there."

After that, he was a dream: he lapped at her rhythmically, his eyes watching her when she occasionally tipped her head forward to watch him. He took her quickly to the edge, and she threw her head back and dug her fingers into his shoulder when she came.

He leaned back, staring at her engorged, soaked pussy like it was the first time he was seeing one.

She pulled him up by his hair and ran her tongue over his mouth, licking up her juices. More than anything because she knew it would drive him wild. His cock pulsed against her leg, when she flitted her eyes down to his pants she saw that precum stained his jeans.

The same rush of power overtook her, and she smiled, running her tongue one last time over his upper lip. Leave him waiting, expecting...

It took her by surprise that next, she slid down his body and looked up at him, unbuckling his pants. He stared down at her as she pulled him from his boxers. Was it her imagination, or did her mouth actually water at the thought of getting his cock inside of her mouth?

She squeezed his rock-hard muscle, and his cock bobbed appreciatively. She extended her tongue to swirl around the crown of his dick, surprised by the delight she took in the different taste of him, the pulse of his blood beneath her fingers. He stared at her while she licked up the pearl of precum that had oozed from the center of his glans.

His whole body shook when she made a slow circle around his crown, along the ridge. She looked up at him, smiled, and took him into her mouth, enjoying the power she held over him. His features were tense, his mouth agape, his body shivering.

She didn't know why it felt so good to have him pressed deep against her throat, stretching her mouth open, but she could feel the heat between her legs again. His cock was almost alive in her mouth, and she feared he

would come too soon, so she worked her way back to the tip, and puckering her lips on the crown, stroked him with her hand, running her teeth without biting along the ridge and the face of his glans. He shuddered and his hand went to her hair.

What was she doing? She teased him some more, and it was only just before it actually happened that she realized what she wanted: she wanted to drive him so crazy that he lost control.

His hand was firmly in her hair when he pushed her onto his cock and thrust his hips forward to ram himself deep into her mouth. She made a move to suck the length of him, but he held her there, in place, and moved his hips instead.

He groaned, and then he fucked her a little more, his balls pressing against her chin, the musky scent of his cock filling her nostrils. "Fuck," he whispered. "Oh, Jesus..."

And then his cum – acrid, brackish, normally filthy to her – was filling her mouth. But his cock was so deep in her throat she barely tasted it, and she wanted to suck it right down, anyway. She wasn't sure why; she just did.

She was unaware that her own fingers had migrated from his shaft to her slit, that she was moving her hips up and down and making a purring noise in her throat. The sticky sound of her fingers in her pussy cut through the low pant from deep in his chest and her gagged moans. With his still hard cock and the salty taste of his cum still in her mouth, she screamed a cock-stifled scream, and came again.

She cleaned his cock off with her tongue as she backed away from his hips. To her enormous pleasure, he was motionless, staring at the wall, holding his dick in his hand.

She stood up, shimmying back into her jeans.

They stared at each other. She twisted her hair into a ponytail and wiped the sweat from her neck, swiping her finger over her lips to make sure that no cum had dribbled out of her mouth.

Then she put her ear to the door, turned out the light, and waited a few minutes in the darkness, before whispering, "See you," and ducking into the hallway.

It was reckless. Utterly reckless.

She went back out to the fire, beers in hand, legs trembling. She stood in the smoke. Letting it saturate her clothes to hide the scent of sex.

But for reasons she would never be able to explain to herself, not then, and not later as she thought of it in bed – when it gave her a sick little thrill – she sat down next to her husband, and when Jake wandered back in from the darkness, she leaned in and kissed Andy.

Salty cum still bitter in her own mouth, and all.

Reckless.

CHAPTER 7

Weeks went by, and the farm was busy. Jo was out working all day, and Nate was locked in the attic pretending to work, all day. The same strange wall between them remained: they spoke to each other, but they seemed to be on other sides of the planet.

Nate was having the worst of all possible writer's block, unless he started working on his erotic stories. These flowed from his hands like water, and before he knew what happened, he had a collection of short stories on his hands, almost 60,000 words in total. He couldn't even remember writing so much: that was how in the zone he was.

That was half a literary novel. In some circles, that was a completed novel. And instead of having anything to show for it, he had a bunch of "stroke shorts."

The guilt plagued him worst of all when Jo would come back from a day of work on the farm, dirt brushed here and there on her face or arms, sweat lightly soaked into her clothes, a hard day's work's tiredness in her limbs, and ask him how his day had gone.

So he lied, and told her his day had gone splendidly.

And then, it wasn't long before he had the idea that he should just publish the stories *somewhere*, and then maybe, maybe, he'd earn a little cash off of them, and then he wouldn't be entirely lying when he said he'd gotten plenty done that day.

And with that decision made, he started publishing erotic fiction on Amazon.

Things went on like this for a while.

And then...

*

It all happened just as though it were a story he had written.

Except that he hadn't written it, and it wasn't a story.

Jo was the one who suggested the barbecue (or "cookout," as she would have it.) He was sure the suggestion came from her – and he spent a

good deal of time reflecting on that very issue, later on, when he thought about what had happened.

They had leaves and branches to burn off, and a bonfire would be just the thing. It was the kind of farmy-rural factoid/tradition that Nate could not have invented if he tried, so he knew that Jo *had* to have come up with the idea.

“We need to have a burn,” Jo said casually in the kitchen one morning, pouring herself some sweet tea from a pitcher in the fridge – the drink she’d gone to drinking in the morning, curiously, instead of coffee. “And so I had a mind it’d be nice if we got a cookout goin’ on Friday, and a bonfire. Invite the boys, feed ‘em, seein’s how they’ve been workin’ real hard.”

They were on month four of living in Georgia, and Jo’s accent was just about as Georgia as peaches. She sipped her tea, looking at him. “What d’you think?”

Nate waited, while his mind laboriously translated the chain of consonants, held together entirely by the sound “uh,” that had just left his wife’s mouth. When the translation made its way through his mind, his body went cool with a pleasurable jolt of fear.

A bonfire?

“The boys?”

He got a clammy feeling from the inside out, as anybody does when an element of a fantasy or a nightmare materializes in real life. It was disturbing, but thrilling.

He looked at Jo, who along with a Georgia accent, had developed a new sense of time. Where in Chicago, his taking five minutes to answer a simple question would have sent her flying into a rage of impatience, she was instead sipping her tea as though she had not one other thing to do in the world at the moment but wait for him to answer.

“A bonfire,” Nate said at last.

“A bon-fire,” Jo repeated, reaching toward him to ruffle his hair. “You know what that is.”

“Uh, sure,” Nate said, decidedly unassuredly. “Sure, yeah... whatever you think is best.”

Jo held her glass and moved it in a lazy roll between her fingers, a slight smile at the corner of her mouth. She was looking at him strangely.

Wasn’t she?

Or was she?

“Okay, then,” she said. “Let’s have ourselves a bonfire.”

*

Mandy disappeared into the darkness, and Nate turned back on the gathering around the bonfire.

Okay, it was not like he had imagined at all. For one thing, there was nowhere to sit, as he had imagined, inserting his experiences at camp as a child into his imaginings. This was no campfire. It was a large, dangerous fire, which people were incidentally drinking and eating nearby.

But the gathering had come about much as he had described in his story: beginning with a casual invite, attracting a few more people through some mysterious mechanism, until Mandy Knight and some of her cousins were there, and enough small conversations had started that Jo had disappeared from the circle of light in the field. Mandy had chatted him up in her usual sexual way, and then taken off with a guy Nate had never seen before, in the direction of the now-invisible trucks littering the parking area. Nate blinked, looking around, sparks dotting his vision as he squinted into the patches of people on the edges of the bonfire. He had last seen his wife about ten minutes ago, and then he had lost track of her. She was definitely nowhere near the fire.

He scanned again, his heart rate racing, to be sure that he was seeing correctly.

He stood up, and moved around the fire, hovering around conversations he hadn’t been invited to, eliciting strange looks or raised beer bottles from the people who were talking.

But it was true: he spotted a few of the other workers whose names he knew, but no Caleb.

And nowhere, nowhere to be found: Jo Bentley.

“You know where Jo went?” he asked no one in particular, as he made his way around the circle of the fire. At the beginning, someone had been charged with keeping it under control at all times, but everyone had since lost interest in handing off the responsibility. Nate had asked Jo who was watching the fire as recently as twenty minutes ago and she had looked around and shrugged. “It’s fine,” she had said.

Everyone shrugged off his question about Jo's whereabouts, if they responded at all. Most ignored him and kept on with what they were doing: having a drunk discussion, complaining about taxes, talking horses.

Jo and Caleb were definitely *both* missing.

The eerie similarity to his story crept along his spine as a cool, electric trail.

"I'm goin' up to the house for a beer," Nate suggested, more for himself than anyone. "Anyone need anything?"

Someone kicked a cooler on the opposite side of the fire. "Got some Coors right here, boss."

Nate's mind whirled as he tried to think of something to say to get him out of accepting the Coors while not sounding like a hipster fuck from Chicago. "Gotta piss," occurred to him, but these guys would laugh at that and tell him to piss into the fire.

Help came from an unlikely sort when another male voice bellowed, "He don't drink that Yankee shitwater, Collins. The man wants one of them macro-waved, micro-wave, micro-brews, dontcha? Bring me one-a them, too."

Nate patted this man on the shoulder (recognizing him as a guy named Graham, who sometimes helped out on the farm), and hurried into the darkness before anyone could think much of it, which he was starting to realize was silly. Almost no one was paying any attention to him – or the fire – at all.

As he made his way up to the house, his heart was raw, almost as if he had already seen something terrible.

It just *couldn't* end up like his story, could it? Something like what he had written couldn't *happen*, not like this, not just the way he had written it.

His wife wouldn't really do that, would she?

Would his wife give a blowjob to a guy that young, barely out of his teens?

As he neared the house, he could feel that the electricity inside of him was more desire than dread, more excitement, more thrill, than any feeling he really *should* be having. Even as he was telling himself how awful it would be to find her, he couldn't help but *hope* that he actually did.

He opened the door quietly, and crept along, avoiding creaking boards. He knew where he was going before his mind consciously registered it: he did not turn for the cellar to fetch "one of them micro-

brews,” but instead kept tight next to the wall, headed straight for the bathroom where he had imagined his story taking place. The bathroom in the farthest corner of the house, the one where no one was likely to look. It was dark in that quarter of the house. He almost felt disappointment – could he really be disappointed? - as he kept walking into the darkness anyway. What kind of crazed man did things like this? What did he expect -?

He stopped in the hallway. A brush across the floor, soft, practically inaudible, caught his attention. Then the vibration of a footstep on the sole of his foot. A light creak. A sharp “sssh!”

A low laugh.

The footsteps were nearing him. The house was designed so that there were several ways to get to any of the hallways in the home, most of which connected to the wraparound porch. He froze, staring into the gray darkness, two slashes of shadows across the wall in front of him, as he listened. Were they coming around the corner? Should he stay there and run into them?

He heard a creak, the sound of a door being opened slowly to make less noise.

The faint puff of a light wood door- a screen door, being let snap back from a short distance against the door frame.

Muffled thumps, a creak.

They were on the porch.

Walking so that the floorboards would not creak took a great deal of time, and it was no easy task. It was dark and mostly silent, and his heart was pounding so hard that he had spots in his vision and a tingling in his ears. This was broken only by the hushed sounds from the porch as he approached it.

The picture he would eventually see came to him in fragments, through the sounds he heard. When he finally reached a vantage point where the moonlight spilled in to a patch on the hallway floor and from just beyond it he could see onto the porch, he was not shocked by what he saw.

The inevitability of it had come to him, wave after wave: a giggle and another hiss to hush that could only be his wife’s voice. The sound of a zipper. The gasp of a man. A silence interrupted only by a sucking sound, the very kind that could originate only from one action.

So when he finally saw the scene on the back porch, the part of the house that no one would ever go to, except for something like this: his wife, on her knees, her face unmistakable in the silver moonlight, her mouth stretched open and stuffed full of meat, her head bobbing back and forth, and Caleb Knight looking down at her with his mouth open like an idiot – he did not fall over.

He just stared.

And watched, his own cock thickening as his insides plummeted through his feet and his whole body went deliciously cold.

Jo, his beautiful wife, was on her knees on the porch, her hands pushing up Caleb's shirt so that his muscled torso was on display beneath her fingers, his abdomen rippling slightly as she worked on him. She moved with an expertise that was shocking, and that snippet of conversation he had begun thinking he hadn't even heard at the Skinkles' party surfaced in his mind: the allusion to the fact that Jo was some kind of blowjob expert.

There was a room, used now as a catch-all for junk and whose real purpose Nate could only guess at, that extended onto the porch and caused it to jut out, just beyond where Jo and Caleb were. Nate looked at the window, his gut behaving much like a lava lamp, rising and falling as he stared at the scene in front of him, unable to believe it was real.

It was as though he were outside of his body when he started to move, walking quickly but softly, so as not to be heard, to the junk room, where he could stand in the shadows with a better view of the scene on the porch. The only space he could stand easily enough to have a view was in the middle of the room, with nothing to lean on, and while he knew that the darkness hid him from their sight, he was sure that he would be seen any moment, gaping at his wife giving Caleb a blowjob.

A real-life cuckold.

He was a cuckold. The realization seared his soul, and yet also pulsed through his iron-hard cock. His wife was on her knees with another man's dick in her mouth.

He stared at their moonlight-tinted flesh. Where he stood the view left nothing to the imagination: his wife's cheeks puffed slightly each time she swallowed Caleb's flesh right up to his straw-colored pubic hair, her chin against his balls.

Then his hand shot to her head, and his jaw fell open slightly more, and Nate saw his abdomen ripple involuntarily. He threw his head back,

banging it loudly on the side of the house, and Jo's fingers sank into his stomach. But she swallowed him to the hilt, leaving nothing to the imagination: Caleb Knight's seed was gushing into his wife's throat, and she was swallowing it all.

"FFFFfffff-" Caleb finally intoned, both his hands on her hair now, trying to push her away from his cock. Whatever Jo was doing, she intended to do it with his cock still twitching in her mouth, and it was driving Caleb wild.

Jo leaned back on her heels, and brought her hand to his still-twitching cock.

As though coming out of a trance suddenly, Caleb stared at her for a moment and then looked wildly around. When his head turned in the direction of Nate's hiding place, Nate's chest went thrillingly icy, and his blood pounded even harder than it already was.

Caleb rushed to zip up his pants. Jo rose to her feet. Nate noticed that she brought a finger to her mouth, and wiped her lips as though her lipstick had smeared.

"You think he heard us?" Caleb asked, clearly torn between the allure of the woman in front of him, and the danger of getting caught by her husband.

Jo's voice purred. "Now, whad'yuh think?"

Reckless.

Nate's heart felt crushed, but his cock pulsed, so hard now that he knew he would have to jerk off in the bathroom as soon as this tableau played out.

Caleb gave a nervous laugh. He brought his hands to Jo's hips. "That sure was a surprise," he said, almost lamely. "I never... that was, uh -"

Jo, as they had been standing there, had slipped her hand into her jeans. It was only as she brought that same hand up to Caleb's lips, that Nate realized she had dipped into her pussy juices. Caleb's voice dribbled away to silence. Jo's fingers went inside Caleb's mouth.

Jo pressed herself against him, and whispered something in his ear, which made Caleb's body go stiff for a moment. Nate closed his eyes slowly, drained of energy suddenly. When he opened them Jo was walking away slowly, her feet loud on the porch, evidently convinced that "he" (and that could only be Nate) was no longer there.

Caleb followed.

Nate remained rooted to the floor, his heart beating so fast and with such fury that it sounded like he was standing next to a waterfall, which disoriented him enough that he felt he could not step through the junk in the junk room to get to the door and see where they went.

He should march up to them, confront his wife, slug the kid (it's not like he didn't know she was married), and then...

And then what?

But he didn't want to do any of those things. He heard a door click shut, and the realization that Jo had taken Caleb into the bathroom poured over him like slow-moving tar, scorching him inch by inch. Too much like his book. Unreal.

All he wanted to do, though, was step into the hallway and walk down to the bathroom. Was she in there, getting Caleb's cock hard again? Or was he already ready to go, and was she as well, bent over the tiled countertop, jeans at her ankles, ass thrust back, glistening pussy lips framed by her sculpted thighs, with Caleb's cock inching nearer to her hole with each passing second?

He sidestepped the junk carefully and stepped into the hallway. Light spilled from under the bathroom door.

He could stand there, listening, and then stay there, so that when they opened the door, he would be staring right at them.

The fright it would give them both made his lip twitch with the beginnings of a smile, in spite of himself.

He was at the door now, and from beneath the door he could hear the ragged breath of a woman. Jo. His wife, panting heavily. And a sticky noise.

A breathy whisper, the words impossible for him to figure out.

A slam, maybe an ankle jerking against the wood cupboards, one time only, and then the beginning of a shriek, quickly muffled by someone's flesh.

Heavier breathing, Jo's.

Silence.

Nate was determined, until the moment he heard them moving again behind the door, to stand there and show them both that they were caught. He was not sure what mechanism moved his feet, backward and into the dark corridor, away from the bathroom door, and back to the junk room. He stepped to the right just as the strip of light from under the door yawned open into a pool, and a figure emerged from the bathroom.

A few minutes passed. He could still hear Jo in the bathroom: the figure he had glimpsed was too bulky to be her. Water turned on and off. She opened and closed some doors.

Nate's insides were on fire. His face burned, jealousy and anger clawed inside of him. Covering her tracks, the fucking bitch?

Because she *was* a bitch, wasn't she? A bitch who would fuck – or at least suck off – a guy in her own house? In his mind, he strode down the hallway and stood in the doorway and stared at her until she cried, and then turned her around and fucked her cheating, cum-filled hole raw.

But he did none of those things. Because as much as the flames of jealousy lapped at his heart, there was another force that kept him still: his desire, no, his *obsession*, with seeing how the rest of the evening would play out.

Jo's footsteps retreated into the house, and distantly, the screen door slapped against the wood after being opened. Nate walked unsteadily to the bathroom and locked himself in, jerking off over the toilet and coming within seconds, the image of Jo's stretched lips around Caleb's cock in the faint moonlight like a veil over his eyes.

He barely remembered the walk back to the bonfire. It was an orange orb in the field of black, a light cloud-cover obscuring the light of the moon and casting the world into occasional pitch-blackness. There was just enough light, and just enough alcohol in his system, to guide him through the field along the utility path and then over to the bonfire.

Nothing about the scene except who was in it seemed to have changed. Jo was talking to Mandy, and neither looked in the least bit ruffled. Nate had a fleeting thought that perhaps he was going totally crazy, imagining all of this, and that his wife and Mandy had never left the ring around the fire.

Caleb was not there, and somehow Nate knew he would not come back.

He wandered into the circle of light. Graham asked him where the beer was, And Nate mumbled that there wasn't any. Someone handed him a Coors. He listened in on a conversation about tractors, his skin on fire from within, for a few minutes. Jo's presence, deliberately oblivious to him on the opposite side of the fire, radiated more heat than the flames.

He looked over at her, and caught her eye. Her mouth stopped moving, and she smiled.

She *waved* at him.

The picture of her face through the flames, smiling at him as she did, would remain forever in his mind, Nate decided.

She looked so... ordinary. Like herself. Her smile seemed so real, so genuine.

In fact, there was nothing at all about the way she was looking at him, waving at him, returning to her conversation with Mandy – who did not look over at him, and therefore was not being told about Jo's escapades – to indicate that there was anything unusual going on.

Jo, for all observable facts, had a completely clear conscience about what she had just done.

Nate walked slowly toward her, a Coors in his hand.

Jo had a microbrew in hers, which she lifted to explain she didn't want the Coors. "Lord," she said casually, looking at the can of Coors. "Who the hell gave you that swill, Jimmy?"

"It's okay," Nate said, making Jo raise her eyebrows.

But not a flicker of worry, not a trace of remorse, flickered on her face.

"You sure were gone a long time," Nate prodded. He wasn't sure why he was doing it, it just intrigued him to test her. How far would Jo wade in? How good of a liar was she?

"Had to dig real deep for these," she said, without batting an eye.

"There's more over there, brought 'em back with me."

"Huh," Nate said. "I'll finish this first."

He studied Jo's face. She had a funny smile on her lips as she looked at him.

His insides boiled.

"How long these things usually go?" Nate asked.

Jo looked at the fire. "'till she's out," she said. "Why?"

"Just curious."

Mandy was already wandering away. Nate felt drunker than he could have possibly been, or at least impaired. He scrutinized his wife as she turned toward the fire and watched it, the orange glow lighting up her face. It was impossible to tell if she was flushed, or if the brown mascara she used to highlight her pale eyelashes had smeared ever-so-slightly. There was nothing about her appearance or her demeanor that would have caused him to suspect that anything of the sort he had just witnessed had happened.

For a second, he felt as though the world shifted: had he actually witnessed what he had witnessed? His heart was still pounding, his nerves still raw, his cock pulsing with renewed excitement, a dull ache still gripping his balls, the spent-out feeling of having just come being replaced by fresh desire. He was sure of all that.

But as he stood there watching Jo, it all seemed as unbelievable as a dream.

She sensed that he was staring at her. She turned, and cocked her head slightly, a smile on her lips. For a moment it seemed as though she were reading his mind, something he knew in his heart was impossible. The smile she gave him seemed like a grin of complicity. His heart thumped against his chest.

The moment to say something to her was then. But what would it have been? *Did you just suck Caleb's cock on our back porch? I thought I saw something just now, back in the house...?*

While one part of his mind worked on the problem of *what* to say, exactly, Jo moved closer to him, her smile holding his body and the rest of his mind spellbound, until her lips were inches from his and every other thought but the thought of her mouth was squeezed from his head.

The same spell held him still when she kissed him, her full, plump lips dry and warm, her tongue racing over his upper lip just before she closed in on him. A delicious shiver ran down his spine, and he pushed forward to meet her kiss. In that moment, he forgot to explore the taste of her because her hand wandered to his cock, brushing over it and eliciting a smile that he could only feel in the shape of her mouth.

"Hmmm," she purred, and smiled at him again. Her hand gave him a squeeze, and then she stepped away, smiling, and brought her beer to her lips.

He hadn't breathed in those moments, and his lungs ached. The gulp of fresh air that filled him connected his story to what had just happened, and he closed his lips, trying in vain to identify the taste in his mouth.

It was alcohol: hops, something stronger than beer, and beneath it, a minty flavor.

The scene was frozen for a moment: there was no one in the world but the two of them, his wife looking at him with that dangerous smile. The thoughts in his head swirled as though picked up by a cyclone: he could not separate the story he had written from the events of the evening, his

jealousy from his desire. At the base of his thoughts he knew he needed a plan of some kind, but before he could think of what to do, the scene was shattered.

Sparks exploded on the other side of the fire, the sound of rolling, crushing burnt wood, laughter, and shouts cracked open the quiet, and a human figure rolled on the ground. “Dammit!”

Jimmy, too drunk, had tripped on the cooler and fallen partially into the fire. No one had reacted except to stand back and laugh at him while he rolled on the ground, and he appeared uninjured when he stood up and brushed himself off, as well as when everyone slapped him playfully on the back and teased him.

“All right,” Jo said. “Someone falls in the fire, it’s time for y’all to go home. Someone able to drive Jimmy here home?”

And the next hour or so consisted of the party dispersing. The moment had come and gone.

Caleb never reappeared, and Jo never said anything about him being missing.

“I gotta stay out here until this thing is out,” Jo told him. “Go grab some more beers and a blanket.”

His blood filled with red-hot venom for a few seconds, and the sound of cicadas seemed to grow so loud it would deafen him. He was certain that he was going to blow, but for some reason he did not.

Instead, he fetched the blankets and the beers.

Jo tended the fire, throwing a few more things into it, before sitting down next to him on the blanket.

“I’m sort of glad everyone is gone,” she purred.

He was silent. His heart and part of his mind clamored for him to confront her, his palms itched to strangle her, and his cock was so hard that he felt sick.

But which part of him was going to win, in the end, anyway? It’s always a foregone conclusion, he thought, almost miserably, as Jo climbed onto his lap and the last vestiges of rational thought were wrung from his brain. She pushed his face into her tits, and then they were clawing wildly at each other.

It was the best sex they’d had since they’d come to Sayville.

What could you make of that?

CHAPTER 8

Nate stared at the empty Word document on his screen. Beneath that tab was another, filled with words, and he knew he should probably hide it away so that he wasn't tempted to add anything to it.

He looked over the edge of his open computer. The pasture was empty today: the horses were on the other side of the farm, and so were all the workers.

Jimmy.

A few other guys.

His wife.

Caleb.

Since the night of the bonfire, he'd been unable to think about anything except the night of the bonfire, and his wife, and their marriage. He had picked apart the hazy memories of the evening, and re-read his own story, over and over again, until he could no longer separate fact from fiction. At times he was convinced that he had witnessed nothing: the whole scenario had been a deliciously realistic fantasy. And then there were times that he could not deny that it must have really happened: dreams did not contain minty flavors, or the feel of wet panties; he never came in a dream, his skin was never clawed.

And yet all of those details could be there, in real life, without the scene he had witnessed in the back of the house ever really happening at all.

So had it?

It was so close to what had happened in his story. This similarity lent unbelievably to the sequence. And yet somehow the events seemed almost more believable, for deviating ever-so-slightly from his story. Like a poor memory. His memory was poor: he'd had to read the story he'd written again to remember if Samantha (his character, modeled precisely on Jo) had sucked the farmboy's cock before or after letting him eat her out in the bathroom. Could the inconsistencies just be his own bad memory, and the whole thing imagined?

Unable to decide 100% for certain if he had dreamed the whole thing or not was only half of the reason Nate didn't speak to his wife about it.

The other was the 'what if?'

What if everything had happened just the way he had envisioned?
What if he asked his wife about it? What if she lied to him?

Or what if she cried, and asked for forgiveness, and stopped?

Nate rubbed his forehead and typed on his computer.

What do you want?

He had written the fantasy, after all, because he *liked* the idea of his wife fucking another guy.

The *idea*, he reminded himself. Liking an idea didn't necessarily mean liking something in the real world, something that actually happened.

He wanted to be angry enough with her to confront her. He wanted to have the balls to be angry at her if she denied it, or said she didn't care.

But something held him back, like the reins of a horse. Every time he felt his nerve gathering in his chest, he would walk downstairs, playing out the scene and the aftermath in his mind.

Once there, though, he would be gripped by an even stronger hand, and find himself torn, standing in the kitchen, breathing like a 70-year-old, his whole body numb with cold.

He didn't *want* to confront her.

In fact, truth be told, he wanted to catch her again. Even though her infidelity burned like swallowed gasoline, he wanted to see her do it again.

*

"How's your book coming along?" Jo asked one morning. "You have anything ready for me to read?"

Nate froze, his hand in midair. Jo continued working at the counter, trimming vegetables for the salad she'd prepared to accompany the farmhands' nasty sandwiches.

When he didn't answer, she rotated and looked at him with raised eyebrows. "That bad, huh?" she asked. It was a gentle, managerial question, designed not piss him off.

Still, he said nothing, because his chest seemed to have ossified.

"Writer's block?" she asked, turning back to the window and biting into a carrot with a clean snap.

Nate sipped his coffee. "Sort of," he managed to say.

He stared at his wife. She was leaning against the counter, swaying from side to side to get a better look at something.

Nate cleared his throat and played with the coffee mug. “I was thinking of maybe going into town,” he said. “Sort of get my creativity going by doing something different.”

Jo turned back to him, and she seemed a little alarmed by the idea. “Into town?” she repeated. Then she smiled. “Whadya suppose you’re goin’ to do there?”

Nate shrugged. “I don’t know. Buy some feed or some boots, I guess. Have a pint.”

Jo popped a grape into her mouth and laughed just before she crushed it. “Don’t go in there callin’ it a pint, though.”

“It says ‘pint’ on the menu.”

Jo rolled her eyes. “That’s for tourists who miss I-75 and have to come through here,” she said. She shook her head in mock severity. “Don’t say that here.”

Nate was grateful, on the one hand, for moments like these, when their friendly marital banter seemed more like it had back in Chicago. This – minus the wardrobe and the folksy accent – was the woman he was married to back in Chicago. It was as if they were visiting for a short time, and for a moment he could pretend that this was just an extended vacation, and they would go back to Chicago in three days and everything would be normal again.

As if none of this had ever happened.

But just as quickly as one of these conversations erupted and felt familiar enough to distort their reality, the feeling would evaporate, and the weight pressing on his chest would return. Every gesture, every twitch of her face, every word his wife said, was up for scrutiny, possibly sinister, possibly a lie.

“I’m taking the car,” Nate said.

Jo sliced two pieces of carrot with deliberate movements in a silence that felt like floodwater. The sound of the blade on the cutting board was foreboding.

Then she waved her hand carelessly. “Have at it. I have a ton of work to do here, else I’d go with you.”

She was turned away from him, so he couldn’t see her expression. She was standing with her erect, dancer’s posture – the posture he knew now must have come from actually dancing, from cheerleading, from being an actual queen, even if it was just of a backwoods country high school.

Her jeans had gotten a little loose. Not much, just a little: all the work and the riding had made her forget meals, toned her muscles, especially her thighs. Her hair was lighter from constant sun, twisted up carelessly on her head, her skin a sexy tan that had fought its way to the surface in spite of her sunscreen. She seemed to have given up since the freckles appeared, a smattering across her cheeks and nose, almost too faint to see. Her appearance had gone from corporate to country music album cover.

She picked up the tray of sandwiches. "I'm runnin' these out, so we can get back at it and call it an early day."

She pushed herself through the swinging door. "Feed store closes at five," she said, looking right at him. "Case you're actually going there."

Nate stared at her as she disappeared from the frame of the door and down the driveway to the stables.

His mind was on fire. His wife, before now, had usually done all she could to prevent him from going into town by himself.

Was she acting like she just had because she *wanted* him gone, more than she wanted him to be quarantined from the rest of the town?

The possibility was there, Nate thought, that her secret – the secret of being a cheerleader – was out now, and she didn't care anymore if he went into town and found out about it. Maybe there was nothing more to her past than that, nothing more than a silly thing she was outsizedly embarrassed about, because it didn't fit with the persona she'd created for him.

His heart fell, though, suddenly and violently: but what about the porch? What about her slut mouth around Caleb's cock?

So was she willing to let him go to town because she wanted to fuck that guy while he was gone?

In his stomach, jealousy moved around, cold and slimy. The feeling was strangely delicious, even though he knew it shouldn't be.

And it was that feeling, that savory cold pain-pleasure, that made him rise from the table, climb upstairs, collect his laptop, and take it out to the car.

He looked over at the stables: there were four workers here today. Caleb's chiseled figure was easy to spot as he walked out to the pasture. Joe was standing by the office door talking to an older guy. The others were going about their business.

Just an ordinary day on the farm, Nate told himself.

He hoped.

Or did he?

CHAPTER 9

“Well, look who it is. Mr. Chicago.”

Nate’s heart sank. He had pictured The Laughing Goat as empty as the last time he’d been here, and because it was nearly the middle of the day, on a Thursday, he’d had no reason to think it would be otherwise. Mandy was behind the bar, drying a glass, and he was glad to see her, as much as she unnerved him. She didn’t seem to have it out for him one way or the other, she was just impish. She continued drying her glass without greeting him, but her eyes twinkled.

Seated at the bar, the speaker was one of the guys from the party at Skinkles, one who had been in the conversation on the porch. A lot of the guys looked alike, so Nate couldn’t put a name to the face, but he was sure he’d seen him there. His eyes were black and set close together, his features had that distinctively country look, and he seemed unstable to Nate. The two guys on his flank Nate could not be sure he had seen before, but they looked at him with distrustful disinterest.

“Guys,” Nate said in dry greeting, again summoning his not-too-cool and not-too-uncool accent.

The black-eyed man leaned his arm on the back of his stool. “Mandy, buy my friend Nathan here a beer for me, will you? Nate, have a seat. Where’s your wife?”

He said the word “wife” with a peculiar tone, and one of his buddies smiled knowingly before tipping his beer into his mouth.

“That mean you want me to buy it for you, Donny Ray. Because if it does, I reckon Mr. Bentley here can buy his own,” Mandy said, with the tone that all bartenders everywhere in the world use for a drunk who spends too much money to be kicked out of the bar, but they’d just as soon see pass out.

Mandy looked at Nate and smiled, giving her chin a lift in greeting. “What can I do you for?”

“That’s right,” Donny Ray muttered at the same time. “Chicago here has Chicago dollars.”

Nate sat down at the short end of the L-shaped bar, close to the three men but with a corner between them. Donny Ray glared at him and the

other two stared at the bar top. The tension could be cut with a knife.

“Uh... what’s Donny Ray having?” Nate asked.

Mandy leaned two hands on the bar, palms forward. Her breasts pressed attractively against her t-shirt, revealing more of the shape of them: they were heavy, mango-shaped and sized, real breasts that were just large enough to droop a little, but in a pleasant way. She had no bra on, and her nipples pointed just slightly out toward her ribs. Nate found it impossible not to steal a few glances at her magnificent chest. The shirt she was wearing left an inch of bare skin between her jeans and the hem, and her smooth, almond-toasted skin was supple and bright.

“Donny Ray is having himself the bottom of my nastiest keg, because he’s a drunk and he can’t buy nothin’ better.” Mandy delivered this with just the right blend of humor and seriousness, indicating it was true but she also liked this about Donny Ray. She wiped the table. “I recommend Sweet Springs Rye.”

“I’ll have that.”

Nate’s lips were poised to say “buy one for Donny Ray, too,” but he stopped himself short. Donny Ray seemed like the kind of guy who would take a classy move like that the wrong way, and it would all end in a bar fight.

“Where’s your wife?” Donny Ray repeated loudly.

Mandy had taken Donny Ray’s beer glass and poured a little more into it. She set it down with a thump. “She’s out on her farm, working, like all the decent folk do around here, Donny Ray.”

She started to pour Nate’s beer.

“I ain’t never been accused,” Donny Ray said loudly, pointing his finger at Nate, “of bein’ decent.”

Mandy snorted. “Ain’t nobody in here been accused of *that*.”

Mandy set Nate’s beer down in front of him with a complicit smile, and he looked down at it just as Donny Ray said, too loudly again, and just a few beats too long after Mandy’s quip for it to not sound sinister: “Your *wife* neither, ‘Chicago.’ Hear that?”

Nate sighed.

He had paid his way through his degree – well, his drinking tab, anyway – tending bar, so he knew there was nothing you could do about a drunk like Donny Ray, except try not to start a fight.

“I hear that,” he said agreeably, lifting his beer. “Cheers.”

This threw Donny Ray temporarily off-balance, because he had clearly pinned his fighting hopes on Nate reacting differently. He had his glass half-lifted before he thought of something new to say.

“Cheers,” he said huffily. “That some kind of Chicago thing?”

“Guess so. What do you guys say here?” Nate asked, as jovially as possible.

“Nothin,” Donny Ray said grumpily, unamused at being deflected again, but clearly too drunk to think his way out of it. But his eyes lit up as he tried again: “So where’s your wife at, Chicago?”

“Donny Ray, I swear,” Mandy said, popping under the bar to reach for something, or perhaps as a pretext for getting out of the way of what seemed to be an unavoidable fistfight.

“So, Donny Ray, I’m glad you’re here,” Nate said, trying to get the man on a drunken upswing again. “Because I’ve been *meaning* to get the gossip on my wife.”

The man seated next to Nate snapped to attention, while Donny Ray looked confused. The third whistled half of a low whistle, but cut himself off.

The tension in the room was palpable. Mandy looked up over the edge of the bar, remaining below it, and her eyes were lit up by the same mischievous glitter that Nate had noticed at the party.

“Now which gossip’s that?” Donny Ray said, confused again by Nate’s amicable demeanor, but intrigued enough to lean his elbows on the counter. He was still itching for a fight, somewhere inside of him.

Nate slammed a full half of his beer and was grateful Mandy had saved him the trouble of remembering not to say “pint” by serving him in an extra-large glass.

“Well,” he said. “You know, gossip. Stuff from back in the day. Jo never told me much about her life here in Sayville.”

Mandy stood up, smiling at the excitement, to confide to Donny Ray: “TJ, he means.”

Good old Mandy. Wouldn’t want a conversation like this to derail because of a mix-up, Nate thought.

Donny Ray harrumphed, and like all good drunks, had a mood swing that made him suddenly despondent.

“Ain’t my business to say,” he declared, after giving the matter a second’s worth of thought.

The comment elicited a round of quashed laughter from everyone – including Donny Ray – but Nate.

Nate took another sip of his beer and shrugged. He wanted Donny Ray to say, of course, but he had mainly set his sights on calming him down, which appeared to have worked.

Quite suddenly, Donny Ray's mood soured and he became serious. He shoved the now-empty beer glass very nearly to the edge of the bar, and Mandy's hand shot out to stop it before it fell inward at her. "Let's git," he said loudly.

The two men with him sighed, drank what they could of their beers, and heaved themselves from the barstools, while Mandy picked up a glass she had already dried and began to polish it casually, a faint smile on her lips. "That's thirty y'all owe me Donny Ray, and you got a tab goin', so you'd best have it in mind next time you come round."

Donny Ray tossed a ten on the bar, glaring at Nate as he said, "That there's your tip."

"Want my tab," Mandy called, but she waited until they were all shuffling for the door before she said it. When they were out, she shot a hand out for the ten without looking away from Nate, that same smile on her lips. She walked the bill to the cash register. The drawer slammed open and she deposited it, kicking it back with her hip. "Thank you kindly, gettin' *him* outta my hair."

Nate turned to the door to verify they were gone.

"He seems like a real fun regular," he said, turning back.

Mandy shrugged. "Gotta take what you can get 'round here." She pointed at Nate's beer. "That one's on me, for keepin' im calm."

Her eyes were glittering still.

Nate picked up his beer.

"What *are* you doin' down here by yourself?" Mandy asked, after a moment of silence. She leaned on the bar, and Nate would have called it seductively, though it just seemed to be the way Mandy did things.

"Just had to get out," Nate said.

Mandy took a towel and began wiping at nothing on the bar. Nate stole another glance at her t-shirt, his low abdomen uneasy suddenly – not with attraction to Mandy, but with the proximity to the secrets of his wife, the sexual energy that Mandy exuded acting like a flame to his mixed emotions.

“So TJ never talked about Sayville none, then,” Mandy began, giving her work on the bar intense scrutiny at the same time her voice was coquettish.

Nate sipped his beer. “Not really,” he said. He could see that Mandy enjoyed a good tease, so he was going to let her take her time. “You know I didn’t even know she was a cheerleader?”

Mandy couldn’t help herself: her eyes shot up at him. She had her mouth formed into an expression of surprise, but he could see in her eyes that she was excited by the prospect of spilling the beans. “No kidding,” she declared. “That’s... something.”

Nate leaned forward, as though confiding with her. “What was it, Donny Ray meant, by it isn’t his place to say?”

Mandy’s mouth fluttered, her excitement to tell the secrets boiling beneath her skin as she tried to maintain a pious expression. “Oh, now, that’s just Donny Ray...” her voice trailed off and she fluttered her eyes as her hand moved the towel around.

God, Nate thought. She was a stage actress if he ever saw one.

“Oh, come on, now, Mandy. You know what he was getting at, I’m sure of it. You’re the bartender in this town, aren’t you?”

Mandy looked at him, and she couldn’t stop herself from leaning forward and grinning. “Used to be the hairdresser, too. I can tell you just about anything,” she said proudly. “But...” she stood back. She gave her head a much-too-woeful shake, which was right about the time Nate realized he was going to hear everything he wanted to hear, and possibly more. “It really isn’t my place to say, you know, if TJ hasn’t...”

“Look,” Nate said. “Eventually someone’ll get around to telling me whatever it is, right?”

“That’s true,” Mandy agreed, much too quickly.

“Might as well be you.”

This was all Mandy needed. She leaned forward on her elbows and began to talk, her sentences interrupted by strangely placed smiles that seemed to have nothing to do with what she was saying. “Well,” she began. “What Donny Ray was probably gettin’ at, it not bein’ *his* place to say, is that he and TJ used to be... not so much an item, like sweethearts or nothin,’ as just... close. I don’t want to be ugly, but you understand what I’m gettin’ at, right?”

Nate believed he did, so he nodded. “That’s to be expected,” he said evenly. “It’s a small town.”

Mandy smiled, standing upright. “You have no idea how small,” she said.

“So that’s it? Jo slept with Donny Ray.”

Mandy’s eyes twinkled, as she enjoyed holding on to her secret for some time. “Well, Nathan – and you just as soon as could have heard this from pretty much anyone around here, so if it’s somethin’ that comes up, I’d love it if you could keep a damper on where it came from, and you know I’m the last person to judge this kind of thing, but TJ? She was somethin’ of a real wild girl back in the day.”

“Real wild?” Nate asked.

“Wild. You know. *Wild*. She liked to party, and she...” Mandy looked up at the ceiling, as though searching for a word. “Well,” Mandy declared. “Let’s just say there are not too many people in this town who might not think it’s not their place to say something about your wife.”

Mandy swept at the bar again, her face aglow with the fun of having divulged a secret that was probably going to whip around like a storm, trying her best to feign remorse and failing terribly. Nate worked his way through the slew of negatives, which took so long that Mandy was talking again by the time he figured out that her convoluted sentence meant that almost everyone in town had fucked his wife.

“It’s a small town,” she said. She looked seriously at Nate. “That’s just how things are. Hell,” she whispered, looking behind her as though someone might be eavesdropping. “I done slept with everyone in this town at least three times. But I feel like... I feel like it ‘ain’t right you not knowin’ what everyone’s sniggering about. You know.”

She wiped the bar, pretending to be remorseful. “If TJ didn’t tell you.” She finished her confession quietly, her whole face cast in a somber expression, but she could not keep the gleam of intrigue and delight from twitching at the corners of her mouth and glistening in her eyes.

Nate’s body was having one of those cold, freeze-over moments that he couldn’t decide if he hated or loved. It wasn’t as if this tidbit of information had really floored him: the signs were easy enough to read all along. What he actually wanted, he realized, was *detail*. He wanted to hear about the specific, sordid details of his wife’s former sluttiness.

Former. But it wasn’t “former” sluttiness, was it?

Nate remembered the whole reason he had come down here: to have a single beer and then return to the farm, hoping to catch Jo doing something illicit with her boy-toy Caleb. He had fantasized about it, he had written about it, and though it seemed perfectly ridiculous – almost mystical – to think this way, he almost believed that by writing about it, he could make it happen.

He paid his tab. Mandy leaned on the bar and put a hand suggestively on her hip, her breasts thrust forward, and gave her hair a toss. She chewed her lip in the most fake display of nervousness and the most porno-like way Nate had ever seen a real woman do. “Now, you won’t run off and tell TJ that I’m the one who done told you?” she pleaded.

What a package, Nate thought. She half-wanted him to, half-desired the excitement. Nate supposed there wasn’t much else to do in Sayville for a girl like Mandy, who was clearly too clever for here, but not clever enough to leave, but to stir things up and watch the fireworks.

Nate mimed zipping his lips, which elicited a smile and a thank-you from Mandy, laid over a very obvious sea of disappointment.

The car was stifling hot – he hadn’t learned to leave the windows down, which was a foolish thing to do anywhere he’d ever lived, but par for the course in Sayville. The heat delivered a blow to him, and he sat for a minute with the door open, his face getting red from the outside as well as inside.

Had his wife been this duplicitous in every aspect of their marriage, he wondered? If she had been a raging slut in Sayville, he could forgive that, pretty much. But now it called into question everything she had ever done. Every night she had worked late, every company trip, everything.

Or had she just turned back into the person she was because she had come back to this place?

Nate put his hand against the vent to make sure the air-conditioning was working. He pulled the door closed.

And what was his wife doing right now, at home, alone on the farm with her husband gone? He looked at the clock. It was only 4:30 pm.

He drove a long way home, knowing he would likely get lost. Cellphone coverage was spotty, and the roads were winding, laid out on a grid that morphed to the landscape of rivers and foothills. He didn’t want to get lost out in the country in Georgia – it seemed like he could easily be caught in a real-life horror film like *Wrong Turn* – but his desire to arrive

after work had wrapped up, after some of the workers had gone home, superseded his instinct for self-preservation.

He did get lost, but easily found himself by sticking to right turns only. One long dirt road came to an unannounced end at a frightening abandoned house, which set his adrenaline going, but in the end he arrived back at Seymore Farms around 5:20pm.

He parked at the end of the driveway near the entrance and the front pastures. Even though it was his own mind that had been at work on it, he was mildly surprised by how much forethought he had put into sneaking up to the house without driving: he had seen something in the fields, he would tell Jo, if he got caught. And gone out to investigate. He had found himself close to the house and gone in for a drink of water before the long walk back up.

Why had he gone so far into the pastures?

“It was just such a pleasant day, I decided to go for a walk” he said aloud, walking through the hay, which was not pleasant at all. Deceptively silky in appearance from a distance, it was scratchy and uneven, thorny and awful to walk through. Nate was wearing shorts, and now saw why all the help and Jo wore jeans, even in the stifling heat. He was sweating buckets halfway down the hill, headed past a mound of field that would obscure his arrival from the stables and the office, which was where, he realized, he was already certain that Jo would be.

The whole endeavor seemed completely ridiculous to him by the time he could see the house again and had to haul himself uphill. He was drenched, parched, scratched up, and incredibly stupid. The buzz of his beer had long since worn off, the idea that Jo would buy his excuse for walking so far through a field in this heat was preposterous, and the idea that his wife would be exactly where he had placed her in a fictional erotic story, just because he was hoping she would be was – well, even more preposterous.

What the hell was wrong with him?

Why would he want to catch his wife fucking Caleb anyway?

What was he going to do if they were?

He entered the house through the back entrance his wife had used to get Caleb alone with her on the porch. His insides twisted with perverse delight as he stepped over the place on the porch where she had knelt. His

cock pulsed, thickening against the confinement of his underwear and shorts.

The house was empty, the air stale and hot. Jo turned the central air in the main house all but completely off, allowing it to heat up to 80 before anything kicked in, while he worked in the attic, where there were no vents. It was all part of her plan to save the farm, one sweltering penny at a time. It was still cool to Nate, who knew his face was red with heat by now. Sweat dripping down his temples as he stepped through the house, ears perked for the slightest noise.

But not really. Jo wouldn't come in here, would she? Somehow he sensed that she would not, that if his wild fantasies were being somehow made real through a magic of the universe he did not understand, then his wife would be where he had written about her. It was absurd, but it propelled him through the house as though it were a certainty.

The door caught on a breeze as he exited. The driveway and the area near the stables were like a ghost town. Some chickens squawked as they skittered across the dirt.

From beyond the stable and the office building – the first house built on the farm a million years ago – there was a low, droning machine noise. As he walked closer to the buildings, a red truck emerged from behind the house into Nate's field of vision. There were two workers on it. They were far out in the field, doing god knows what.

No sign of Jo.

No sign of Caleb.

He walked up to the shabby porch leading into the office. His groin was aching, his stomach cold and fiery at once, and he shuddered at himself, noting that he had done it quietly, to go unnoticed, to walk on in and catch his wife in the act.

He moved slowly to reach for the screen door, and then turn the knob of the wooden door, without making a sound. His ears were attuned to the machinery in the distance, vaguely wondering what they could be doing out there, and why, and marveling at how this scene so adroitly added up the way he had written it.

He held his breath, and the ache swirled inside him as he stood there, with his hand on the door. He listened for sounds, some telltale sign.

What if he caught her? What if he opened the door and she was there, just as he had written about her, legs wrapped around Caleb's taut, muscled

body, his shaft squelching in and out of her pussy, a puddle building beneath her on the wood floor.

The smell of this imaginary sex act rose up inside his nostrils, almost real enough to believe.

He pushed the door open gently, just a crack.

He peered through the crack, his heart falling as it became clear that there was no one inside. His ears confirmed it: no rustling, no hushed whispers. The scent that reached his nose was of dust and mold. He let the door swing wide open.

A fan oscillated on the table. When Nate closed the office door, to turn on the air conditioning, the whump of it annoyed him, changing the pressure in his ears.

He collapsed into an old, torn office chair and leafed aimlessly through some papers on the desk. He felt strange – disappointed, and relieved, and ashamed of himself. He leaned his head back on the chair, marveling at the fact that he had actually had it in his head, so clearly he could taste it, that he was going walk in on -

There was a loud thump, followed by a scrambling set of thumps, above his head. Nate froze. He had forgotten, in his musings, that the rest of the house even existed – part of it had been turned into a storage and garage area, a cement addition leaning up against an area that must have been a living room. But upstairs, of course, still existed. And it wasn't a garage.

Footsteps, one set, light, hurried across the floor. Nate swiveled in the chair, rising up as the footsteps descended the stairs, his heart pounding for no apparent reason.

“Nate?” Jo said, when he opened the door to the garage area, beyond which there was another door leading, evidently, to some stairs.

Jo had a rag in her hands and was wiping them with it. “Back already?”

Nate wondered if she seemed breathless. She was flushed, and wiped her hand over her forehead as she walked toward him, discarding the rag by tossing it aside.

“What’re you doing here?” she asked.

He was moving toward her, a single idea on his mind, to pull her close to him and smell him, because no sooner had he seen her than his fantasies had been reactivated and his cock had pulsed hard again as he

thought about sniffing her skin and smelling something amiss – the sweat of another man, cum, a deodorant that was not his or hers.

She pushed him away as he reached for her, only fueling his suspicions.

“Ugh, don’t, I’ve been up there in the dust and rat poo and you do *not* want to touch me ‘till I take a shower.”

Nate scrutinized his wife’s face. She had a smear of something that looked like soot across her forehead. Her expression was calm, either the face of a woman who really had just been cleaning up rat shit innocently, or the face of a pathological lying slut. Her shirt was soaked through, and he had gotten close enough to get the scent of her sweet sweat off her. He thought he could smell her pussy, the tangy ripeness of it, but he had also thought he could smell sex when he opened the office door.

With the vague feeling that he was losing his mind, he held up his hands. “Okay,” he said.

But he made a move toward her anyway.

Jo pushed him away. “Seriously,” she said, more aggrieved than she should be.

Or at least, that’s how it seemed to him.

“Jesus, Nate, you’re soaking wet. What the hell have you been doing?”

Jo was glowering at him, her voice almost accusatory.

“I took a walk,” Nate said. For a moment, as Jo narrowed her eyes and grimaced at him, his mind went blank.

“What are *you* doing in here?” Nate said, turning the tables on her.

Jo sighed. Nate suddenly felt like an ass, even before she started talking. “I just *told* you, cleaning,” she said. “You went on a *walk*?” she asked.

Nate shrugged. “What’s up there?” he asked, looking at the ceiling.

“An old hang-out room,” Jo said, smiling.

“Oh yeah?” Nate said, the afternoon’s secrets and fantasies and realities percolating all at once in his head. “Is that where you used to make out with all the boys?”

“*Used* to?” Jo asked.

Her voice was teasing, she even smiled. Nate was caught off-guard. He saw Jo’s eyes drop to the bulge in his pants. He was sure that she saw it,

sure that she had looked at it right after her comment, but then she wiped her head again and said, “Lord. I am *hot*. I gotta go take a shower.”

She pushed past him, and it seemed like her teasing comment had never been made, like she had never looked at his pants, like she had never done any of the things he had thought about her doing. And yet, at the same time, it felt like everything he had imagined, worried about, or suspected, *had* happened.

When Jo reached the door, Nate was sure he heard a thump upstairs.

He spun to look at his wife, but she continued out the door, as though she hadn’t heard anything.

When she reached the porch, she stepped back, looking back at him. “You coming?” she asked.

The question seemed perfectly natural. He was standing, he realized, in the semi-darkness of a doorway between a dusty office and a garage. His wife was dirty and wanted to take a shower. He was probably imagining that thump, like he imagined the smell of her cunt before, and for that matter, in the heat, he could almost believe he’d imagined seeing her on the porch with Caleb.

He knew he hadn’t.

But everything felt like a weird dream.

Jo gave him a funny look. “You got heat stroke or somethin?” she asked.

“Thought I heard something,” Nate croaked.

Jo made a face. “You need some water. Your face is all red. Come on up to the house.”

She walked out the door, without looking back. Nate listened, hearing nothing above him.

He’d seem totally crazy to Jo if he went up the stairs now. She would know that he suspected something, maybe even realize that she was caught. And though it made no sense in any intellectual way, it became clear to him as he followed his wife out of the office: he didn’t want the game to be over. Not yet.

Halfway across the driveway area, the desire to turn back and look at the office gripped him like an itch, so he did.

He thought he saw something move upstairs – a shadow, or a falling curtain. A shift.

It could have just been his imagination, he thought, turning around to see Jo still walking calmly, unconcerned by his glance backward. A floater in his eye, an outside shadow, a reflection of the light.

Deep down inside, though, he didn't really believe it. He was sure it was Caleb, pulling the curtain aside to watch them walk away, his cock still throbbing and his balls clenched in the pain of interrupted sex, Jo's pussy juices drying on his scrotum.

CHAPTER 10

Samantha moved through the house like a ghost, deftly stepping around the creaking boards of the kitchen floor, turning the back door handle slowly so it would not squeak, and throwing it open quickly for the same reason. As though not a week had passed since she was sixteen and sneaking out of her house to climb into the back seat of Hank Rowley's Chevy, parked up the road, motor running.

The night was cool even though it was June. A mist had come down from the mountains and settled into the Sayville valley, cold and brackish, smelling like a fake swamp at an amusement park. She was in a thin white cotton nightgown, one she'd dredged up from the dresser in her old room. Her nipples grew hard in the cool air and pushed against the fabric, rounded like small cherries atop her small, firm breasts. She was easily comparable to a sundae, her nipples pink and large inside of small aureole, her breasts vanilla-colored and rounded like a scoop of ice cream.

While her nipples hardened in the cool air, her pussy throbbed. There was a light on in the barn: all she had to do was walk over there, through the enclosure, ducking slightly under the stone doorway, and stand in the frame of it until he turned around.

She could already picture him in complete detail: his tawny skin, the muscles that moved beneath it, the high-strung, youthful energy in his body, power that was coming into being and not quite under control. She closed her hand unconsciously, nearly feeling the weight and heat of his sizable cock – if the shape against his jeans was anything to go by – and the near-bursting hardness that only an eighteen-year-old could achieve.

She shut the screen door – quickly, so the hinges didn't squeak, but holding it, so that it didn't slam. Her breath left her mouth in a cloud, and she saw through the window in the door, the thin lace curtains, to the light in the study cast on the steps.

A pang of guilt slapped her like the bite of cold winter air: What about Andy? Her husband of twelve years?

The bad feeling twisted inside of her, and it was enough to infuse each thing she did with tingling fear, but not enough to stop her from turning around. Not enough to keep her from stepping into her boots, taking a tool –

she grabbed it blindly, not seeing what it was, clutching it as she would if she were looking for an intruder, which was the cover story she had already invented if she got caught. Not enough guilt to keep her from stepping into the soft earth – not quite muddy, not quite dry, -her eyes fixed on the light in the barn.

This guilty fear – a fear of getting caught, more than anything, and that is the kind of fear that comes from having decided to go ahead and do something very bad – made her clutch the handle of what turned out to be a shovel so tightly her palms would hurt the next day. She didn't dare look back, because the skin on her back tingled whenever she thought of Andy. What if he were standing there by the window, watching her go?

He was bare-chested, which was just how she'd imagined it. He had a pitchfork and was pulling apart a bale of hay for the sick horse, Eloise. Inside the barn the air was hot, sweet-scented by the hay, earthy with the heated dirt. The outline of his firm legs and rounded ass pressed against his jeans, and his hard muscles rolled beneath his skin as he moved, making his skin shine when he caught the light. He was the kind of boy who worked all day in the sun, putting a shirt on only to come in for lunch like he had the other day.

When Andy had gone into town.

And she had been alone. Making sweet tea and cucumber sandwiches for a boy almost half her age so she could invite him into the house and watch him drink and eat like an animal – a Southern animal, wiping his mouth – but, like anyone who worked for a living, he ate voraciously. And she had spent her whole afternoon thinking about how she'd love for that voracious appetite to be turned on her.

He noticed her right away, but didn't look startled. He had the same smugness that all good-looking eighteen-year-old guys who win at everything they try have. "Oh. Evenin' Mrs. Brighton."

His tone was polite. He leaned on the pitchfork and lifted a foot to rest on the bottom of the metal fork, arms resting on the handle. "You coming to help me out? Cuz' a shovel won't do you much good."

In his eyes she could see that he already knew why she was there, but because he was a properly raised Sayville boy, he wasn't going to say anything so crass.

"I saw the light," she said coyly. "I thought there was a burglar."

Her voice was cloying. This was all just a song and dance, and they both knew it.

He pushed the pitchfork out to the side and jerked it from the ground, where he had stabbed it in quite deep without much effort at all. "That so?" he drawled, walking toward her.

There was no need to have the conversation that might have been most natural at that moment: why was she here, in boots and a paper-thin white nightgown, her hair down, her lips dewy-shiny with lip gloss, and most importantly, instead of her husband?

By now sweat had beaded up delicately on her own skin, and though she couldn't see it, she had started to glow on her cheeks. Her heart was fluttering in the curve of her neck, her chest rising and falling with excited breaths. She said nothing as he walked toward her, getting closer and closer but saying nothing. It was in those moments, his eyes locked on hers, his mouth in his confident grin, her lips also upturned in a smile of feigned helplessness, that they conveyed to each other what they would do in the next half hour.

The pitchfork went up against the wall, shoved there by Jake with a strong, manly push. He tilted his head slightly before reaching toward her hair, sliding his fingers beneath a single lock, and pulling it toward him as though inspecting it.

During the day his boss wore her hair in a no-nonsense twist, an import from her city ways, the one thing she had not changed out for the rural look she now wore so well. Plaid shirts, mucky jeans, cowboy boots or steel-tipped work boots, but no ponytail. Her streaked blonde hair was twisted up as though she thought she were still some kind of urban princess.

"Your hair looks good down," he said simply. It was true: her hair was blonde, straight and silky, heavy and pampered enough that the humidity could not make it sprout up in a frayed mess like so many other women's did.

And it wasn't just her hair that made her different: she didn't talk like Sayville girls, or smell like Sayville girls. And he was sure that her snatch wasn't shaved roughly like Sayville girls', with bumpy red patches and too-long hair in the center that had been hacked away by dull scissors. He knew hers was downy-white, trimmed to a landing strip, and that her skin was smooth all around. He knew because he had seen her, when she took a bath a few afternoons ago, twisting her hair up absent-mindedly while the water

dripped down her body. At the time, he hadn't been 100% sure she had done it on purpose, though who forgets that their bathroom window opens up toward the road your workers take to the fields?

But now that she was standing there, slightly damp, her lips parted and her eyes glistening with excitement, her nightgown so thin he could see right through it to her hardened nipples and the white skin in her groin that was not covered by underwear – now, he was sure she had done it on purpose.

His cock was hard, just from touching her hair. He was too cocky, too young, to think about something like endurance. And now, his thoughts were narrowing down to the most limited, and the most feral.

He let his fingers drop to her collarbone. She didn't tremble, or back away. Her gaze was steady, and the expression he'd almost been afraid of when she had met him for the first time was on it.

The expression of a woman who wants what she wants.

She stepped past him, avoiding a pile of dung while somehow managing to look sexy as she did it, even in her mucky boots.

"You ever been inside the garage?" she asked him, slipping into the semi darkness, her hand on Eloise's damp head for just a moment. The horse snorted, and Samantha swung her hips slightly, past the paddock, to the door that led to the back of the barn and the short road to the garage. "I think my daddy left some beer in the fridge."

Her accent was back, strong and Sayville through and through. Her voice was husky, had been slightly nasal without her drawl, and now came out like a smooth bourbon, all the gravel filed down to a low static at the end of her sentences.

They were in the garage within minutes, beer can cracking open, the alcohol and cold liquid only making his limbs boil more. Then they were up the stairs, inside a room that was almost pitch black, carpet under his feet, a piece of furniture that they could recline on.

It was so hot they were both slippery with sweat. Her nightgown was off, and her whole body was slick and wet. When he reached between her legs and cupped her trimmed bush it was just as smooth around her slit as he had imagined it, and for the first time in his young life he was not overly anxious to get his dick out. He wanted to keep feeling the silky smoothness of it. Her pussy juices, sweet and tangy and hanging thick in the air, oozed from between her lips and onto his fingers.

She bit lightly into his lower lip, which made him realize she had her mouth on his. Her hands were on his chest, squeezing his muscles. He felt her tongue over his pecs, making a circle around his nipples.

It was her hand that got him out of his jeans, her hands that pulled him to her pussy and sank his crown into her wetness. With one hand on his chest, twisting his nipple, she held him in place while she moved his cock against the hard nub of her clit.

He strained his eyes to see her, but it was dim and he saw only gray and silver edges of her body – the rest he had to fill in. She was using his cock to masturbate herself, and his precum was boiling out of the tip, he could feel it. He could hear her moans, feel her hot pussy, and could hardly stand to let her finish before he sank into her, but she had control of him, and he had never experienced anything like it.

When she came, her pussy overflowed, and then she pulled him inside of her. She grabbed him by the shoulders and her hot cunt enveloped him, all the way to his balls. She was tighter, wetter, hotter than he had imagined. And as her legs wrapped around his and she ground up against him and then refused to move except for so very slightly, her lips against his ear, her throaty voice purring: “you’re going to make me come again before you fill my pussy up,” he was stunned enough by the novelty of it that he managed not to come right away.

She held him in place and ground her pelvis against his, her pussy squeezing him, her ankle against his lower back, pinning his hips to hers so he couldn’t move. Her body was so wet and slippery against his skin that he felt like she was another kind of animal entirely.

At last she released him, and spread her legs spread wide, digging her nails into his shoulder and slapping him on the ass. “Fuck me hard!” she said breathlessly.

And so he did. And when he came it made his forehead hurt and he clenched his jaw so hard he wasn’t sure if he had broken a tooth or not.

He rose onto his knees, her legs still sprawled around his waist. The clouds veiling the moon disappeared, and her body started to glow white. He watched his hand moving over her wet, soft skin, only her nipples rough beneath his palm. Her pussy throbbed around his cock, and it was the first time he had ever felt that, because all the girls he’d been fucking had not known what they were doing, and neither had he, and he could see that now.

She pushed herself up on her elbows and kissed him. His cock flopped out of her.

“That was nice,” she said, airily. “Clean up when you leave, will you?”

CHAPTER 11

He wasn't sure what had woken him up. His first thoughts were that it was a gunshot, and it sent him sitting up straight, heart pounding, staring into the darkness.

Then, as consciousness started to seep into his brain and take over where dreams receded, it seemed to him that the sound was a door.

He looked at the clock first: 11:15. It had seemed much later.

His hand had already gone out to the side, already found that Jo's side of the bed was warm but empty. His ears were already searching for the sound of her footsteps.

It had been almost a month since the office, a month of wondering what had transpired there, if anything at all. He had written a story about it, the way he would have had it transpire, and he had spent many a night next to Jo, his cock getting hard as he thought about his fantasy as if it were real. He had thought of his fantasies until they seemed just as real as the things he had seen seemed fantastical, until he could only think of the bitter taste of cum that had been in his wife's mouth when she kissed him (it had not, he knew, but it seemed as though it had) or the feel of her sloshy pussy when he entered her and she was full of Caleb's cum (this had never happened, he knew, but he imagined it so viscerally, describing it in his writing so thoroughly, that he almost believed that it had).

So now, woken by what he now thought was a door slamming, staring into the dark, his wife missing, he did not know what to make of reality. Maybe he was still just dreaming.

But he wasn't. Dreams did not have clocks that changed the time as they should, or that were blurry, with loyalty to his exact visual impairment. Dreams did not have moons in the right stage leering into the room, casting light on discarded clothing. In dreams, he did not think to get to the closet and put on shoes he could wear outside.

He peered into the darkness from the guest bedroom on his way downstairs. His heart soared into his throat when he saw a white nightgown moving toward the office.

A ghost. This was a dream.

But it wasn't: the ghost was yellow-haired, moved like a person...

His eyes drifted from the nightgown to the house, to a low, faint glow in the upstairs window.

His body nearly tore itself in two with the opposite feelings inside of him: the sinking, freezing feeling of despair, the electrifying hum of excitement, a sense of accomplishment and of being right, the dread of having guessed at a terrible truth, the groin-squeezing vicegrip of desire, competing for space around his nut sack with the enraging fingers of jealousy.

He stared at the dim light cast from the window of the lower floor after she disappeared inside.

And then he was walking. Down the stairs, through the kitchen, his hands on the door exactly as he had described his wife's. He dropped to the pavement, the wood creaked, and the screen slammed against the outside. *That* was the sound that had woken him.

He put the door back in place, a wind breathed as a gust swept across the yard. The night was cooler than the day, but not like the night he had described.

Something passed in front of the light in the office/house. His heart sank again, his stomach turned. His legs propelled him forward, his mind getting blanker by the second, thinking only about what was in that room upstairs, at that very moment.

Time seemed to stop as he walked across the driveway. He had slipped into a shoe from two different pairs, and one hurt his foot, but he didn't look down to fix it. The wind died to stillness once he was in the middle of the buildings, stables and barn on one side, houses opposite each other, a pile of hay bales blocking the rest. Light poured down from the full moon directly overhead, giving the entire place the artificial appearance of a movie set.

He crept through the office, ears perked for all noises. He had nothing in his hands, no excuse to be there, and for a horrifying moment he pictured himself getting caught: standing there in a t-shirt and ratty shorts, his mouth hanging open, his eyes rimmed red with anger, disbelief – no excuse on his lips or object in his hand to defend himself from Caleb and Jo seeing him for what he was: the sort of man who crept through a dark house to catch his cheating wife without getting caught. A cuckold.

A willing cuckold.

He had never been upstairs, as absurd as it seemed. He had pictured it as an unfinished attic, stacked with boxes of papers, and it was only because Jo had described it to him as something else that he had written it into his story differently. When he reached the top of the stairs and peered into the darkness he found it was neither. It was the top floor of an old farmhouse: peeling wallpaper, chipped doors, a floor made of thick wood boards warped by hundreds of wet summers. Four small rooms squared off a small landing.

A single door – the door behind which the light glowed, and the panting of two humans could be heard, the door from behind which all the squeaks and the creaks were coming – had been left open. He felt almost as though he were following a trail of breadcrumbs as he crept toward it: Jo's nightgown, the ghostly white of it gray in the darkness, was on the floor. Her moans were enticing, not stifled at all: he heard the sharp whisper of a male voice as Caleb tried to keep her quieter.

The floor creaked but they didn't hear it: Nate could tell by the way they went on, uninterrupted. Jo's moans were too loud, and they were almost certainly right next to Caleb's ear. And a guy who was only twenty, with his cock balls-deep in another man's hot wife, was hardly going to hear a small creak in the floor.

The door had been left open almost as if they had *wanted* him to stand there in the darkness of the hallway without being seen and peer into the room. The angle was almost perfect; like the light of the courtyard it almost seemed staged. He couldn't see it all, but he could see enough.

His wife was utterly naked, and her skin was wet with sweat and the shine of it shifted as she moved. Reflecting patches, white where they caught the light, moved like a caress over her sinewy muscles, in the muscle line of her thigh, between her breasts, into her collarbone, over her cheek and onto her forehead when she tilted it up at the ceiling to moan again. Her blonde hair was light brown close to her head, damp from her exertions, strands of it clinging to her shoulder, curling along the shape of her lower lip. She was too enraptured to push it away.

Her mouth was open with the kind of ghastly, zombie-like expression many people get when they fuck and forget about everything but that. Her fingers were white at the knuckles, the nails embedded in Caleb's hard flesh. She moved up and down, straddled over his folded legs. Caleb's

hands slid and slipped over her body, his fingers splayed, dipping into the crack of her ass as she rode him.

Nate could almost feel the sensation of his wife's body, slippery and wet, on his own palms as he watched. His cock throbbed as Caleb enjoyed Jo's pussy rolling over his groin, slurping up his cock and squeezing it; sloppy wet, if the sounds in the room were anything to go by.

The scent of her sex reached his nose. This is real, he thought to himself. However fake the lighting, however theatrical it all appeared, the smell of his wife's pussy gave it all the hard edge of reality. His wife was bouncing on the cock of another man, and she was loving it.

Jo's moans disappeared into hoarse whispers, almost panicked, and her stomach rippled.

Suddenly, she stopped, up on her knees, Caleb's slick, sticky cock visible to Nate, only the head enclosed in his wife's cunt.

For a moment, he turned to ice, thinking he'd been caught. She had heard him, and was about to confront him. He thought of stepping forward, throwing the first punch, but at that moment her lips moved and he heard her say:

"Not yet. I want you to keep going. Not yet."

She had twisted her hand behind her back, and when Caleb's body twitched and his mouth fell open, Nate knew why: she was squeezing him at the root of his cock. He didn't know because she had never done it to *him*, which burned. He only knew because he had read about it in a book.

Jo slowly edged back onto his cock, and Caleb's hands went to work, slipping all over her wet body. He grabbed her hips and started to pull on them, but Jo's muscles tightened and she remained steadfast, halfway down his shaft.

She shook her head, and rested her arms on his shoulders. "Nice and slow," she said. Her voice was loud, a low rumble, seductive and arousing. "I'm going to come again, and then..."

She didn't finish her sentence, but instead began to rock on his cock, slowly at first, and grinding her body against him each time he filled her pussy. Her feet twisted beneath her, and she threw back her head again as she ground herself harder. "Oh, yeah," she moaned. "Make me come one more time and then you can fill me up."

Her body seized up immediately, and Nate noticed, of all things, that her toes clenched and her foot spasmed – Jo got foot cramps when she had

wild sex – and the sight of it cut him to the core. However strange it was, *this* intimate detail bothered him.

Jo let her head tip forward, and stopped fucking Caleb, her eyelids heavy, her breath jagged.

Caleb grasped her again by the hips with one hand, his large fingers splaying over her waist and halfway across her lower back. Holding her like a prop with one hand, he dropped his other hand behind him, and rammed himself into her soaked pussy with a slosh.

He held her in place and fucked her like a rag doll someone had propped up on his lap. Jo moaned and her head tilted as she bounced on Caleb's cock. It wasn't long, but it was lewd. Caleb grabbed her with both hands and athletically rose halfway on his knees and pulled her tight into his pelvis as he shouted and filled her pussy with his cum.

He rocked back and forth with three more grunts, emptying the last spurts of his cum into Jo's cunt, and then he held her there as her head fell forward onto his shoulder. They were both breathing heavily, both exhausted.

Jo began to roll her face toward the door, pivoting on her forehead against Caleb's shoulder. When Nate stepped back, the floor creaked, and he froze again. Jo stared at the crack, and Nate's heart fell, but then she blinked slowly and lifted her head. "That was amazing," she panted.

Nate stepped back, and back again, before turning and creeping down the stairs, through the garage, into the office, and out of the building. Without looking back, blood pounding in his ears, he walked to their house, up the stairs, stripped his clothing, and lay in bed, quieting his breathing.

He didn't hear Jo until she reached the upstairs, just outside of their bedroom, maybe because of the blood pounding in his ears. He closed his eyes, and breathed slowly, but he didn't care much if the ruse was revealed. His heart was flying, and there was no way to hide his erection.

Jo was at the side of the bed. She dropped her nightgown to the floor: it was heavy when it landed, damp from her soaked-up sweat, no doubt.

The heat of her body radiated to him the moment she slipped under the sheets. He felt like he was going to burst: his heart was beating too fast, his cock was too full of blood, he was going to split open. Still, he kept his eyes closed, and then after a while he had lain there pretending to be asleep for so long that it would have seemed absurd to open his eyes suddenly. So he kept them closed.

How long would he have to lie there, he wondered? Before Jo went back to sleep, before he could rise and go to the bathroom, start a shower, jerk off? The energy coiled inside of him felt dangerous. He couldn't hear worth a damn: the dark rang around him. He thought maybe he sensed the sheets moving but he couldn't be sure, he could only feel his heart.

It was a surprise that made him lift his torso with a jump when Jo's mouth enclosed his cock almost in one, wet, hot movement. Her hand was on his abdomen to push him down almost instantly, and he stared down at the white sheet over his torso, the shape of Jo's head moving beneath it in time with the wet suction traveling along the length of his shaft.

He tugged at the sheet and it slid from her hair. He was on his elbows, watching her bob up and down on his cock, her cheeks hollowed out by the suction as she drew her mouth up to the crown of his dick. Inside the wetness of her mouth, her tongue flicked at the ridge of his cock and into his cumhole, then she was down again, all the way to his balls, her lips wet and hot saliva dripping onto his ball sack.

Jo had never given him a blowjob like this one. Of course, he had never gotten a blowjob from Jo right after watching her fuck some other guy. The orgasm boiled from the center of his abdomen, and when he felt himself tipping over the edge, he grasped her head. Her hair was damp at the neck and the tips, and he knew why, he was about to boil over into her mouth, when suddenly her mouth was gone.

His eyes, which he hadn't realized he had squeezed shut, flew open, and his blood felt like it had turned to brick the way it all stopped inside of him. The sound of his arteries was visceral in his ears: *pshuh pshuh pshuh*, and Jo's naked body was moving on top of him. He felt sick: he was going to come but only because the cascade could not be stopped, something about it was disappointing because she had stopped -

And then the weight of her body was on him, his cock sinking into her pussy as she plopped onto him and began to ride his cock. She was soaking wet, and as his strangled orgasm choked out of him, rendering him speechless with satisfaction and deep disappointment at the same time, he thought of how all the soggy wetness of her cheating cunt was a mixture of Caleb's cum and her own, to which his jolted, jilted spew would be added.

He fell back on the sheets, stiff with overstimulation, as she squeezed every last drop of cum from his cock – it felt as though her spasming, wet

cunt was sucking it from the very center of him through his balls and out his dick, into the yawning wet mess of her pussy.

She rode him long past the end of his orgasm, and the skin of his cock felt wetly raw by the time her abdomen went hard and her muscles clenched around him and then began to roll in waves with her orgasm. Her pussy juices and the mingled cum of her two lovers gushed out and down his balls, pooling at the base of his asscrack, hot and sticky. Her thighs, where his hands had come to rest, turned from stone to jell-o as she relaxed, and her weight crushed his balls.

Then her nipples were grazing his chest, sweat dripping onto him, their skin wet and slippery, as she rolled off and to the side.

He felt himself exhale as though he had stopped breathing the whole time, and perhaps he had. It was a moment before he could speak.

“What was that?”

His voice was hoarse, it cracked and stuck in his throat.

Jo didn’t answer.

He turned his head, and saw that her eyes were closed. Her mouth was slightly parted, her naked skin still shining and wet, goosebumps rising on her outer thigh and her arm as the air conditioning finally bit into the heat of her rutting body.

“Jo?” he whispered.

But he didn’t really want to wake her, did he? That’s why he moved the sheet so gingerly to cover her up, why he didn’t shake her by the shoulder, why he lay down and looked at her face instead of slapping her awake, until his eyelids grew heavy and he fell into a deeply troubled sleep.

He could tell himself one of two stories, and he did, in alternating waves, throughout the next days:

Either he was afraid to confront her, and bring an end to all of this, because he was afraid that she would tell him that she was leaving him for Caleb, or didn’t love him anymore.

Or he didn’t wake her because he sort of enjoyed what they had between them. Or whatever she had as a secret – but surely, now, she had to know that he knew?

Chapter 11

Nate wasn't able to write anything – not even his erotic stories – for days. He wasn't able to think about anything but his wife, his wife fucking Caleb, and the weird way that his fantasies had become aligned with reality. He toyed with the idea of confronting her, but could not leave the labyrinth of tormenting thoughts about why he didn't: was it because he liked it, or because he was afraid of her, or because he actually thought he was losing his mind, or because it was just easier to let it go on and not make it stop?

Was it all of these things?

And how long could he let her carry on fucking Caleb?

It was after a week of this dark thinking, of running in circles in his mind, burning red-hot at the attic window and peering out into the farm from the kitchen like a hawk hoping to catch his wife and Caleb flirting or touching, and getting nothing, that he sat down to write again.

He wrote a series of stories, each one filthier than the last, half in anger, half aroused. The words flew from his fingertips, filling pages and pages of prose, almost too dirty to publish, the whole contents of his twisted male mind pouring out in more depraved scenarios than he really wanted to imagine. Almost like he could take his revenge on his real-life cheating wife by turning her into a whore and humiliating her in the pages of a book. He wrote until the lines of reality and his fictions blurred so completely that he no longer knew what parts of his story were real and what parts of his life were story.

*

Samantha left at the same time as the other workers, because she knew Andy wouldn't notice that she was missing for hours. He would hear the cars leaving, the tires in the gravel, and think nothing of it. She often worked in the barn, or out in the fields, late. She left a note on the car, just in case. It was a silly note, a paper-thin excuse, and she knew it would not stand his scrutiny. But she didn't really care. Samantha was driven by the intoxication of Jake's youth, of returning to the real person she had been all along, but pretended not to be for her husband's sake.

“Ran to the store,” the note read. Nothing was open, and she would probably be gone for hours, but she wrote it anyway. And then she climbed into his car and left with him.

She gave him a blowjob while he drove, and he rolled to a stop in a ditch and nearly hit the Greenly’s fence. His cock was hard before she even touched him: it was nothing to fish it out from his pants after unzipping him and look at it, fat and dripping with precum, pulsing in her hand, before leaning over to take him all the way to the back of her throat.

She liked his gasp, the way the car swerved slightly. She liked that he was getting more confident, and that she was the one who had given it to him. His hand rested on her head, and then his fingers dug into her hair, and when she teased him at the crown of his cock, he pushed her down to the base, making her gag, filling her throat with his dick. Before, he had just been her pawn, and now he was dominating her.

He filled her mouth with seed as she gagged on his cock. It spurted out and dribbled onto her chin, and she licked it off as she released his cock, and then sat back in her own seat. “Jesus,” he said softly. Then he looked at her, because he always (in his Southern politeness) wanted to do something for her if she did something for him.

She leaned back against the door, bringing her finger to her mouth. “Do you know what I want?” she asked.

She had been a raging slut back in the day, but this was different. Back then, it had been more out of her control. Now, she knew what she wanted, and she was going to get it.

His eyes went wide with disbelief as she used her foot, along with her words, to stroke his cock back to hardness.

“You think you can make that happen?” she asked, at last, and all he did was swallow. By now she’d let her leg fall open – she’d put on a sundress, no underwear, and her smooth pussy had burst open from the white of her skin like an overripe fruit: red, swollen, and juicy.

“Uh...” was really all he said, but he started the car and maneuvered it out of the ditch, and they were at his friends’ house within fifteen minutes. He popped out of the truck, and maybe he told her wait there or maybe he didn’t, but he was talking to his buddy on the porch and his eyes were growing wider as he looked over at the truck and she lifted a hand to wave her fingers at him. From the expression on his face she could tell that Jake

had repeated her desires faithfully, and that chances were good, she was going to get what she wanted.

*

She was surprised that it took them as long as it did to get the real party started, but maybe it was because they were so young and she was an “older” woman. Maybe because they hadn’t ever had a woman be so direct about something so lewd.

They milled around in the living room for a while with beers. A college football game was on a TV that no one was watching, and they left in pairs to go to the kitchen, where she knew they were talking about what she’d asked Jake to tell them.

Finally, she got bored, and she started right in.

She got on her hands and knees, just in front of Ricky’s lap. His cock bulged beneath the taut pull of his jeans. Looking down at her, he had a mixture of disbelief and cockiness on his face, the kind of expression only a younger guy who is lucking out so unbelievably can have. Samantha didn’t care, in fact, she hoped he’d have the balls to take on more of the cockiness. Just like Jake. She moved her hand over the lump in his jeans, and was pleased when it twitched.

“Hmm,” she murmured. “That feels big.”

He had his hand on his zipper in an instant, and was taking it out. He put his other hand on the back of her head.

“Gets bigger, too,” he said.

She looked at him. He wasn’t as gorgeous as Jake: he had the sort of limp abdomen that would be a beer belly one day, and his face was a bland mix of thin lips, hooked nose, and dark eyes. His cock was gnarly in a way that was appealing, however, even embedded on the thick mat of black pubic hair as it was.

What he lacked in physical appeal, though, was made up for in his confidence. “How big?” she purred, but he was already pushing her toward it, forcing her to open her mouth and take him into her throat. His cock had already bumped against her soft palate before she heard him say: “You’ll just have to suck it and find out.”

Now that he was in her mouth, she could taste the salty precum that had dripped from the slit of his cock, deep in the back of her throat. She

fluttered her eyes up to look at him, and the twist of submission – sucking cock, meeting the eyes of the man who held you by your hair – ground inside of her.

“She’s not even gagging on it,” Ricky said, half to himself, and half to Jake and Chance, who were watching the scene from their respective positions in the living room.

Chance got up, coming up behind her. “That’s because she’s a fucking slut.”

Samantha continued to suck on Ricky’s cock, unbothered by the declaration behind her. If anything, it turned her on. In fact, she realized how much she wanted to be just that: a slutty, cocksucking whore who would soon be getting used by all three of these guys at once. She could feel the excitement traveling right through her and dripping down her thighs. She hoped Chance could see it, too. Her slit was soaked, and she was ready.

“Guys,” Jake said hesitantly, as she continued to suck Ricky’s cock. But he moved toward the scene, not away from it, and his protest was short lived.

“I think she’s ready to party,” Chance said. Samantha released Ricky’s cock with a wet slurp and turned behind her, where she saw that Chance was getting to his knees and unzipping his pants at the same time. His fat prick, which was far larger than either Ricky’s or Jake’s, was already engorged and ready.

She closed her hand around Ricky’s cock and stroked him, her saliva lubricating the handjob, while she smiled at Chance’s cock to let him know that she was game for exactly what he was suggesting – probably more. With her free hand she pulled up her sundress, so that he could see her bare ass, and her engorged pussy dripping down her thighs.

Just to make sure he got the message that she was ready for anything, she lay her hand over her ass and drew her pussy juices from her slit to her asshole, and smeared the sticky wetness around in a sensual circle to really underline the point.

Chance’s eyes went wide, and for a moment he looked as stunned as Ricky had. But only for a moment. His lips turned up in a smirk, and he smiled cruelly. Samantha’s abdomen lurched with excitement: hopefully, he would dominate her properly.

“You into that?” Chance asked her. “Think you can handle my cock?”

He had his prick in his hand, and once she could see the girth of it in comparison to his grip, she realized it was probably the fattest cock she had ever taken. Not the longest, but it was thick. And she'd seen a lot of cock in the past.

She licked her lips. "It's so big," she said. "And I haven't had it in my ass for such a long time. I might need one of you -" she fluttered her eyes from Jake's approaching shadow, to Ricky's gaping face, "to break me in."

Ricky's cock pulsed so hard in her hand that she almost lost control of it. She smiled at him and took him slowly back into her mouth. While she did this, Chance pressed the head of his cock to her dripping slit. He drew the fat bulb through her gushing inner flesh, and then pressed it against the face of her clit. He felt so fat that he might even stretch her going into her cunt, even when she was this wet and ready to get fucked.

She traveled back to the crown of Ricky's cock so she could free her mouth to talk. "You ever fucked a girl in the ass?" she asked him.

Ricky was too stunned to lie or to admit that he hadn't, she could see, so she took care of the problem for him by standing up abruptly. She pulled her dress over her head as she did, so that she was stark naked except for her boots. It was a spectacular sight: her hair fell loose around her shoulders, her legs were long and lean and even more sculpted with the boots. Her breasts, almost as firm as they had been in high school, were upturned and her pink nipples had formed tantalizing pebbles. Between her legs, her bare muff glistened, and a smear of her excitement shone on her inner thigh. Behind her, Chance stared at her high, rounded ass and reached forward, almost involuntarily, to creep his hand up her leg.

She turned to face Chance, and saw that Jake was standing, his pants down, his cock in his hand, staring at her as though he was seeing an erotic ghost.

"I don't think I've ever had a cock that big in my mouth," she told Chance, looking down at his fat prick, the crown of it wet with her juices. She stepped backward, and, one leg at a time, she climbed over Ricky's lap, raised up on her knees. Her ass was in his face, and he grabbed her hips and pulled her toward him. She pushed her hair up as she turned to Ricky. "Why don't you get your cock wet in my pussy first, and then I'll slide right down on you and you can blow my ass full of cum?"

Ricky stared at her, so she went ahead and reached between her legs to grab his dick and slip it into the folds of her pussy, lowering herself

slowly onto his throbbing shaft. "Don't come yet," she said breathlessly. "I need all that cum in my ass," she turned toward Chance, "so I can get this big dick in there."

She put a hand around Chance's cock and pulled him toward her.

She was pleased when he reached down for her hair and pushed her face toward him, forcing his cock between her parted lips and filling her mouth with all of his meat. He was going to be far more dominating than the other two, maybe even lead this gangbang, and she wanted someone who would take control. With just Jake, she had enjoyed her power, but now she wanted to be fucked full of cum like a rag doll.

Chance fed his cock to her, while she lowered herself to the base of Ricky's dick. Jake stared at them, his cock in his hand, so she looked over at him to let him know: there would plenty for him, in just a moment. Chance pushed his cock even deeper into her throat, and she struggled to breathe as he filled her all the way back. Her jaw ached as she opened her mouth to accommodate him fully.

"Fuck, that's so hot," Chance said, and she looked up at him. "Is that the biggest cock you've ever had in your mouth?"

She nodded, her eyes watering, and she could see that it turned him on to see her mascara begin to streak. Ricky was agitating behind her, trying to fuck her, and so she needed to deal with that. She really did need him to fill her ass up with cum if she was going to get Chance's cock in there.

But Chance wasn't ready to let her go yet: he used her hair to push and pull her along the length of his dick, while her eyes watered over and the sticky, thick saliva from deep in her throat coated his cock and dribbled out of her chin.

When he finally released her, she gasped for air, and a long strand of spit stretched out from his cock to her face, and slowly sagged, until it fell sloppily to her thighs.

"Fuck, you must have sucked a lot of cock," Chance growled. He started to push her forward.

"Wait," she said. She lifted her hips. "I have to get this cock in my ass."

She used her free hand to slide her fingers down her asscrack and to her pussy, pulling up a fingerful of her juices to lubricate her fingers. Then she pushed one finger in, then two, and finger-fucked herself while she held

firmly to Chance's cock (her hand barely grasped the full girth of it). She could feel Ricky's cock bobbing against her thighs, and his leg muscles tensed practically to rock as he struggled to wait and hold back until she let him into her ass.

Ricky's cock was thick, but it was nothing compared to Chance's. As she grasped it to aim the crown at her asshole, she marveled at how twisted it was: this was going to feel good, rub her in new places, and it was going to feel even better with someone else's cock in her cunt at the same time.

She shuddered, almost able to feel herself stretched out and full, almost able to feel the explosion of cum in her ass, hot and liquid.

She spread her legs a little wider and angled his dick at her hole. She would never do this with Andy, because it just seemed so obscene with him, but she had done it enough in the past that she knew how to relax and take the first cock of the night without it hurting too bad.

Still, there was always a little sting, and she savored it as it turned into an ache and she sank back and down onto Ricky's gnarly cock. "Oh!" she cried, because it really was touching her in places she had never felt before.

She still had Chance's cock in her hand. Once she felt nothing but the dull ass ache of cock deep inside of her, she sank further, and opened her mouth again for Chance.

He flicked her hand away from his shaft and held his dick to wipe his precum along her lips. She opened her mouth and lay her tongue out flat, and he responded exactly as she had hoped, slapping his meat on her tongue and her mouth. "You're not gonna bite me, are you, you little slut?"

She looked him in the eye and moved her whole head as she signaled "no," so that her wet tongue rolled across the underside of his cock. He slapped it against her cheek, and then the opposite side.

She ground herself against Ricky's cock, deep inside her, and let the ache in her ass roll through her as Chance pushed her head toward his pelvis and fed his cock into her throat again.

She sucked him hard, which was no easy task because of his size. She knew how to suck a cock and move her hips up and down to stroke another with her rear hole, so she went to work milking Ricky's dick, and sucking Chance off the best she could. She wanted Ricky's load in her ass, and then maybe Jake's, and she wanted Chance to spend a long time back there fucking her senseless.

Her eyes lit up when she felt Chance's cock pulsing with the first spasms of his orgasm. He clamped his hand on the back of her head and rammed himself deep into her throat. "Drink it all up, you fucking slut," he growled, just as his cum burst against the back of her throat and her mouth became a hot, salty, bitter floodplain.

"Fuck!" Ricky yelled, and she sat down hard on his lap so that his cum would get in deep, and dribble down, making a nice, hot mess for Chance's cock.

Chance let his dick flop out of her mouth, and she opened wide, tipping her head back so that he could see the glob of cum she'd saved for him. She rolled it around in the back of her throat, and then swallowed it, before turning to Ricky, who was still spluttering a few last squirts of cum into her ass. "That's it, get me nice and full of your load," she said.

"Jesus," Chance said.

She looked at Jake. "Now you," she said.

She climbed off of Ricky, and got on her hands and knees on the couch, bouncing her ass up playfully in Jake's direction, her feet draped over the armrest. She lay down, so that her head was on Ricky's lap, and put her hands on her asscheeks. Then she played with her ass, feeling along the slightly stretched rim, wondering what kind of gaping hole Ricky had given her.

Ricky's cum welled up from inside of her, and Jake stared at it. He had never seen anything so lewd in his life. Samantha's hands on her asscheeks, displaying her ass to him – fucking her in the ass?

He kicked himself out of his pants and put the head of his cock to the red eyelet. Ricky's cum was hot as he dipped into her. Her hole felt like a tight rubber band as it slid up the length of his dick, but inside her ass it was as hot, wet and silky, as anything he had ever felt. He stared down at her hands on her ass, and began to fuck her, slowly at first, and then, because she was obviously into it, he grabbed her hips and started to ram himself in and out of her sloppy ass. Cum squirted from the seal between his cock and her rim, and it didn't take long for him to add his load to Ricky's.

Ricky had gone from pushing her hair from her face and staring at Jake fucking her, to pulling her up by the hair and guiding her mouth to his dick.

He could only see her head bobbing up and down on Ricky's cock, cleaning him off from fucking her ass, getting him hard again. Jake rammed

the last three squirts of his load into her, and then stood there, with his dick still pretty hard and cum dripping out of her ass, watching her suck off Ricky.

Ricky tipped his head back on the couch and closed his eyes, then forward, to look at her. "Fuck, you fucking slut, you dirty slut, oh fuck that feels good..." he breathed.

Her arms fell down and she moved her right hand to Ricky's balls. Then Chance was next to Jake, pushing him out of the way, and his cock flopped out of her with a wet spurt.

He put the head of his cock against her hole. She released Ricky's dick from her mouth and looked behind her. The head of Chance's dick was still too big, covering up her asshole, which was stretched by then to a silver-dollar-sized gape.

She looked back at Chance. "It's so big," she repeated, her hand on Ricky's cock. "I don't know if I can take it."

She pushed up on her hands and let go of Ricky's cock, which made Ricky throw his head back on the couch in disappointment. Samantha finger-fucked her ass with two fingers for a moment, looking at Chance. "Stretch me out a little, first," she said.

Then she got back to work on Ricky's cock, because Ricky had pushed her head toward himself.

As she gagged on Ricky's cock, she moaned a little, because Chance dipped three fingers into her ass, folded at first, and then spread out. Her ass stretched tight and wide, and her feet twisted in discomfort. Pearly cum dribbled from her hole.

Chance couldn't wait any longer. Ricky threw him a frantic look when he saw that he was going to shove his dick into Samantha, while Ricky's cock was still in her mouth.

Samantha's screams – partly of pleasure, no doubt, but partly in pain as Chance stretched her further than she had ever been stretched before – were muffled by the thick cock in her mouth.

Her head went limp in Ricky's hands, allowing him to use her hair to pump her up and down on his cock until he came, while Chance fucked her slowly from behind.

As soon as Ricky lifted her head and pulled her hair back to look at her slutty, mascara-stained face, and the cum dribbling from her mouth, Chance started to fuck her hard in the ass. Her body swayed violently and

her eyes glazed over. Chance reached for her hair and grabbed it, pulling her head back even more, and riding her hard. The sound of his cock squelching in her ass filled the room.

He slowed when it was clear that he was about to come, making it last longer. "Fuck," he breathed occasionally, "that's one nice hot ass you got there. Nice and tight, at least 'til I'm done with it."

At last, he rammed into her, and his cum exploded inside of her ass. She fell to the couch and lay with her chest on it, howling, as he slammed all of it into her.

Ricky had gotten up from the couch, and Jake had come to stand next to it. His cock was ready again.

Chance pulled out of her, and stared at his handiwork: her gape was enormous now. Cum dribbled out of her ass. Then he looked at Jake, and gave her ass a slap. "Have at her," he said.

He looked at Samantha, who rose to her knees and played with her tits, smiling at him. "Where do you want to put it?" she teased him. Her hand drifted to her pussy, and she started to play with herself.

Jake rubbed his lips together, and pushed her back down on all fours. She played with herself as he slid his cock into her gaping hole and worked it deep into her ass. She slowed her fingers so that she didn't make herself come until Jake was tense behind her, and she timed it just right so that his hot cum was filling her ass again when she shuddered her way to orgasm. She sat up, and leaned back on his thighs so that she was sitting on his lap.

And that was when, her head reeling with her orgasm, she looked through the window, and saw her husband's face, staring at her.

She went cold with that hard-hitting fear like no other, of getting caught.

The feeling drained slowly as she watched his expression more carefully. She settled on Jake's lap. Someone opened a beer can and said "fuck."

She was in a dream. She lifted herself up and snatched the dress from the floor. "I gotta run," she said hastily.

Jake closed his eyes and took a deep breath. "Oh, gimme a second," he complained, thinking he'd have to take her. These Southern boys might fuck a girl in the ass in a filthy gangbang, but they would not fail to escort her home.

"I got a ride," she said, pulling her small purse over her head.

“Huh?” Jake said.

She pointed at the window. It was Jake’s turn to freeze solidly cold.

She was still reeling as she opened the door, and in the wordless silence between them as she climbed into the truck he’d hijacked from the barn. He pulled over at the whey pond, turned off the lights, and things were startlingly silent between them.

He turned to her. “That was fucking hot,” he breathed.

Her dull pain tingled away.

She opened her legs. “I’m too sore there,” she said. “But I’m all ready for you here...”

She slipped her hand down to her slit and spread her legs open, inviting him to fill her pussy with his cock, which he was more than happy to oblige.

Chapter 10

Nate blinked at the screen and rubbed his eyes, then let them drift to the whiskey glass on his desk.

Could it be that he had far more of a drinking problem than he believed?

But you write during the day, he thought to himself. Not at night, not like this.

Why was he even writing? What had compelled him to come up here, and hide in the attic, instead of going to the party at The Laughing Goat?

He stared at the story.

Had he written this story?

His vision was blurry from lack of sleep, alcohol, and the creeping sensation that he was losing his mind. The watery quality of his vision was analogous to the quality of his thoughts: distorted, in places clear, in others muddled.

There had been fevered afternoons, when he had been overheated and driven crazy by what he had just witnessed between his wife and Caleb, when he had written pages and pages of erotica. Sometimes he would look back over the writing and have to dig, very deep, to remember writing it.

But this... he would remember, wouldn't he, if he had written a gangbang scene this lewd.

He put his hand on his mouth.

It wasn't so much that it didn't appeal to him: it did, his cock was hard, he had jerked off, he was getting hard again. It wasn't that he had never had the thought – especially not after talking to Mandy – that his wife hadn't been a gangbang slut in her day, the cheerleader – fucking the whole football team at one party. It wasn't as if imagining that scenario gave him no pleasure at all.

So it was entirely *possible* that he had written this.

It just didn't seem like he had.

"Fuck," he breathed into the stale attic air. "You are really losing it."

He couldn't even explain to himself why he was here, in the attic, only the glow of the computer lighting the overstuffed space, instead of out with his wife. It was almost as if he wanted to set her up for something, as if

he had let her go to the party so that she would do... well, precisely the kind of thing he had evidently described in this scenario.

A Jack and Jill, which he had needed explained to him, was exactly the sort of party where Jo could slip up (even more than she already had). It was a mix of bachelor(ette) party and fundraiser, and it sounded like everyone in town would be there. Mandy, riding someone's cock in the office of her restaurant. The high school crowd. Probably Caleb.

So why had he said, plainly, that he was tired, and he would probably stay home and try to write? Why had he delighted when his wife had looked at him, and it seemed to him that she had almost winked, and then agreed?

He looked again at the whiskey glass. How much had he drank? How often did he drink? He didn't feel especially drunk. Disconnected from reality, unsure of what was happening, a little insane, maybe – but not drunk.

He stared out at the lines of the peach orchard, outlined in silver by the rising moon.

It all snapped together for him in a single heartbeat, and the next beat slammed against his chest so hard it seemed as if time stopped. There was a dead silence that rang in his ears, and his skin felt hot from head to toe.

Of course.

*

“Have you seen Jo?” Nate yelled, but over the roar of the music and the raucous crowd – evidently a Jack and Jill was also part biker bar brawl – Mandy couldn't hear him. Or she could, and she didn't know the answer. She shook her head.

Nate's face was hot. It was the kind of heat brought around by stress and impatience – the heat of running to catch a plane, or crunching to meet a deadline, or watching a game that you bet on as it nears sudden death, tied, all your money riding on the underdog.

He pushed through more people. “You seen Jo anywhere?” he asked every one of them in turn. He was trying to stay calm, sound casual, but the panic in his voice was causing people to look at him strangely and shake their heads.

He was halfway through the crowd- the entire Laughing Goat was filled with what had to be every single person in the entire town of Sayville

– when he realized that no one knew who “Jo” was. “You seen TJ Seymore?” he asked the next person he saw.

Recognition flowed through the features of the guy’s face. He looked here and there, standing on tiptoe to see over the crowd, but shook his head in the end. The girl he was dancing with did the same.

“Anyone seen TJ?” he continued asking, getting the same result each time, until he reached the back of the bar and was pushed up against the kitchen door with nowhere else to look and no one else to ask.

It was his fault, wasn’t it, if she had done it? He was the one who hadn’t read carefully, who had become so entangled in his fantasy that he could no longer think straight or sort his own words from reality, or from the words of someone else.

The sinking feeling of defeat began to pour over him. It was cold to his hot, and it burned as much as hot water on ice-cold hands.

Someone pushed him slightly, and the doors behind him opened and disgorged him into the kitchen.

He almost went back out, annoyed, to start his search again, when he heard a tinkling laugh behind him.

Jo’s laugh.

The scene that he saw when he turned around took several moments to materialize in his mind. He had braced for the worst, for an actual re-enactment of the lewd story he had just read. He expected to see Jo’s mouth open for someone’s cock, or her legs parted to let someone fuck her on the metal table.

But she was leaning, fully clothed, against the counter. Her long, toned arm stretched out to prop her up as she brought a beer to her lips.

She was giving him a curious look, but it was also much like the looks she’d given him this morning. There was something knowing and complicit in her expression.

Flanking her were two guys. Nate recognized them as Jay and the guy he was *sure* was named Chance.

They were all standing a little closer together than old friends might have, and the men edged a little away from her, in the slow, deliberate way one edges away from a woman you’re standing too close to when her husband shows up.

He blinked, unable to believe either the scene or his untrustworthy eyes. Who was to say that he had ever seen any of the things he thought he

had? Who was to say he wasn't seeing something right now, and that Jo was actually fucking these guys? Who was even to say that they hadn't already done just that, and were now having a beer to celebrate?

Jo's face, though, melted into a confused relief. Nate had no idea what his own face looked like, and he couldn't think of anything to say.

"Hey man," Jay said.

"What are you doing here?" Jo asked. "I thought... you were staying home."

The two guys evidently had enough brains to feel the tension in the air, and so they slid their beers toward themselves and began to walk out.

Nate watched them, sensing that he probably looked like a dog standing over its bone while other dogs walk by, not sure if he would have to growl or fight for it.

The door swung open and then closed.

Jo looked at him.

Nate had driven here in a state of such heightened adrenaline that he had not even thought of what he was going to say. Jo looked as if she expected him to say something, as if she might know what it was going to be.

"Nate," she said. "What's...?"

"I didn't read it," he blurted out. "I didn't... I hadn't read it, not until tonight."

If there was any doubt that his hypothesis had somehow been incorrect, it faded, as Jo's expression changed, but not into utter confusion. Not the kind of confusion that would have ensued if she did not know at all what he hadn't read.

Because it was clear to him now: Jo had somehow been reading his stories. Jo had even written her own scenes into his stories, like a trail of breadcrumbs for him. And like an idiot, he had simply believed his own imagination was going wild, that the lines between fantasy and reality were blurring because... because what? Because he was such an *artiste*?

In retrospect, it seemed so stupid.

But now it was definitely clear: Jo herself had written the scene that had tipped him off, so it followed that Jo had also read everything he'd written, and so Jo had only been acting out his fantasies.

She had picked up her beer, and had been tapping her nails against it with her other hand, and now she set it down. "What do you mean?" she

said quietly.

“I hadn’t read it,” Nate repeated. He sounded breathless; his chest was tight. This was it, it was really happening, and this conversation was real. He was as sure of reality as he had been in months.

Jo’s mouth dropped open. “I – what do you *mean*?”

Now, Jo seemed to be building up a head of steam. She was angry. It was an unexpected reaction.

Nate took a deep breath. What was it he should say here?

They looked at each other.

“Why did you... let me... what do you mean? Why didn’t you... *say anything*, then?” Jo continued.

Jo’s voice rose from the beginning of her sentence to the end, and now it was nearly hysterical.

“Why did you write it?” Nate demanded. “Why did you *do* it?”

Jo’s mouth gaped. “Why didn’t you read it?” And then, because Nate could see that wasn’t the real question, not really, her mind worked, and he could almost see it calculating as her eyes went back and forth, in disbelief, very rapidly. “Why didn’t you *do anything*?”

Nate stepped back. “I’m not the one who is fucking the help,” he spat venomously.

Jo gave her head a circular shake of disbelief, her eyes widening.

“But you were *there*. You saw everything. So if... why didn’t you stop me, then?!”

Nate shook from head to toe. “That’s not the point.”

Jo looked like she was about to blow, red rising from her chin and headed to the top of her head. She had never changed color like this, or become this un-poised, in Nate’s memory, and he had no idea how to handle her. She stepped forward toward him and reached for his arm, pulling him with her toward the back of the kitchen. “Get in here,” she seethed. “Before somebody comes and hears all our dirty laundry.”

They entered an office in the back and Jo held the door open for him until he walked through, and then she slammed it, barely under control. “So you mean to tell me,” she began, practically hissing.

But then she seemed to be gripped by another emotion entirely, and to regain her composure all at once, before breaking suddenly into a half sob, holding her hands up in despair, and walking to a small, broken-down love seat that seemed to have been shoved into the office direct from someone’s

trailer park living room for storage. “What do you mean, you didn’t read it,” she said desperately. Then, to no one in particular: “What have I done?”

Nate stared at her. She was actually crying, and he could not remember a moment in their life together, now that he thought about it, when Jo had actually cried. Her eyes had misted over when her mom died, and she once got a little sniffly about a movie, but this was a woman whose veneer rarely so much as cracked.

Nate himself didn’t know what to do. Now he felt terrible in a completely different way, because women crying had a terrible effect on him and made him just want to get it to stop, and Jo crying was so out of place, that he felt panicked, helpless, and desperate to get her to stop, which were none of the feelings he had come in here with. The effect made him a little ill.

“Jo,” he said, reaching for her shoulder. “I just -”

Jo interrupted: “I only did all that stuff because... because I thought, I figured... oh, I don’t know. Now I don’t even know what I was thinking. But *how* – why didn’t you *do* anything? I just figured you had read it if you were just going to play along like that. I figured I had it right, I figured it was your fantasy. And then I figured... I just assumed, you knew that it was mine, too, that you’d... read it.”

Nate stared at her. “Why didn’t you just... say something?”

Jo looked up at him. “Why didn’t you?”

What had happened, he could see now, was both of their faults. It was impossible to know, without asking her, which didn’t seem to matter right now, when Jo had first stumbled onto his writing, or how.

Without him saying anything, she offered the explanation herself.

“I just wanted to see what you were up to,” she said. “I guess... I was worried that you weren’t doing anything, that this was all a mistake. I didn’t want to nag you, or make you feel like I was bossing you around. I knew you moved here because of me, that you’d rather not stay, but if I asked you if you were doing okay, that you’d say you were. I know this place...” she sniffed, and rubbed her nose, and looked around helplessly, as if Mandy’s office and its disarray were all of Sayville “has made you... I don’t know, I can *feel* that you don’t like it. So I snuck up there. I just wanted to see what you were doing, so I’d know the truth. And then... I found all of that.”

She looked at him.

“At first I was mad. Then I had... I don’t know. It’s all so crazy. I had... all these things I wanted to keep from you, about my past. I’ve been working so hard to keep them from you, because I thought you’d lose respect for me, or hate me, or feel worse being here than you already did. So then after I read all these... stories... and I saw you’d published them -”

She looked back up at him quickly, and gave him a kind of half-smile. “I’m sorry. I really did a lot of snooping.”

He stared at her, unable to believe this was his wife.

She sniffed again. “So I saw all that, and then I thought... okay. So, if it was your fantasy, and I mean – you didn’t even change the name of the town, you know? And that guy Jake was so obviously Caleb, and so I thought... well, fine then. It was kind of my fantasy, too.”

She paused, and composed herself.

Nate’s racing mind hit a snag. “So why... why didn’t you just talk to me first? Why would you *do* all that and not have a conversation with me about -”

Jo shook her head. “I just wanted it to be like – like your stories. You know? And so I thought, okay, if I write something into your story – I mean, how was I supposed to know you didn’t re-read things, or whatever it is that happened? I wrote that stuff for *you*, I added things... I mean, what happened? How did you *not* read it?”

“Why didn’t you *tell* me?” Nate repeated.

“I thought... I thought you knew. I thought it was part of the fantasy. And it... I mean, Nate... I set it up to get caught, every time. I set things up as much as I could possibly set them up like the stories you wrote. And then I *told you* what I was planning next. I wrote it down. I thought you were in on it *with* me. That’s why... you’re here. That’s why I thought you stayed home tonight, so you could come and watch.” She folded her arms. “How could I know you hadn’t read it? You watched me and then you said nothing! I thought it was what you wanted.”

Nate’s mouth had been hanging ever-lower, ever-more-open.

She had a point.

It didn’t really matter that he had a point as well – that she should have talked to him.

“You should have talked to me,” he said blandly, out loud.

But he could also see her side of things.

He *had* written those stories. And he *had* seen her, and never tried to stop her, and now that he thought of how he had caught her, he could see that she had led him to find her each time. He had been so confused by how his stories aligned with reality, he had never even thought to imagine that she was acting the stories out. He had never thought of that possibility at all.

Which now seemed... well, stupid.

It made sense of the coincidences, the fog of reality and unreality that had been dampening his mind for months now. Why would he have been so willing to believe that he was going crazy, and not have thought of this possibility?

“Jo,” he said. “I... I don’t know what to say.”

She looked at him. “Me either.” Her eyes welled up with tears. “This was all a mistake, coming here.” Nate knew she meant Sayville. “It really put a strain on things. I knew you didn’t like who I was becoming, and I didn’t like that about you. I can’t help that this is where I’m from, that this was the way my... past was. And then, when I read those stories, I thought maybe... maybe we had found the solution.” She shuddered with a sob and looked down.

“Wait,” Nate said, crouching next to her and putting his hands on her knees. “Jo, don’t... don’t cry. Don’t feel like that. This isn’t all your fault. It isn’t even... it’s not really anyone’s *fault*. It isn’t...” Nate looked at the ceiling, trying to figure out what he wanted to say. There was so much there to discuss: he didn’t dislike her, or who she had become, or even her past. But he didn’t know how to get all of that across as quickly as possible to make her stop crying.

Almost desperately, he landed on the most important thing, it seemed: “I’m not actually *mad* about what you did,” he blurted.

Jo looked up at him, blinking away the wetness in her eyes.

He touched her face, and as he spoke he realized the truth of his words: “It *was* – it *is* my fantasy. Kind of. I mean, definitely, it is. That’s why I wrote it. That’s why I let you do it. I just... this whole scene is... it took me off-guard. I don’t know, I feel kind of stupid that I didn’t figure this out until now. I couldn’t remember writing that scene – the party scene, I mean – and it was so...”

There was a long silence, while Jo stared at the carpet.

“Too much?” Jo offered.

Nate looked at his hands. "Uh... I mean, I don't know. Maybe too much."

Jo cocked her head to the side.

Nate shrugged. "Maybe too much. Maybe I just wasn't expecting it. Maybe... I don't know." He put his hand to his forehead and laughed, letting out some of the tension. "I actually just put all of this together, you know? So I don't... really know *what* I think."

Jo raised her eyebrows. "You didn't want me to go through with it, though," she said. "I'm guessing. Since you're here."

Nate shook his head slowly. "It just surprised me, is all I can say for now."

Jo took a deep breath. She dabbed at her eyes. "It is... kind of a lot. I don't think I really would have gone through with it, anyway."

Nate cocked his head. "No?"

Jo gave a laugh, which was a relief to hear. "I thought maybe there would be something left, with those guys, you know? At first, when we first got here, there kind of was. Just the regular thing you feel about your ex, you know?"

Nate nodded, even though he really didn't know. It *did* give him a thrill in his gut to hear Jo say it, though.

"And then..." she let out a sigh. "I guess, I spent so much time trying to escape the past, and here I was back in it. It was kind of like... I don't know. Starting up smoking again or something. Just habit. Something like that. But... after I flirted with these guys, I wasn't really all that into it. It's like, the thrill just died, you know?"

Nate took a deep breath. "And what about with Caleb?"

Jo looked at him. "You really didn't read *anything* did you?" She shrugged. "Caleb is... it's fun, you know? Being the one in charge, in a way, even when he thinks it's him. It's fun like, teaching him, I guess. It's sort of reliving my sexual past, but with more experience. So it's better."

Nate's cock was rock hard now, and jealousy was coursing through his veins like ice water. Jo looked at him, and for a moment there was so much heat between them the air should have warped.

He was on top of her in seconds, and he never was able to figure out how they wrangled out of their clothes. The door of the office was unlocked: vaguely he recalled someone coming in and shutting the door

quickly after seeing the animal passion that was going on inside, but that could have been his imagination, for all he knew.

They emerged almost an hour later, hair mussed, Jo's makeup worn away, their actions in the office obvious to all. Nate couldn't help but feel a little thrill when he saw Jay look at them, and a flicker of disappointment and jealousy cross the other man's face.

Jo was *his*. TJ was theirs.

And that felt good.

CHAPTER 12

The upstairs of the old farmhouse seemed to have been designed for this kind of thing in particular, Of course, in reality, Andy knew it hadn't.

He had planned this day for a long time, and he knew that she had as well. He knew, for instance, that she had ordered a lingerie set from Amazon. The package had disappeared from the counter as though it had never been there, and she had burnt the box. When he asked her about it she had pretended not to know what he was talking about. But he had seen her open it and stuff the contents into the deep recesses of a chest he never opened.

When she went out to work, he had fingered the fabric in the chest. She had opened the package at some point, so he knew she must have tried them on, or at least felt them the same way that he was. The panties and the bra were made of a see-through material, silky and expensive, like silk stockings. They were laced with an intricate black embroidery, so that when they were on, her slit and her nipples would wink at the person watching her, hiding behind the thinnest of veneers. He loved to imagine how she would look in them, her breasts spilling out of the cups, her round ass on either side of the embroidered thong, her fingers sliding up and down the bra line while she teased her lover Jake.

He left in the afternoon. The claim was that he needed to go to the city to get a few legal things done for his publisher, requiring a fax and a notary, and do some shopping as well. He would be in Marietta until late.

Which left his wife with Jake all day long, in the sweltering heat, sweating until beads of water ran down the curvature of their spines and they began to think of the way their tongues would feel traveling the same path. Quitting time would be early because of the sweltering temperatures. There would be plenty of time to invite him in for a drink. Him, and a friend of his she'd hired weeks ago.

Andy would come back through the back fields, where he could reach the back stairs without anyone hearing him. There was a rarely-used bedroom, full of junk, butting up to the master bedroom, and it was there that he would hide and wait, and see, and hear everything...

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Something he hadn't thought of was the heat: the junk room, as they called it, was not serviced by the vents and was several, even dozens, of degrees warmer than the rest of the house. He left the door open until the last minute, and discovered that it creaked only when it was too late to do anything about it. They were already in the house.

He left the door partially ajar, so as not to make any further noise, and crouched in the heat, waiting, listening, his heart pounding. Any moment now, he was going to see for himself, finally, everything he had wanted to see, in full detail. Hopefully she would be too preoccupied to notice the door ajar, hopefully she would think nothing of it and continue on with her plan...

They were downstairs a long time, and their voices went from loud to soft, so it was a while before he identified the second male voice. His cock thickened when he teased it out, and then as the voices grew lower, more like growls and moans, he figured it out: she was not coming upstairs. Whatever was happening was happening down there, and if he wanted to catch her doing it, he would have to find a way to get down there without alerting them to his presence.

In the stuffy junk room, he remembered, there were no vents because of a hole in the floor with a decorative cover over it, so that on cold days (which happened so rarely he found it almost laughable that this house even had this feature) the heat of the old stove would have traveled up to the room. He looked at it now, and crept over, slowly, so that he wouldn't make the floor creak.

As he approached the cover, the voices got louder, and by the time he was there, he realized they were in what was now a living room – another room they rarely used. If he lifted the cover, he would be able to see down there, and maybe, just maybe, see what they were doing.

He could hear the three voices distinctly now: Caleb, whose drawl he recognized anywhere, the sound of the man who had fucked his wife so many times already cut through his groin like a weirdly pleasurable razor. And the lilting laughter of his flirtatious wife. The third voice was unknown to him, and he wondered where she had dragged this guy in from. Was he another field worker? A friend of Caleb's?

It took a long time for him to lift the metal cover, and sweat was running down the sides of his face by the time he set it carefully next to the hole and could lean into the darkness to look down into the room below.

He had a view of the back of his wife's head, her neck and her shoulders, and the fact that she was no longer wearing a shirt – just the straps the lacy black bra against her skin. One of them was loose, falling down over her right shoulder. She was talking in a low voice, and the male voice he didn't recognize interrupted her.

And then the man – dark-haired, as young as Caleb – was just in front of her shoulders. Suddenly his voice was crystal-clear. “Oh, yeah?” he said.

“Never,” his wife said, running her finger along the taut black strap of her bra. Her voice was teasing, sexual – and really, there was very little to interpret of what was going on here.

“There's a first time for everything, then,” the dark-haired man growled.

He buried his head where Jo's chest would be, and her head tipped back as she enjoyed him sucking on her nipples.

Nate strained to see them, his cock throbbing and his neck aching from the odd angle he had to put his head at to see anything at all. Sweat dripped silently onto the wood next to his temple, and he edged himself back and forth in an attempt to get more of the picture in view, but it was always, disappointingly, unclear. He could only see Jo's hair, the back of the dark man, and the back of the couch blocked out the rest, the scene he really wanted to see.

Jo whimpered, and gasped, and Nate's blood boiled.

But he was soon a little more satisfied, as the tanned and muscled body of Caleb, his cock making a firm tent in his boxers, passed into the picture. He climbed into the vision, kneeling next to Jo on the couch, and Nate had a good view of his hand as he slid it into Jo's hair to turn her head toward him.

He could see Caleb's other hand fisted around his cock, but the view was blocked by the back of Jo's head and Caleb's hand firmly cradling it like a football. It was then that Jo's feet swung up to the back of the couch, held at the ankles by one of the dark man's hands. He pushed her ankles next to her right ear, while Nate experienced vertigo trying to imagine the contorted position she was in, with her legs off to the side and her head bent over to bob up and down on Caleb's cock.

Her feet rocked as Caleb's dark friend fucked her, pounding her hard enough that Nate could hear the sloshing of her pussy from where he was. Caleb pushed her head up and down on his cock, and Nate burned as the scene unfolded, so near and yet so far from him, with no chance for him to see what was actually going on.

He heard a groan, and Jo's feet jerked violently a few times as the man who was fucking her thrust deep inside of her. Nate was left to imagine his cock sawing into her pussy and splurging his cum deep inside his wife. He let go of Jo's feet, and they descended slowly, almost like a deflating balloon, but she was still hard at work sucking on Caleb's cock, and now that her pussy wasn't sloshing so much, Nate could hear the squeaky sucks of her lips sliding on his shaft.

"Oh fuck," Caleb whispered loudly, and his hips thrust forward, his knuckles almost white with the force he was applying to push Jo's head into his groin. He groaned and shook as he emptied his seed into Jo's mouth.

Jo popped her head up, and gave a shake of her hair. Her hand floated to her face, and without actually seeing the gesture, Nate knew that she was wiping Caleb's cum from the corners of her mouth. The men were panting, the dark guy sitting on the floor, only his head visible to Nate, and Caleb had leaned back onto the armrest of the couch.

Nate's stomach felt cold. He had planned this for so long, and now it seemed he had missed the bulk of it. A different kind of vicious jealousy plucked at his insides.

"Well," Jo said, as though she could hear his thoughts. "I'm going to go get rinsed off. Y'all aren't leaving yet, are you? I think you two owe me one."

She stood up, and Nate glimpsed her bare ass, the panties she had so carefully chosen having been tossed aside far earlier in the game than he had expected. Her bra was still clinging to her, though he could see that it had been mangled, and was all askew. She reached behind her and unclasped it with a single snap. She dangled it over the dark man's head.

"Oh, I see," he said, the smirk evident in his voice. "You're ready for more."

"What do you think that was all about?" Jo quipped, her voice silky. "I want you to last a lot longer than that the next time around."

She dropped the bra on Black Hair's face, and sauntered off. Nate held his breath, which by now seemed as loud as a waterfall in his ears, so

that he would hear her coming toward the stairs. The familiar creak of them signaled that she was approaching, and his pulse raced again. She was going to get them up here, and his plans wouldn't go to waste.

"What a fucking *ho*," the black-haired guy said.

"What'd I tell you?" Caleb asked.

"Her pussy is so wet," Black Hair commented, in awe. "So fucking wet, and it's *waxed*. That's so hot."

"Get her to suck your cock," Caleb told him in a whisper. "She is a fucking maniac."

Black Hair rose to his feet, and Nate glimpsed his pulsing cock. It was normal-sized but stubby, coming back to life, quivering out of a nest of black hair.

"What now?" Black Hair asked.

"Give the lady what she wants," Caleb said, with a shrug.

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Upstairs, the shower turned on. She was up here, and she was naked in their shower, spinning under a stream of cool water that would make her nipples hard. He desperately wanted to see her, watch the cum streak from her pussy. He wondered if she had her fingers in her slippery-wet slit, if the cum was snaking down her thigh with the rivulets of water, a milky stream among sparkling clear rivers that were kissing her thighs.

Heavy footsteps made the stairs creak and groan, and Nate used the sounds to mask his own passage back to just behind the door of the junk room. In the end, he thought, it hadn't mattered: no one would notice this door or much of anything, not with her blowjob and wet pussy to look forward to.

The shower water turned off, and their footsteps shifted in the master bedroom.

"Oh good," he heard his wife say. "You're here. Can you get me a towel?"

"Maybe I like you all wet," Black Hair growled.

There was a soft sound of fabric falling on tile, and then no one said much of anything, but Nate could hear them moving in the bedroom.

"Caleb says you're real good at sucking cock," Nate heard Black Hair say, as Nate stepped into the hallway and made his way to the door of the

bathroom, hoping that Jo had left the opposite door, which led to the bedroom, open, hoping that from there he would get a better view of what she was doing in their bed with two guys from the darkness of the bathroom, maybe behind the curtain that served as a door to the strange closet they had been planning to replace.

“He does, does he?” Jo purred. “The only problem is, no one’s done *me* any favors yet and I’m feeling a little left out.”

Jo’s voice was uncharacteristically feminine, it almost sounded as though she were making a joke. God, she sounded like such a slut, like a woman from a porno. Nate knew it shouldn’t turn him on like it did, but he couldn’t help himself. His cock ached so badly by the time he reached the door of the bathroom that he had a hard time walking.

It seemed absurd to him as soon as he put his hand on the bathroom door. Of course he couldn’t just hide in his bathroom: someone would see him, eventually, and then what would he do?

“I have an idea,” he heard Jo say, and all his worries about getting caught dissolved in thin air. He *had* to see this. All his planning couldn’t go to waste. Not now.

His stomach felt like a twisting block of ice and his hands were shaking, but he turned the handle and slipped into the bathroom with a confidence that surprised himself. The door was open, he realized with relief: wide open. He could see right into the bedroom, where Jo was stretching out on the bed, face-up, with a feline stretch that elongated her lithe body.

Nate almost fell over backward as he tried to step back and tuck himself behind the curtain, but was nowhere near where he thought he was and his ankle caught on a magazine basket.

There was a shuffle in the bathroom, and it seemed loud, but no one in the other room seemed to notice. Not with a spectacular naked woman writhing on the bed, her breasts plump teardrops with red, inflamed nipples hardened into little balls like a cherry on top, not with her head slipping down the side of the bed, golden tresses cascading in waves.

Not when this same woman’s legs were swinging open in an athletic near-split. Caleb had climbed between her legs and was kneeling, looking down at her, his prick hard and pointing out straight in front of him. Jo had her legs – the musculature and the agility of cheerleading abundantly

evident in her graceful, slutty pose - spread wide open wide and suspended in a perfect arch with her ankles nearly up at her ears again.

Black Hair was standing in front of her face, because she had her hand around his cock. She was pulling him toward her, her mouth yawning open.

Black Hair stumbled forward a little bit, and it was obvious that he was slightly unsure of what to do. Nate was slightly unsure of what he should do, too, and Caleb was staring at them in disbelief. This, after all, was something that they could surely all recognize – it was a classic move from porn films. But none of them, Nate could tell, had ever actually *seen a* woman perform this stunt in real life.

“Now don’t be shy,” Jo purred, from her upside down perch. “Just drop down right there and get that cock in my mouth.”

A ripple traveled through the muscles of Black Hair’s back, and he was tense as he fell to his knees. Jo guided his cock to her lips, and rubbed the crown of it over her mouth, smearing her lips with his sticky precum.

The angle from the bathroom was such that Nate got a perfect view, slightly from the side and behind, as Jo guided Black Hair’s cock into her throat. The bulge of his dick pressed upward on her neck, and when he started to slide back and forth into her yawning mouth, it rolled along the length of her unblemished, creamy skin.

At the same time, her hands came up behind him, her fingernails digging into his ass to push him further and deeper into her throat. Her hair swung just above the floor as Black Hair began to fuck her mouth. He dropped one hand to her neck, and rested there, and Nate was jealous of the feel against his palm, the feel of his cock through her skin as he slowly fucked her.

At the same time, Nate heard the squelch of her pussy as Caleb entered her. He had to scoop her ass up with his two hands, his formidable farmhand biceps flexing as he tilted her up to get deep into her.

Jo’s pointed toes curled, and then she folded her legs around Caleb’s waist, crushing him into her pelvis. Nate heard her moan with her mouth full of Black Hair’s cock as Caleb ground into her. Caleb dropped a hand to her gash and began to agitate her clit in the liquid pool of her juices, the sticky motion of it resonating in the high-ceilinged room.

Black Hair fucked her mouth a few strokes, then pulled out to let her breathe, and Jo grabbed his cock and rubbed it furiously while she gasped

for air. He dove back in, gaining confidence in the maneuver, and Caleb held her hips and pummeled into her cunt.

On the second breath, she turned her head to the side and squealed. Nate saw her abdomen ripple and her hand clutch Black Hair's cock until it pulsed at the end like a squished fruit. "Oh, yes," she moaned. "I'm going to come, just like that, make me come all over your cock."

Black Hair decided not to go in while she came, letting out a wail and shuddering from head to toe. She rubbed his glistening crown over her lips and her tongue made lapping circles over his cock as she cried out in orgasm. The sloshing of her pussy got louder. "Jesus," Caleb said.

Black Hair waited until she had come, and then was back in her mouth again, his dick moving in and out as he gained his own momentum.

Jo pushed him away suddenly and unwrapped her legs from Caleb. She flipped onto her stomach by neatly helicoptering her legs, holding Black Hair's cock and rising up to her knees, forcing him to go along with her. Caleb leaned back long enough for her to rise up on her hands and knees, before he lifted himself and stuffed his cock back into her pussy with a squelch.

The black-haired guy thrust his fingers into her hair and pushed his dick into her mouth at the same time, and they began to fuck her in a train, her body ping-ponging between them, her stuffed mouth and pussy squishing and sloshing with every motion.

This seemed to go on a long time, longer than Nate would have thought they could have endured, before he saw Black Hair's muscles tense and heard his low, guttural groan as he flexed and rammed himself deep into Jo's throat, filled her mouth with his cum.

Caleb was still going strong, as Jo sucked on the length of Black Hair's shaft until the man shuddered and dropped another hand to her head to push her away, but she held strong and licked the cum off his shaft, taking him into her mouth one last time, and then released him with a pop. His dick was still hard and fell from her mouth engorged and twitching, and he made an incomprehensible sound before stepping away, his hand still in her hair, saying, "Jesus."

Jo dropped both hands to the bed and flipped her head around to look at Caleb. "That's it, don't come yet, I want you to make me come one more time before you load me up with your cum."

Caleb shuddered, and narrowed his eyes in concentration, and for a moment Nate almost felt sorry for him with such a tall order delivered in a way that probably made him almost boil over in and of itself. Jo arched her back and leaned backward, forcing Caleb to drop to his heels so she could sit on him.

Her body was covered in a wet sheen, and her lips were distended on her face, streaks of mascara, spit, and cum framing her whoreish mouth that yawned open as she ground herself onto Caleb's cock and then dropped her hand to play the folds of her abused and swollen gash. Nate could see Caleb's cock, thick and bent slightly, stuffed into her hole, throbbing with need. Her breasts bounced, her cherry-red nipples swinging in the air. Her hair clung to her face, and she closed her eyes as she made herself come, biting her lower lip and letting out a strangled cry.

She tipped forward once she was spent. Caleb threw himself into fucking his cum as deep inside her as he could, his thighs slapping against her ass, and her torso flopped onto the bed and scooted with his thrusts until he came, her head almost hanging over the edge of the bed again.

Caleb's abdomen shuddered with the final spasms of his orgasm, and Black Hair sat down, still panting, on the floor, hooking his elbows around his knees. "Jesus, lady," he said.

Jo rose up to her hands and knees, and then pushed her hair out of her face. She was smiling. Her pussy sloshed as she rose up and sat back on her heels, turning around to run her fingers through Caleb's hair.

"That was hot," she purred. "But I'm afraid I'm going to have to kick you two out before my husband gets home."

The two guys didn't move, but they exchanged a glance that revealed they were not going to stick around much longer. Jo lay back on the bed and tossed a hand up to her forehead. "Phew," she said, in her most Scarlett O'Hara voice.

Caleb brushed a strand of her hair from her face, a tender gesture, before he hopped to his feet and scooped something off the floor. "What time's he gettin' home?" he asked, shaking the material out and stepping into it. It was his underwear.

Jo shrugged. "Any minute now, so y'all better run."

"Holy shit, you are a little slut," Black Hair breathed, though in a tone more of admiration than anything else.

“Go on, now,” Jo said, but not urgently. “Scram. I don’t need any drama.”

Black Hair laughed, a little nervously, and rose to his feet. “That’s cold,” he said.

“Out,” Jo told him, waving him away. “You can see yourselves out. There’s beer in the fridge if you want one for the road.”

Black Hair looked down at her and smiled. “Yes, ma’am,”

And the two of them left, their footsteps indicating they were halfway down the stairs before they started whispering to each other.

Nate could only imagine what they were saying.

He trembled behind the curtain, his body so gripped by tension he was sure he would never be able to move.

Then, and only then, did Jo’s eyes shift from the listless gaze she’d been giving to the wall, to him. The downstairs screen door banged, and her lips turned up in a smile. “Well,” she said coyly. “That was a surprise.”

Nate walked forward in a daze, the curtain clinging to his clothes, which were soaked in sweat even though he had only a t-shirt and shorts on. His cock was pressed tight against his shorts, his ears ringing. Jo looked him up and down.

She sat up. “Too much?” she asked him. “His buddy Chris was here and one thing just led to another…”

Nate shook his head. His fingers were already unfastening the button of his shorts, and Jo’s eyes fell to his cock as he slipped his boxers down and it popped out, pulsing and pointing in front of him. She scooted toward the end of the bed, crawling on her knees, and dropped her feet over the edge, her eyes on his cock. “I guess it wasn’t too much,” she drawled.

Her hand was around his cock in a second, hot and sticky, and he felt her tongue flick at his cumhole, lapping up the latest bead of precum that had been pulsing from his slit and had stained his shorts. She looked up at him, a smile on her lips, as she swirled her tongue around his crown, and then opened her cum-stained mouth to take his prick into her soft heat.

Nate groaned and looked up at the ceiling to keep himself from erupting in her mouth right then and there, as his cock bounced against the back of her throat. He had to push the images he had just seen to the corners of his mind to keep it together as her tongue swirled over his hyper-sensitive dick, deep inside her mouth.

She treated him to a few languid passes along the length of his cock before lying back on the bed, scooting backward and stretching her hands up above her head. From between her legs came the strong scent of her pussy, a brackish vein of cum cutting through it in patches. Nate stared down at her pussy: her skin was red and a creamy glob of cum slipped from her slit between her asscheeks, onto their bed.

He climbed onto the bed on his knees, and then dropped down to her hot, sweaty body. The scent of the other men lingered on her, and just when he thought he could only smell her sex a male odor would bite into the scent. Her face was a mess, and there was a bit of dried cum clinging to her cheek.

He sank into her pussy, and the cauldron of cum overflowed around him, hot and sticky, coating his balls. She was so wet he could hardly feel it at first as he plunged in and out of her, which was a bonus, because it gave him enough time to make her moan and squirm underneath him. He was able to hold back his own orgasm until he felt her body tense and her pussy clench around him, and then he tipped his head back and burst into the milky liquid heat of her pussy.

Jo rested her head on his chest, and they were both so sweaty that her skin glided on his as though she were hydroplaning. She laughed, and gave up, settling into the crook of his shoulder. Her lips grazed his inner arm as she murmured, "I love you."

Nate lay awake, after Jo had drifted off to sleep. It was late dusk, and the darkness grew in the room in throbs. He wondered why it was that he felt so content: on the face of it, it didn't make sense. But as he lay there, with Jo wrapped in his arm, the darkness deepening until his own eyelids felt heavy, he circled around the idea until just before he fell asleep. His thoughts were groggy, disjointed, half-dreamlike, but when they coalesced together, his eyes flew open with a start and he reveled in a few seconds of understanding before he grew tired again.

He was content because Jo had wanted to give him his fantasy. His fantasy was not so much about seeing his wife with another guy – even though that was what he wanted to *see*, but it was more about the risk that it represented, the ultimate, thrilling testing of their bond. Could she do it, and then come back?

And in the end, she *had* come back to him.

The last of his fluttering thoughts made him smile just before he fell asleep: she really was a homecoming queen.

EPILOGUE

“That it?” Nate asked, pulling again on an orange tie strapped over the top of their car. “This looks like *The Grapes of Wrath*.”

Jo rolled her eyes. “It’s an Audi.”

Nate smiled. Fair point. But it was an Audi stacked high – too high, in his opinion – with junk that Jo was insisting on hauling to Washington. He knew that somewhere along the way, she’d decide she didn’t actually want it, but for now, he was content to appease her by strapping it to the roof.

“Okay,” Jo said. “I’ll just run this up to the office...and, you know. Say goodbye.”

Nate grinned. “A proper goodbye?”

Jo smiled back. “Already did that, remember? I believe you were there. Nah, just...a regular goodbye.”

Nate’s groin was agitating with heat and cold, and he sort of wished that she was going up there to say a “proper goodbye,” but he *had* already watched his wife’s last fling with Caleb Knight, in the barn, no less. And like Jo said, there was a point where you just had to let things go.

He pulled on the straps for the fiftieth time, frowning at the teetering load on top of the car. Jo walked down the dirt road to the farmhouse and the office, her golden hair bobbing in a ponytail. She was surprisingly unsentimental about leaving: it was her childhood home, and she had fought hard to rehabilitate the farm. It was now operating in the black, and she was walking away from it with little more than \$50,000, which seemed like an awfully small inheritance for all the work she’d put into rescuing her family’s wealth.

But she had walked through the house in a perfunctory way, looking for dirt rather than memories. She was even shedding her accent, and some of her mannerisms. She was ready to go back to the city life, with a new job in Washington. She had put on a pair of jeans from her old life: ripped strategically and fashionably. Nate admired the curve of her bottom as she walked away. She was wearing a tight, white tank top that showed off her tan and her toned arms. Overall, the farm life had been very good for her appearance.

He was a successful erotica writer now, which wasn't what he had set out to be, but he couldn't argue with his success.

He leaned against the car and looked out over the pastures. A few horses grazed on the hillside next to the peach orchard. It really was a beautiful property. Maybe they should have stayed...

But no sooner was he entertaining the idea, than he realized it was a terrible one. It was better to get out of here, better to start over somewhere else. Better to have Jo Bentley back, even if TJ Seymore had been a lot of fun.

Jo was walking back already.

"That was short," he commented, when she reached the car.

She put the keys in his hand. "You drive," she said.

They climbed into the car. "Everything okay?" he asked.

She smiled at him. "Fine. I told you. We've left on an amicable note. I think he's a little relieved, honestly, because he's always afraid he's going to get caught."

Nate smiled, turning over the engine. It amused him that Caleb was afraid of getting caught by him, not only because he already knew about everything his wife did with Caleb, but because he wasn't the kind of guy to do anything violent or drastic. Southerners, on the other hand, were big into getting out guns and waving them around. That's probably what Caleb was worried about with Nate, despite his "bein' a Yankee."

"Want anything else? You gonna take a last look around or anything?"

"Lord. Who sounds like 'Gone With The Wind' now?" Jo teased, fanning herself with a magazine. "I do declare."

Nate smiled. "Is that a 'no?'" He *had*, against his will, picked up a bit of the accent around here. It was catchy.

"Get us out of here, Rhett Butler. You're terrifying me."

He started to drive.

The deal was: what happened in Sayville would stay in Sayville, and so he felt a little pang of disappointment as they left it behind. At the same time, there was a discomfort in their life here that he was getting tired of. He didn't mind getting back to being more like the people they were before they came here.

"Wait, wait, wait," Jo said, putting her hand out as he started to turn left on the road.

His heart took the same kind of exhilarating and awful plunge that it did so frequently when she slept with Caleb, or flirted with other men – for him, of course, but still. What if she had decided to stay? To go back, right here at the end of the road?

“Turn right,” Jo said, pointing in that direction.

Nate’s heart slammed against his chest. “Huh?”

“I’m sorry,” Jo said, and his adrenaline rose again. She was being dead serious, and she actually looked like she was sorry. “I changed my mind. It’s just...”

The pause between this word and the rest of her sentence was, in reality, probably less than a second, but it felt like an eternity to Nate.

“...I know I made you put all that stuff up there, but I don’t really want it. Let’s take it to the dump.”

Nate was pale and staring at her.

She shook her head, and made a face. “Come on, it’s just up the road, by Dawson’s.”

She settled back in her seat. “I’m sorry,” she repeated.

Nate turned the car, relief flooding his veins, and smiled, as he drove to the dump.

They’d be heading up to Washington, free of any baggage.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Hannah Gets Hot

When Hannah has a chance encounter with a younger man on a plane, Twitter goes crazy for their "budding romance." Her husband Mike sees an opportunity to seize on his long-hidden fantasies. While Hannah is attracted to the hot, young guy from the plane, she's far too loyal to her husband to have an affair... at first. This is a slow-burning story of wife-sharing for the first time, with a scorching finale.

Working On Her Game

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn't long before the couple discover that Scarlett's new instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

Game For More

Scarlett and Will are not finished with the adventure they began in *Working On Her Game*. Will gives his blessing to Scarlett to return to her physical relationship with her tennis instructor. At first, their sex life is re-invigorated and the affair seems to bring them closer together. But the young, Italian bull is always pushing the limits of Will's jealousy, Scarlett's comfort zone, and the strength of their marriage. Will things go too far?

Mixed Doubles

Will thought that Scarlett's affair with her tennis instructor ended months ago, but her strange behavior makes him suspect otherwise. As evidence of Scarlett's cheating mounts, Will discovers that he enjoys the thrill of Scarlett's now very illicit affair: the casual lies, the deleted texts, the sneaking around. But there is much more to Scarlett's renewed affair with Alessandro than meets Will's eyes, and she may be in way over her head. Is there any way to untangle the delicious mess Scarlett has made, while salvaging the trust in their marriage?

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a "hobby job." Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs.

Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's "hobby job" make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Laura's Dark Side

Laura and Chris have an ordinary marriage. Like most ordinary marriages, it's missing something.

They have ordinary friends, too. Or, at least they thought they did.

When Laura and Chris see firsthand that Jenna and Rob have their own solution to the marriage blahs, they have wildly different reactions – at least outwardly. But behind Laura's shock and disappointment in her friends, she's hiding a very dark secret... one she doesn't want to admit, even to herself.

Luckily for her, Jenna has a stable of dark men who know just how to unlock the needs of a woman like Laura.

Is Chris ready for the ride?

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons

to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor – the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Hotwife Suspense By Arnica Butler

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be “Clothing Optional.” They’re even more surprised to find out that “Clothing Optional” is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

Explore darker themes by Arnica Butler:

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the

angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.